



**Vikash ki Lahar,
Gaon se Sahar**



**Inauguration and Laying of Foundation Stone for
various developmental projects worth**

₹47,600 Crore

Chief Guest

Smt. Droupadi Murmu

Hon'ble President of India

in august presence of

Shri Narendra Modi

Prime Minister

Dr. Hari Babu Kambhampati
Governor, Odisha

Shri Mohan Charan Majhi
Chief Minister, Odisha

Shri Kanak Vardhan Singh Deo
Deputy Chief Minister, Odisha

Smt. Pravati Parida
Deputy Chief Minister, Odisha

Ministers of State Government

Members of Parliament

Members of Odisha Legislative Assembly

Inauguration

₹811 Crore
Road & Bridge Projects

₹530 Crore
**Strengthening of Transport
Infrastructure**

A step towards safer roads, smarter transport,
and better public services.

Other Projects worth ₹3,218 Crore

Laying of Foundation Stone

₹25,000 Crore
BCGCL Coal Gasification Project

₹17,117 Crore
**Advanced Power Infrastructure
Projects**

Increase in Direct and Indirect Employment.
Strengthening of State's Electricity Infrastructure.

Other Projects worth ₹927 Crore

Dedication of Railway Projects

• Hindol – Meramandali multi-tracking project • Jakhapura – Jajpur Keonjhar Road – Baitarani Road multi-tracking project
Strengthening of regional connectivity and boosting of economic development

20 June 2026 | 12:15 PM | Rairangpur, Mayurbhanj

ISRAEL SAYS IT TARGETED HEZBOLLAH POSITIONS, INFRASTRUCTURE IN RESPONSE TO CEASEFIRE VIOLATIONS

Israel strikes kill 47 in Lebanon; Tel Aviv says 4 soldiers dead in Hezbollah attack

Will extract ‘very heavy price’, says Netanyahu

Reuters
Jerusalem, June 19

ISRAEL AND Iran-backed Hezbollah agreed to a ceasefire on Friday, a US official said, after an escalation in hostilities in Lebanon sorely tested the US-Iranian interim deal to end the wider Middle East conflict.

A senior Israeli official and two Hezbollah sources confirmed the ceasefire to *Reuters*, which the US official said was due to begin at 4 pm. “If Hezbollah does not attack us, then for us it is not a time of war,” the Israeli official said.

Israeli forces would remain in southern Lebanon, the official added. Two Lebanese security sources said Israel carried out a dozen airstrikes in the first hour after the ceasefire came into effect, but none were recorded after 5 pm. An Israeli military official confirmed that there had been no strikes since 5 pm but denied that Israel had carried out a dozen strikes after 4 pm.

Israeli airstrikes had killed at least 47 people in Lebanon since midnight, the Lebanese health ministry reported. Israel reported four of its soldiers killed in south Lebanon in one of the deadliest Hezbollah attacks of the war.

The Israeli official said Israel had the freedom to act against emerging threats and threats to its forces and territory. Earlier, Israeli Prime Minister



Smoke billows from southern Lebanon following an Israeli strike, as seen from Marjayoun on Friday. REUTERS

Benjamin Netanyahu had vowed to “extract a very heavy price” from Hezbollah for the killing of the four soldiers.

Israeli officials have voiced anger at the US-Iran pact, saying it does not go far enough to address Israeli concerns over Iran’s nuclear programme.

Israel said it carried out strikes targeting Hezbollah operatives and infrastructure across several areas in response to repeated Hezbollah ceasefire violations.

Hezbollah denied it had violated the ceasefire, and accused Israel of repeatedly violating truce terms, including the terms of the US-Iran agreement. A statement from the group accused Israeli forces of carrying out attacks that killed civilians, destroying homes and infrastructure, and continuing its

ground incursions.

Heavy fighting overnight was concentrated in an area north of the Litani River known as Ali al-Taher hill - high ground strategically important to Hezbollah where Israeli forces had sought to advance, a senior Lebanese security source said.

Hezbollah said its fighters ambushed an Israeli force advancing near the hill, destroying three Merkava tanks with guided missiles and targeting troops with rocket and artillery fire. Hezbollah said it later attacked Israeli forces had sought to enter the area to retrieve casualties.

Israel has seized a self-declared security zone in the south, saying it aims to shield northern Israel from Hezbollah attack. Its forces have been razing villages in the south where they say Hezbollah has embedded itself.

Israel-Lebanon talks to be held in Washington next week, says US

Washington: The next round of Lebanese-Israeli talks will be held June 23–25 in Washington, the US State Department said on Friday following a call between US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Lebanese president Joseph Aoun.

Rubio “reiterated the need to disarm” Hezbollah and reaffirmed US “support for the Government of Lebanon’s efforts for a fully sovereign Lebanese state...,” spokesperson Tommy Pigott said. **REUTERS**

Vance’s defence of Iran deal rests on vague and misleading claims

Zolan Kanno-Youngs, Rebecca F Elliott, & Erica L Green
Washington, June 19

VICE PRESIDENT JD Vance on Thursday defended the preliminary deal to stop the war with Iran as a “win for the American people.” But he relied in part on a string of aspirational, vague and misleading claims about the agreement.

Vance, speaking at the White House, sought to counter criticism that the deal would reward and embolden Iran without ensuring that the US achieved the main objectives laid out by President Donald Trump at the start of the fighting.

The agreement, which reopened the Strait of Hormuz, appeared to provide some economic relief to Americans on Thursday, as oil and gas prices dropped to levels not seen since the early days of the war.

Vance highlighted the development as he continued his increasingly prominent role as a defender of the deal.

“We have all the cards,” Vance said, adding, “If they change their behavior, big things are going to happen for Iran and for the world. If they don’t, no skin off our backs.”

But he sought to divert attention from the text of the memorandum of understanding released by the two sides on Wednesday, which appeared to give Iran a number of immediate benefits.

Vance claimed that one immediate concession in the memorandum of understanding — lifting oil sanctions on Iran — was “not a new benefit” for the country. The claim ignores how the economic penalties in place before the war forced Iran to resort to desperate methods to sell oil. In the memorandum, Iran reiterated its long-standing commitment not to pursue a nuclear weapon, an assurance US and its allies have long regarded as largely meaningless.

Vance projected confidence that the final agreement would include terms upholding Trump’s goal of ensuring that Iran cannot possess nuclear weapons, and that Iran would not benefit from the changes promised in the memorandum if it does not comply with the US demands.

“They have promised not to enrich, they have promised they would allow inspectors in to destroy that highly enriched stockpile,” Vance said. “That’s why the deal contemplates a number of benefits if they do those things, but it doesn’t do anything if they don’t actually meet promises.”

Starmer under pressure after Labour rival wins key election

Associated Press
London, June 19

LABOUR’S ANDY Burnham, the current mayor of Greater Manchester, has won a special election for a seat in Parliament that puts him in a position to challenge embattled Prime Minister Keir Starmer for leadership of the country.

Burnham decisively won the seat of Makerfield in northwest England over Rob Kenyon of the anti-immigration party Reform UK.

The victory announced early Friday cements the status of

Burnham, a 56-year-old politician nicknamed the King of the North, as the top contender to replace Starmer as leader of the Labour Party and the country. Burnham won almost 55 per cent of the 45,510 votes cast for a field of more than a dozen candidates, over 9,000 more than runner-up Kenyon.

Burnham’s victory speech left no doubt that he wants to lead the country, and not just be one of the more than 400 Labour lawmakers in the 650-seat House of Commons. “Everyone knows that politics isn’t working,” he said. “Everyone can feel



Andy Burnham

that the country isn’t where it should be. Tonight could, just could, be the turning point.”

Starmer congratulated

Burnham, writing on X that voters “chose Labour’s campaign of hope and optimism over division and hate.” But he insisted he would fight attempts to oust him.

“Yes, I will run, I will stand,” if there is a Labour leadership contest, Starmer said. “I’ve said repeatedly I’m not going to walk away from that.”

Burnham has led Manchester since 2017, overseeing rapid regeneration for the city where the Industrial Revolution was forged. He is pledging to repeat his signature brand of “Manchesterism” on a

national scale.

Burnham said he would work to ensure that “the name Makerfield is forever synonymous with bringing about the change this country needs.” He said Labour had “a final chance to change” and win back voters’ trust. “But it is a chance now, from this result tonight, to build a new politics based on unity and hope, turning away from the path that takes us to a divided, dark politics of the kind we see in the United States,” he said.

Starmer’s popularity has cratered since he led the centre-

left Labour Party to a landslide election victory in July 2024.

He has struggled to deliver promised economic growth, repair tattered public services and ease the cost of living, and been hamstrung by repeated missteps, including his decision to appoint Peter Mandelson, a scandal-tarnished friend of Jeffrey Epstein, as the UK ambassador to the United States.

Labour is losing liberal voters to the growing Green Party, and facing a rising Reform UK, which consistently leads in nationwide opinion polls.

Congo Ebola outbreak worsens as deaths top 200

Associated Press
Dakar, June 19

THE EBOLA outbreak in Congo and Uganda has claimed more than 200 lives in its first month and is the worst known outbreak at this stage, with up to 35,000 suspected potential contacts, Africa’s Centres for Disease Control and Prevention said on Thursday.

With 894 confirmed cases so far, the current outbreak is three times worse than a previous outbreak in Uganda in 2000, which had 281 cases at the same point, said Dr. Wesam Mankoula, a medical epi-

demiologist at Africa CDC.

The latest number of cases is believed to be higher because the outbreak was confirmed on May 15, weeks after it was suspected to have begun. The number of cases has increased 38% since last week and is now in 32 health zones across eastern Congo, said Mankoula.

The outbreak is caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus, which has no approved vaccines or treatments and was not tested for in the early days. The more common Zaire virus, for which there is a vaccine, was responsible for most of Congo’s past 16 outbreaks of the disease.

21 protected sea turtles rescued in Bali bust, man held

Denpasar: Authorities in Indonesia’s tourist island of Bali foiled an attempt last week to illegally trade 21 protected green sea turtles, police said on Friday.

Bali police seized the live animals during a raid on the island’s Pegametan coast on June 10, after local residents reported suspected illegal turtle trading activity in the area, according to Nanang Pri Hasmojo, head of law enforcement at the force.

Police arrested a 67-year-old man identified only by his initials as KS, who is suspected of storing the protected animals before their sale. **AP**

EU leaders squabble over outreach to Moscow as Ukraine war rages on

Associated Press
Brussels, June 19

EUROPEAN UNION leaders have been unable to agree on setting up a back-channel with Moscow to ensure that the bloc’s interests are protected should progress be made in negotiations to end Russia’s war on Ukraine, some of them said on Friday.

European Council President António Costa, who chaired their two-day summit, had directed his office to reach out to the Kremlin and proposed a senior official to make contact. Costa said his aim was not to mediate or set up a paral-

lel negotiating track to the one led by the United States, which is making little progress.

Debate has been swirling around Europe in recent months about whether to appoint a mediator for talks with Russia to help get things moving again, but this has been largely rejected as many believe that Russian President Vladimir Putin would be unlikely to negotiate anyway.

Instead, the 27 EU countries have focused on concessions that Russia should make to secure peace.

Speaking to reporters, Czech Prime Minister Andrej

Babiš said the leaders had failed to resolve their differences over the approach overnight.

“Europe is unable to agree even on whether there will be negotiations or who will lead them,” he said.

Irish Prime Minister Micheál Martin said that “opening up a channel is not a mistake in our view, and I trust António Costa.”

“What was very clear last evening is that any negotiations would have to be first and foremost between Ukraine and Russia, but there are no indications that Russia is coming to the table at all,” he said.

Meloni says Trump ‘invented’ story she begged him for photo

Italy Foreign Minister cancels US trip amid row

Associated Press
Rome, June 19



“... Trump’s statements are fabricated. I am frankly stunned. I don’t know why the president of the United States behaves this way toward his own allies. After all, this isn’t the first time this has happened. But there’s one thing he must remember: Italy and I do not beg”

GIORGIA MELONI, PRIME MINISTER OF ITALY

English audio.

In her video, Meloni said she was responding to Trump’s claims because “certain things deserve an immediate response. Donald Trump’s statements are completely fabricated. I am frankly stunned,” she said. “I don’t know why the president of the US behaves this way toward his own allies. After all, this isn’t the first time this has happened.”

It was an apparent reference to an interview Trump gave to Italian daily *Corriere della Sera* in April in which he criticised Meloni’s refusal to back the US-Israel war in Iran.

• BRIEFLY

MOROCCO

Football star Hakimi to face rape trial after French court ruling



Moroccan football star Achraf Hakimi during the FIFA World Cup

A FRENCH appeals court confirmed Friday that Paris Saint-Germain and Morocco star player Achraf Hakimi will stand trial in a rape case. The defender, who is currently playing with Morocco at the World Cup, had appealed a February decision by an investigative judge. That ruling followed recommendations from public prosecutors that Hakimi should face trial. The Versailles appeals court said in a press statement that it ordered that Hakimi be formally charged with rape. **AP**

SRI LANKA

Dengue surge pushes cases past 44,000

SRI LANKA is battling the worst outbreak of mosquito-borne dengue fever in years, with more than 44,000 cases and 28 deaths recorded since January, an official said on Friday, putting public hospitals under strain. The number of dengue cases doubled from 5,651 in April to 10,638 in the first two weeks of June, data from the National Dengue Control Unit showed. **REUTERS**

JAPAN

300 evacuated after fire at Tokyo school

A FIRE broke out at an elementary school in downtown Tokyo Friday, but all of about 300 students and teachers were evacuated or rescued, officials said. The Tokyo Fire Department said the fire at the Takingawa No. 3 Elementary School broke out near a music room on the top floor of the four-story building late morning Friday. Firefighters rescued a teacher and several children out of the building. **AP**

• THE MORE THAN 2,000-YEAR-OLD DRAGON BOAT FESTIVAL IS BEST KNOWN FOR ITS SPORTING EVENTS, BUT ITS ROOTS LIE IN ANCIENT BELIEFS ABOUT HEALTH, PROTECTION AND HARMONY WITH NATURE

From river races to family rituals, an ancient festival keeps China’s traditions alive

Maria Teresa Hernandez
Beijing, June 19

DRAGON BOAT races, lion dances and other festivities marked the Dragon Boat Festival on Friday across mainland China, Hong Kong and Taiwan. The more than 2,000-year-old holiday is best known for its sporting events, but its origins are rooted in ancient beliefs about health, protection and harmony with nature.

“The fact that this holiday has been preserved for thousands of years shows how much we value our traditional customs,” said Meng Dongmei, a retired resident of Beijing’s Tongzhou district.

Meng said her family observes the holiday through a variety of traditional customs. They prepare zongzi, the sticky rice dumplings associated with the festival, and children wear five-colored bracelets believed to ward off evil.

“We also learned online about a traditional recipe using mugwort leaves, red dates, brown sugar and ginger to boil eggs,” Meng said. “We heard that it could help ward off illness and keep people healthy throughout the year, so we hope that through this festival our family will enjoy good health.”

Beijing’s 2026 celebrations will continue through the weekend at the capital’s Grand Canal.

The three-day event features men’s, women’s and mixed dragon boat races over distances of 100, 200 and 500 meters.

Teams from Beijing, Tianjin, Hebei, Shanxi and Guangdong will compete throughout the holiday weekend.

More than 1,000 athletes and 200,000 spectators are expected to gather for the event, organizers said in a press release. “The competition helped strengthen our team spirit,” said Li Maoshan, a participant in Friday’s races. “It also gave us an opportunity to demonstrate the spirit of perseverance and hard work.”

Among the cultural features



Participants on dragon boats compete during the annual Tuen Ng or Dragon Boat Festival in Hong Kong on Friday. AP

during Beijing’s Dragon Boat Festival were demonstrations of Wing Chun martial arts, a market featuring traditional handi-

crafts and a performance in which dancers mimic the movements of a lion.

Activities were intended to

highlight cultural exchanges between northern and southern China, officials said.

Friday’s lion dance was presented by a group of performers from Guangdong province in southern China. “Wherever there is a festive occasion, you’ll find dragon and lion dances,” said He Weihong, founder of the group. “Dragon boat racing and dragon-and-lion dancing are inseparable, as they are both part of our intangible cultural heritage.”

The festival’s roots run deeper than sporting competitions. It is widely associated with the ancient poet Qu Yuan, who according to legend drowned himself more than

2,000 years ago.

Tradition holds that people raced out in boats to search for him and threw rice into the river so fish would not eat his body. That story is often linked to both today’s dragon boat races and the zongzi still prepared by families across China.

“The Dragon Boat Festival is probably the richest and most diverse of all traditional Chinese festivals,” said Tsinghua University history professor Liu Xiaofeng. “Across different regions, people developed a wide variety of traditions based on ideas connected to the summer solstice and the balance of yin and yang.”

The holiday falls in the fifth

month of the traditional Chinese lunar calendar, around the time of the summer solstice. Ancient Chinese viewed this as a period when insects, poisonous creatures and disease became more prevalent, giving rise to a wide range of customs aimed at preserving health and warding off misfortune.

“At its core, the Dragon Boat Festival is about disease prevention, warding off evil and maintaining health,” Liu said.

Some people wear sachets containing medicinal herbs during the festival. Others fumigate their homes with smoke, a practice intended to prevent disease by driving out things considered harmful. **AP**



SATURDAY, JUNE 20, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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FREE RATION
for my family81+ crore people receiving
benefits every monthTODAY, THE COUNTRY HAS NEARLY
1,000 WAREHOUSES, ALMOST TWICE AS
MANY AS IN 2014**12** Saal
Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-kalyan ke**CWC**
Logistics Driving ProgressBusiness as Usual
By EP UNNYIndia Inc hopes
it is signed in
at least semi-
permanent ink**Happening
today**● **PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA**
Modi will release the 23rd
instalment of the Pradhan
Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi
Yojana from West Bengal.● **PRESIDENT DROUPADI**
Murmur will celebrate her 68th
birthday at her native place in
Odisha's Mayurbhanj district.TRACK THESE AND MORE ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**THE BIG
PICTURE****BILLA & RANGA**
A reporter's diary
PAGE 22

VANCE, IRANIANS CALL OFF SWITZERLAND MEETING

Deal under strain: Iran suspends talks after Israel attacks Lebanon

Hezbollah-Israeli
ceasefire after
intense fighting,
but Israel says its
troops will stay**Aamer Madhani, Jamey
Keaten & Samy Magdy**
Zurich, Cairo, June 19

THE AMERICAN push to quickly begin high-stakes talks with Iran hit a snag Friday, just two days after the signing of an agreement that opens a two-month window for negotiations on Tehran's nuclear programme and returning oil traffic through the Strait of Hormuz to pre-war levels.

Iranian officials did not travel as planned to Switzerland, insisting that Israeli strikes on Iranian-backed Hezbollah militants in Lebanon must stop before the talks can
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**E. EXPLAINED****Difficult talks ahead**
The discussions in Switzerland, when they do happen, are expected to focus on Iran's nuclear programme. Tehran maintains it is peaceful, though it has highly enriched uranium that could be used to build multiple atomic bombs.LNG carrier *Disha*, which was the first Indian vessel to cross the Strait of Hormuz after the US and Iran announced a deal, at Gujarat's Dahej port, Friday. Carrying Qatari LNG, the vessel had been stranded in the Persian Gulf for over three months amid the West Asia war. PTI

India's Russian oil imports at record high, set to remain core of crude diet

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 19

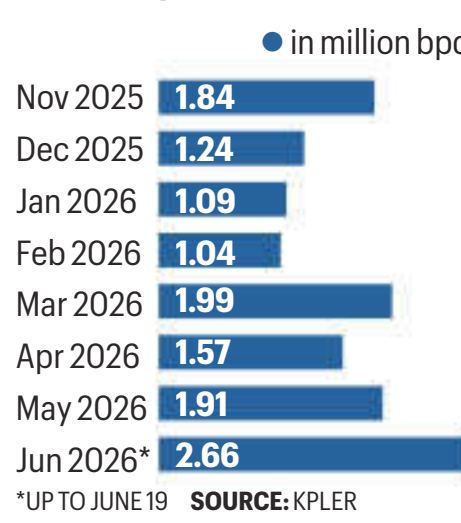
WITH INDIA stepping up its oil imports from Russia amid the loss of West Asian barrels due to supply disruption owing to the crisis in the region, crude imports from Moscow in June are expected to touch an all-time high, preliminary ship tracking data indicates.

Although the US has allowed its sanctions waiver on Russian oil purchases to lapse, at least for the time being, industry experts and insiders expect Russian crude to remain Indian refiners' mainstay in the foreseeable future.

So far in June, India's oil imports from Russia averaged at 2.6 million barrels per day (bpd), a whopping 53.5% of the

country's total crude imports for the period, as per vessel tracking data from commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

For the full month, Kpler expects Russian oil imports at over 2.35 million bpd, which would be the highest-ever. The previous monthly high was 2.2 million bpd in May 2023.

Sumit Ritolia, Manager,
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2● **Import of Russian oil
over eight months**

'LEAST RESTRICTIVE'

Delhi HC upholds Govt order blocking Telegram to secure NEET retest Sunday

Govt empowered to issue emergency blocking directions under IT Act: Court

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 19

UPHOLDING THE Centre's order directing temporary blocking of message application Telegram until June 22, ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination this Sunday, the Delhi High Court said Friday that the government is "empowered" to issue emergency blocking directions to not only individual users, but also platforms or applications like Telegram.

Dismissing Telegram's plea challenging the June 16 blocking order, Justice Tejas Karia held the government action to be proportionate and the "least

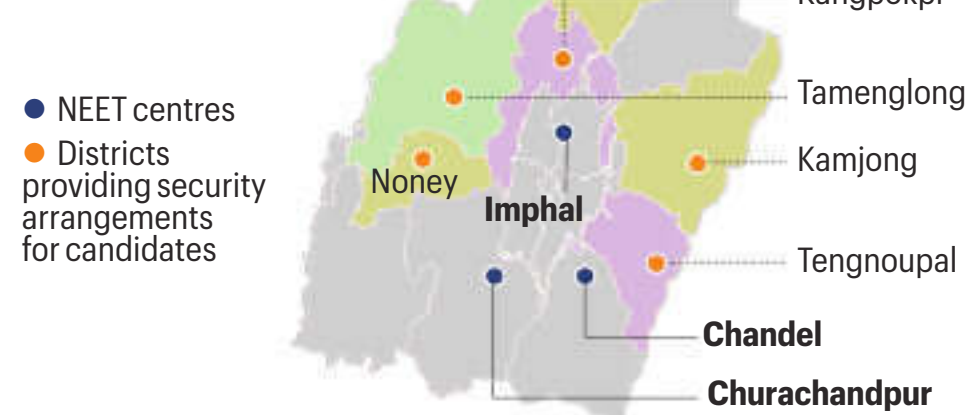
restrictive measure" for achieving the objective of potential misuse of the platform ahead of the NEET-UG retest on June 21, and preventing potential public order implications.

"The temporary blocking of Telegram under the Orders is operative only until 22.06.2026, while the disabling of the message-editing feature is confined to the period until 30.06.2026. The limited temporal scope of these measures demonstrates that they are narrowly tailored and confined to the period strictly necessary for securing the stated objective," Justice Karia said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'What if there's an ambush': Across divide, aspirants dread journey to NEET centres

In Manipur, some are being escorted to centres under security cover at night

● **NEET centres in
three towns****Sukrita Baruah**
Guwahati, June 19

MORE THAN a month ago, a 19-year-old student travelled from her home in Manipur's Kangpokpi by road, taking National Highway-2 through Senapati district, to her exam centre in Nagaland's Kohima, to write the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) on May 3.

Since then, not only has that test been cancelled following a paper leak controversy that

rocked the entire country, but her state has also seen fresh conflict, with the flaring up of tensions and hardening of faultlines making the circumstances surrounding the upcoming NEET retest significantly different.

The national-level undergraduate medical entrance exam will now be held on June 21, and the 19-year-old has had to travel days before the test to the location of her examination
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Many universities in MP, Chhattisgarh replace 'India' with 'Bharat' in degrees, marksheets

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, June 19

A NUMBER of state and central universities in some states have decided to replace the word "India" with "Bharat" in their degrees, marksheets, correspondence, invites, and signboards, among other things.

On Sunday, President Droupadi Murmu will attend a convocation of Rani Durgavati University in Madhya Pradesh's Jabalpur, a state university, where all degrees to be awarded will feature Bharat in-

stead of India.

Rani Durgavati University's Vice-Chancellor (V-C) Rajesh Kumar Verma told *The Indian Express* that the university will henceforth use Bharat on all its degrees and marksheets in Hindi as well as English. "In the G20 summit, the word Bharat was used. We are people of Bharat and the real name of the country is Bharat. The name India came later. So, our Executive Council passed a resolution to use the word Bharat in all our documentation."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'All Problem Solved': Inside Insta scam built on faith, desperation

Alok Singh
New Delhi, June 19

BY THE time she typed "Hi" on a number she found on Instagram in mid-April, the engineer had already drawn on every ounce of her emotional strength. At 22, this B.Tech graduate had found life to be unkind: she had spent months filling out job applications and attending interviews with no luck, and was getting increasingly dismayed by the rejections.

So, when she came across the faith-healing page 'All Problem Solved' while browsing Instagram, she thought she had found a solution. After all, the comments section was full of praise for how a "Moulana ji"



Accused Ganesh and Mandeep in the custody of Delhi Police

helped people overcome similar predicaments.

However, she didn't know she was about to walk into a trap that police claim was

meant for people like the 22-year-old: desperate people looking for solutions to their love, family and financial
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

POLITICS PAGE 10

**UDDHAV APPEALS
TO CADRE AS SHINDE
SAYS SENA UBT
EXODUS IS 'TRAILER'****DISQUALIFY TMC
MPs WHO DEFECTED:
ABHISHEK TO BIRLA**

NATION PAGE 14

**FIR AGAINST LALU
SON TEJ PRATAP
FOR THREATENING
PATNA FAMILY**

● PART OF AI 171'S CABIN CREW, 22-YEAR-OLD WOULD CALL UP HOME WITHOUT FAIL, AND SEVERAL TIMES A DAY IF HE WAS FLYING ANYWHERE

For family, flight attendant killed in Air India crash lives — one message at a time

Dipanita Nath
Pune, June 19**JUNE 17, 5.50 AM:** "Irfan, Islamic naya saal shuru hua hai. Moharram ka mahina"**MAY 22, 6.37 AM:** "Irfan, aaj barish ho rahi hai. Is saal garmi ke baad ki pahli baarish... maine video nahin nikali... tujhe bhejti thi na, ab kisko bhejoon..."**MAY 3, 6.14 AM:** "Janam din مبارک ہو Irfan, or aaj hi Bhaijaan ka nikah bhi hai. Dua karna sab thik ho. Ameen"**MAY 3, 8.08 PM:** "Abhi hum

raaste mein hain. Inshaallah 10-11 baje tak pahuchenge. Bhaijaan Scorpio chala raha hai, dulha bana hai or khud ki gaadi chala raha hai"

ON JUNE 12, 2025, 22-year-old Irfan Shaikh, an attendant on AI-171, was killed when the Air India Boeing 787 Dreamliner crashed in Ahmedabad, seconds after take-off.

Every few days, sometimes several times a day, Taslim Samir Shaikh sends a text to his phone number, kept activated by the family — and updates him on

what's happening with their lives.

Taslim tells him about the first rain post-summer, the start of Moharram, and his elder brother's wedding. They chose his birthday for it, she reminds Irfan, as she wishes him, so that they have something to celebrate that day.

It's something Irfan would like, believes Taslim. Not a day passed when her younger son, who moved to Mumbai after getting a job at the age of 19, did not speak to his family, says the 46-year-old.

Having done a course at Frankfinn Institute in Pune,



Irfan Shaikh's parents with the last uniform that he wore, at their home in Pimpri, Pune. ARUL HORIZON

Irfan had joined Air Vistara as cabin crew, and after Air Vistara merged with Air India, was flying to international destinations like Mauritius.

Every time he flew, Irfan would follow a routine. He would call or message when he left for his flight, then when he reached the airport, again when he had boarded, soon after landing, and finally drop a line or connect with Taslim after he reached the hotel where he was staying.

On June 12, 2025, too, Irfan called. In the taxi taking the cabin crew to the Ahmedabad airport for the Gatwick London-

bound flight, he made a two-minute video call to Taslim. The time was 10.07 am, three-and-a-half hours before the crash.

The moment they heard of the accident, the family rushed to Ahmedabad by plane, trying Irfan's phone every few minutes. It kept ringing till the evening, they say, but no one answered. "We thought Irfan may be busy. As a flight attendant, it was his duty to help rescue passengers...", says father Samir Noormohammed Shaikh, 50.

By the time they got to Civil Hospital, Ahmedabad, hopes of any survivors had been

quashed. There was eventually only one, a passenger, Vishwas Kumar.

The Shaikhs spent nine days more in Ahmedabad before they could take Irfan's body home. Sitting in the living room of the family's two-room flat in Sant Tukaram Nagar in Pimpri Chinchwad, Samir talks of an endless wait, made worse by "insensitive" officials and politicians "vying for photocopies". Every time it happened, the rescue operations were halted, he says, as Irfan's grandmother Shanubi Noormohammed Shaikh, 73, and
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Yoga session in China

Indian Ambassador to China Vikram Doraiswami takes part in a yoga session during an event held ahead of the 'International Day of Yoga' at the Indian Embassy premises, in Beijing. PTI

29-year-old Dalit man killed in UP village, protesters set house of main accused on fire

Express News Service
Lucknow, June 19

TENSION GRIPPED the Bah-hira area of Uttar Pradesh's Sant Kabir Nagar district on Friday after a 29-year-old Dalit man was allegedly killed by a man from another community a day before by slitting his throat with a sharp-edged weapon.

The incident sparked anger among residents, who staged a protest on a road with the victim's body and later set fire to the house of the main accused.

Preliminary investigation suggested the murder occurred following a dispute during a function around 10 days back, police said, adding the victim's niece had complained to him that the prime accused, Nasir Ali, harassed her during the event. Following the complaint, the victim, Anand Kumar, a resident of Kolki village, is believed to have confronted Nasir and assaulted him.

The altercation is likely to have fuelled the animosity that culminated in the fatal attack, police said.

An FIR was registered at the Bakhira police station against three persons, including Nasir Ali, in connection with Anand's murder. One of the accused has not yet been identified, it is learnt.

Police said teams have been formed to trace and arrest those involved in the killing.

On Friday, the body was handed over to the family which conducted the man's funeral rites.

Additional Director General of Police, Gorakhpur zone, Mutha Ashok Jain said the situation was under control and teams were formed to trace the accused.

Anand Kumar worked as a tile installer. He is survived by his wife and two young children, the youngest of whom is three months old.

Police said the accused's family left their homes in neighbouring villages after the incident and heavy police force was deployed in the area to prevent any escalation and ensure that no untoward incidents occur.

'Give me his body or ashes': Mother's plea in HC after murder case against Andhra cop

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, June 19

A MURDER case has been registered against a suspended inspector in connection with the disappearance of 24-year-old Gade Sai Krishna in Vijayawada.

The FIR was registered after the Andhra Pradesh High Court directed Vijayawada Police to produce Krishnalanka Circle Inspector S V Nagaraju, who was allegedly picked up by the police from Markapuram on May 9, before it by June 22 in a habeas corpus petition filed by his mother, G Vijayalakshmi.

Police sources said Krishna was picked up in connection with two arrest warrants. Krishna, who has several cases against him, had gone into hiding fearing arrest, though he had earlier appeared before police in connection with the cases, an official said.

However, after he was picked up on May 9 evening, police did not produce him before any court. His mother, Vijayalakshmi, said police repeatedly denied he was in their custody.

"I was asked to go to the Krishnalanka Police Station on May 9, where they asked me where Krishna was. They checked my phone also and let me go, and after that I did not see my son again. I went to Krishnalanka Police Station on May 11. I knew that my son was there but Inspector Nagaraju did not let me meet him. He abused me and asked me to leave. I appealed to senior police officers too but they simply brushed me off, saying that he was not in police custody," Vijayalakshmi told

remain robust, even if not at record-high levels."

India's crude import strategy has shifted sharply since March 2026 as Strait of Hormuz disruptions tightened West Asian oil flows and increased freight risks. Russian crude remains the backbone of India's import slate, while refiners have diversified aggressively toward North American and Venezuelan barrels to offset the drop in supplies from the Gulf.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Deal under strain

take place, according to three regional officials and a person familiar with the matter.

The situation was fluid as Israel and Hezbollah agreed Friday to renew their ceasefire, according to a US official and regional officials. It remains to be seen whether that could help put the US-Iran talks back on track.

In Washington, President Donald Trump lashed out once again in the midst of the intensified fighting in Lebanon and the stalled nuclear talks. "We didn't meet out of desperation, Iran did," Trump wrote in a social media post. "They are finished! We'll play out the 60 days. They get no money, not ten cents!"

Trump's vice president, JD Vance, had been prepared to make an overnight flight to meet with his Iranian counterparts at a mountainside resort in the tiny Swiss village of Ob-bürgen and begin the technical talks.

Vance's staff and a small

group of journalists had gathered at Joint Base Andrews outside Washington in anticipation of the trip. Dozens of White House officials, advance staffers and more media were already in Switzerland. Then the trip was called off — abruptly and for the time being.

A White House statement said Vance, tapped by Trump to lead the negotiations, decided to postpone his travel. It made no mention of the escalating violence in Lebanon. "The logistics of these negotiations have never been simple or predictable," the statement said.

But, according to officials, the Iranians made clear to the White House that they had balked at starting the talks with Vance because of the Israeli action in Lebanon.

The fighting had intensified with at least 18 killed by Israeli airstrikes, while four Israeli soldiers were killed in southern Lebanon, officials said.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel's

the example set by us."

Guru Ghasidas Vishwavidyalaya in Chhattisgarh's Bilaspur, a central university, has also decided to replace India with Bharat. Its V-C Alok Kumar Chakrawal said, "We have decided to use Bharat instead of India. It is yet to appear in mark-sheets but the decision has already been taken. The real name of the country is Bharat. It is foreigners who named it India. It is the belief of all intelligent people and intellectuals that we should call it Bharat."

Behind these moves is a campaign undertaken by the Shiksha Sanskriti Utthan Nyas — an organisation having close links with the RSS — which had been associated with the late Dina Nath Batra.

ML Gupta, a member of the central executive committee of the Bharatiya Bhasha Manch, a wing of the Nyas, said they have campaigned extensively to have the word India replaced with Bharat.

Gupta argues that a country or a person should not have two

military would stay in a "security zone" of southern Lebanon as long as "Israel's security needs require it."

Israel and Hezbollah are not parties to the US-Iran agreement. Iran insists Israel must withdraw from the large swath of southern Lebanon it is occupying, but the wording of the interim deal does not explicitly require that and only ensures Lebanon's "territorial integrity."

Hours before postponing his trip, Vance gave some indication of the state of flux when he told reporters at a White House briefing that he was uncertain if the talks were going to happen this weekend. "We think these technical negotiations start sometime this weekend,"

Vance said. "That's still the plan. But that could change."

Soon after Vance spoke to reporters, Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, endorsed direct negotiations with the United States. His terse statement, read by state media, appeared to signal to the Islamic Republic's leadership that it could move forward with a first round of talks.

names, adding that the real name of the country is Bharat, but it came to be known as India, a word taken from the Indus, after the British came here. "The British used the name in a derogatory sense, why should we retain it?" he asks. He says the efforts of the Nyas gradually yielded results, citing the use of the word Bharat even in English during the G20 summit as "a sign of the change of mood in the country".

Gupta has also written a book, *India Nahin Bharat*, which claims that 17 different universities and educational institutions across MP, Haryana, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat and Maharashtra have passed resolutions they would only use the word Bharat for all official purposes.

The V-C of Raja Mansingh Tomar Music and Arts University, Gwalior, Smita Sahasrabudhe, confirmed that its Executive Council also decided to replace India with Bharat in its documents as they were "convinced" by the arguments made by a Nyas delegation. "Hindi is

A-I crash

Taslim break down.

Irfan's elder brother Amir brings down a small plastic box from a shelf, holding Irfan's uniform, a stained white shirt, a waistcoat, trousers, socks and underwear, all torn. "This is the last uniform that Irfan wore," Amir says.

Every time they see the clothes, the same questions dog him, says Samir. "If Irfan's body was completely charred (as the authorities said), how is it that his clothes didn't get burnt?"

The family also asks why it took nine days for the body to be released to them. "Why didn't they conduct a DNA test and release the body immediately?" Samir says.

Praful Pansheriya, Minister of State with Independent Charge for Health, Family Welfare and Medical Education with the Gujarat government, says the authorities did everything possible to ease the pain of the families. For days following the crash, "forensic doctors did not eat, sleep, take a break", he says. "*Bhayanak shithit* (It was horrible), and they kept working to match DNA."

Now, they are striving to get Irfan's phone back. Authorities retained electronic devices found at the crash site as part of investigations. Earlier this year, Air India released 25 of these, including tablets and phones. Samir says Irfan's phone was not among the 5,000-odd personal effects Air India shared on its website for family members to identify and claim.

On February 19, he sent an email to Air India with photographs of the purchase bill of Irfan's phone and its IMEI details. They got a response from AI Personal Effects saying their

"It is obvious that the face-to-face negotiations that will be held in the future will not mean accepting the enemy's opinion," Khamenei said. The messaging seemed to give Khamenei, who was badly wounded in the US strike on February 28 that killed his father, some maneuverability.

Vance was initially expected to go to Switzerland to sign the agreement at a formal ceremony. Instead, Trump signed the document Wednesday during a glitzy dinner at the Palace of Versailles with French President Emmanuel Macron. Iran's president, Masoud Pezeshkian, separately signed the agreement.

It says Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium, which is believed to be buried under rubble left by US military strikes last year targeting Tehran's key nuclear sites, must at minimum be diluted under international supervision. It also says Iran shall not procure or develop nuclear weapons, a commitment Tehran has made previously. Other commitments remain to be worked out. — ASSOCIATED PRESS

called Rashtra Bhasha, so Bharat should be used instead of India. As soon as our old stock of mark-sheets gets over, the new mark-sheets and degrees will replace India with Bharat," she said.

In 2025, addressing Gyan Sabha, a national education conference organised by the Nyas in Kochi, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat said, "Bharat is a proper noun. It should not be translated as 'India is Bharat'. That is true. But Bharat is Bharat. That is why, while talking, writing and speaking, be it personal or public, we should keep Bharat as Bharat."

The Constitution uses both names India and Bharat for the country, leading to it being called India in English and Bharat in Hindi. In 2023, a G-20 dinner invite referred to Droupadi Murmu as President of Bharat. The Office Memorandum of the 2026 Republic Day referred to the Government as Government of India/Bharat Sarkar. The Narendra Modi government uses both Bharat and India for official purposes.

request was being reviewed and they would hear back "as soon as possible".

An Air India spokesperson told The Indian Express, "All recovered digital devices underwent mandatory screening... The (pending) cases largely relate to instances where documentation is incomplete or where families have chosen not to receive the items. We continue to work in close coordination... to bring closure to all pending cases, wherever possible."

Irfan's phone is an invaluable repository for them of his memories, the photos and videos he had, the music he loved. This is why they have kept his number active too, as well as installed a duplicate SIM in another phone. It only receives incoming calls, and sometimes Irfan's friends ring the number and they talk.

Getting Irfan's phone would also be a closure the family feels it was denied, as they were advised not to open the coffin in which Irfan's remains came home due to all the chemicals used to preserve his body. Police personnel escorted the coffin till the burial to ensure the family didn't act impulsively.

Sobs Shanubli, 73: "We could not give our child a ritual bath or see his face."

The messages are to tell Irfan that he is not forgotten. Every Friday, the family also visits the 22-year-old's grave carrying his favourite attars (perfumes). Recently, they found a handwritten note there, by a friend of Irfan's telling him he had bought a bike. "I hope in some other universe, I can give you a ride," wrote the friend.

Hope after all can't be crushed, Taslim says. Despite all that she knows, "when I don't get a reply to my messages to Irfan's number, I get upset", she says. "But, if I don't talk to my son, how will I live?"

replace quickly. Second, the Middle Eastern bottleneck around the strait will probably take months to normalise fully. Third, the Asian view of Russian crude has changed: it is now increasingly treated as a reliable base-load supply source rather than an opportunistic discounted barrel."

Moreover, the Iran deal is being seen as shaky and the market appears to be unwilling to fully write off the risks yet.

HC on Telegram ban

The High Court also took into consideration the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology's June 16 and June 18 orders that entity-specific actions, including reporting and removal of channels, groups, bots and accounts were "repeatedly found to be ineffective and inadequate".

Weighing the blocking action through the lens of whether the objective to prevent misuse of the platform outweighed the ability of 150 million users in India to access the platform for lawful purposes, Justice Karia held it to be a proportionate measure, taking into account the platform's unique architecture, which made it susceptible to platform-forming widespread dissemination of misinformation.

The temporary blocking order, issued by MeitY on June 16, and also confirmed by a review committee on June 18, was in exercise of the government's powers under the Information Technology (IT) Act section 69A and its associated Rules.

IT Act Section 69A empowers the government to block access to "information" through any "computer resource" as an emergency measure, say if sovereignty and integrity of a country is threatened.

While Telegram had argued that such power can be exercised only with respect to "specific information" and cannot be construed to imply "a blanket restriction on an entire intermediary platform", the High Court disagreed.

Justice Karia said the legislative intent was that "the expression "information" is required to be construed expansively", and thus "there is no reason to exclude an application or platform from the ambit of the said expression".

"An application or platform, in its ordinary and commonly understood sense, is a computer programme or software

designed to perform specified functions for an end user. In view of the express inclusion of "codes", "computer programmes" and "software" within the definition of "information" under Section 2(1)(v) of the IT Act, there is no reason to exclude an application or platform from the ambit of the said expression," he said.

Also relying on the definitions of "computer resource" and "computer" under the Act, he held that the same makes "it evident that information generated, transmitted, received, stored, or hosted through such software-based infrastructure falls within the ambit of Section 69A of the IT Act."

"An application or platform performs logical, arithmetic and memory functions through electronic, magnetic or optical impulses, and includes input, output, processing, storage, computer software and communication facilities connected with a computer system or computer network. Accordingly, this Court is of the view that (the government) was empowered under Section 69A of the IT Act to issue directions for blocking public access to Telegram," the High Court ruled.

It declined to interfere with the MeitY's temporary blocking order on the ground that there was application of mind while taking the decision, even though Telegram had asserted otherwise, and due process was followed.

The High Court noted that the temporary blocking order disclosed reasons why it was taking this measure: to prevent "potential grave implications for public order in the country and for preventing the commission of cognisable offences arising from circulation of examination-related misinformation and purported examination papers on Telegram, particularly in light of prior incidents relating to NEET-UG 2026."

Across the divide

centre, under the cover of night and accompanied by security personnel.

Manipur has NEET centres in three towns: in the capital, Imphal, located in the state's Meitei-majority valley; in Kuki-Zo-majority Churachandpur; and in Chandel, which has a mixed tribal population. Students from the state have also been allocated centres in neighbouring states and in Guwahati.

This time, the teenager's centre is in Churachandpur town, where Kuki-Zos like her are in the majority. But the now three-way conflict in Manipur, between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities on the one hand, and the Kuki-Zo and Naga communities on the other, has resulted in vast swathes of the state, including roads and highways, becoming potentially dangerous for members of each of the three communities.

Journey to Churachandpur

Going from Gangpokpi to Churachandpur through any route requires travelling either through Meitei- or Naga-majority areas. And so, the 19-year-old and around 20 other medical aspirants from Gangpokpi travelled on Tuesday night as part of a security convoy through the valley to Churachandpur. It was the first time since May 2023 — when the conflict started — that she entered the Imphal valley.

"It was really scary because it felt like anything could happen. It was dark when we left, and we were surrounded by security forces. But we reached safely late in the night, and I am staying at my aunt's place here till the exam," she says.

She recalls that she was already "emotionally and physically burned out" by the NEET cancellation and the process of preparing to sit for the examination again. "I am just trying to hold myself together. I feel that after going through so much, I can't give up right now. So, my friends and I are encouraging each other," she says.

Kuki Students' Organisation Gangpokpi vice-president Thangtinlen Haokip says this transportation was arranged for aspirants with the help of the district administration, police, security forces. He says another batch of students from Gangpokpi was similarly escorted to the airport in Imphal,

to travel onwards to their centres.

With the tangle of conflict, blockades, and threats, various district administrations such as those in Gangpokpi, Kamjong, Noney, Tamenglong, Tengnoupal and Senapati have announced transportation and security arrangements for the candidates and their guardians to travel for their exams.

The Tengnoupal administration announced, "In view of the prevailing law and order situation, special coordination mechanisms have been put in place with the concerned authorities to ensure the safety and security of candidates and guardians during the examination period."

'Confidence shaken'

Another medical aspirant, a 21-year-old from Naga-majority Senapati, says she is on edge, waiting to find out about the arrangements for her travel to her exam centre in Imphal. For her May 3 exam, she had made the same journey, which requires travelling through Kuki-Zo-majority Gangpokpi, without a hitch. The inflammation of conflict between the Naga and Kuki-Zo communities in the subsequent period, especially in Senapati and Gangpokpi, means that the same journey is now another source of anxiety for her.

"When the Senapati District Students' Association told us that they are coordinating military protection for us, it really unsettled me, and it has been haunting me ever since. What if there is an ambush or a bomb attack on the way? My confidence is already shaken by the exam leak and cancellation," she says.

Using almost the same language as the 19-year-old from Gangpokpi, she says that she is "emotionally and physically drained".

"We had prepared and written the exam, giving it our best — and all our hard work was for nothing. So I have already been losing confidence. This is very stressful," she says. Senapati District Students Association president Saloni Tony says there are over 80 students from their district who they are in touch with for this travel.

According to the National Testing Agency data, 9,285 students from Manipur had appeared in the May 3 NEET examination.



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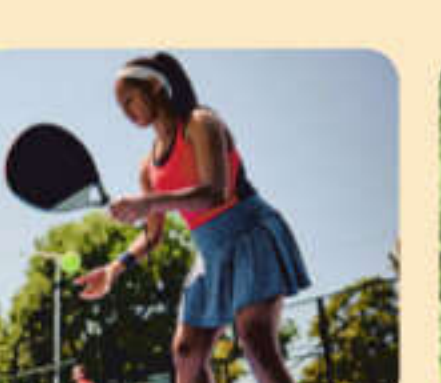
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Over 15,000 take part in Jan Kalyan Shivr

New Delhi: More than 15,000 residents visited Jan Suvidha Kendras across Delhi to obtain information about various government schemes and services, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Friday.

Gupta said that the Jan Kalyan Shivr, being organised by the Delhi government from

June 18 to 20, have received an encouraging response from residents across the Capital.

"On the first day ... a total of 15,186 citizens visited 42 Jan Suvidha Kendras across Delhi to obtain information about various government schemes and services, seek solutions to their grievances, and complete

necessary formalities," she said.

The camps are emerging as an effective means of delivering public services to every household, the chief minister said, adding: "The government is confident that a large number of citizens will continue to visit the camps over the remaining two days. PTI

WORKERS FEAR THEIR LIVELIHOODS ARE ON THE LINE

Tractors roll in and the turf is torn up: Jaipur Polo Grounds fall silent

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 19

TRACTORS HAVE been moving in. The grounds have been dug up, and poles are being erected to fence off the area: The 15.2-acre Jaipur Polo Grounds in Lutyens' Delhi is undergoing a dramatic change following the Centre's takeover on June 13.

Sources said work at the site had halted for three to four days, raising hopes among its members, several of whom are Army personnel, that the grounds might continue to be with them. However, the activity resumed after the Delhi High Court Thursday declined to grant any relief to the Indian Polo Association (IPA), which had managed the grounds.

The move has dealt a blow to the IPA and its members. The new season was to begin in August, and Delhi would have seen its first match in October.

The last match of the season was played at the ground on March 29, between Jindal Panthers and Jaipur Achievers—the finale of the Northern India Polo Championship.

It was on June 13 that officials of the Land and Development Office (L&DO), which comes under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, arrived with 150 personnel from the CRPF and Delhi Police to physically take over the premises managed by the Indian Polo Association (IPA).

The action follows an eviction order passed on May 20.

L&DO officials have since begun demarcating the property. The government had said the land is required for a 'larger public purpose', though it has not disclosed its proposed use.

Uncertainty for staff

As digging and fencing work continues, uncertainty



SAKSHI CHAND

has gripped the workers who have maintained the polo grounds for years. While the land has changed hands, those who looked after it said they have been left in the dark about what comes next.

Some of the workers have spent decades at the grounds. One has worked there for nearly five years, while others have spent 10 to 15 years maintaining the sprawling lawns. They said no official has told them whether they will be retained, shifted elsewhere or lose their jobs altogether.

"We have not been told what will happen to us. We don't know if we'll have jobs tomorrow," said a worker who has been employed at the grounds for nearly five years.

"Since the takeover last week, we have had no work and no information. All we have been told is to pick up our belongings and vacate the place".

The Jaipur Polo Grounds relies on a small workforce of around five permanent employees and nearly 10 contractual workers for its daily upkeep. The workers are employees of the Army Polo and Riding club (APRC).

Their work included mowing the grass, watering the fields, maintaining the turf, keeping the grounds clean and preparing the polo field for matches and practice sessions. According to workers, many of the ground staff earned any-



AMIT MEHRA

A notice hangs outside the gate; (top) the ground on Friday.

thing between Rs 15,000 to Rs 18,000 a month.

Workers said the biggest question remains, whether they will have a livelihood once the takeover process is complete, remains unanswered.

"Because we were employed here, we didn't have to worry about rent, electricity or water. Food and accommodation were taken care of, which made a huge difference on a salary like ours. Now, if we have to look for work elsewhere, we will have to pay for all of that ourselves," another staffer told *The Indian Express*.

"We earn only Rs 15,000-18,000 a month, what will be left after paying rent and other expenses? We have spent years working here, and now, after all this time, we don't even know if we will have a job tomorrow... Every morning, we come here hoping someone will tell us what's going to happen, but no one has any answers. In all likelihood, we will not be here in a day or two," he added.

Sujan Singh Park eviction: No breach of lease, says real estate firm

Damini Nath
New Delhi, June 19

APPEARING BEFORE the Estate Officer of the Union government's Land and Development Office (L&DO) on Friday in connection with the eviction proceedings for Sujan Singh Park North, the real estate firm that runs the prime residential and commercial complex in New Delhi challenged the Centre's notice, saying it has not breached the lease.

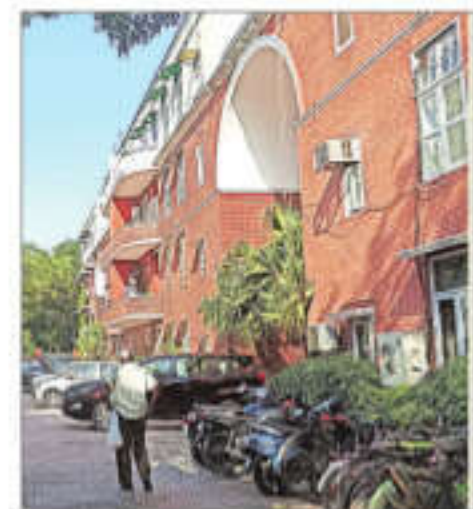
The Estate Officer had on June 11 issued an eviction notice under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971, to the real estate firm, Sir Sobha Singh and Sons Pvt. Ltd. The notice had stated the company had breached the 1945 lease and the lease had been "re-entered", or terminated, in 1960.

Since then, the notice said, the company was in unauthorised occupation of the property, which includes residential flats as well as Ambassador Hotel.

The company was asked to appear before the Estate Officer on Friday.

In the representation to the Estate Officer, the company's general manager Col S P Sharma (retired) argued that the re-entry in 1960 was "invalid and inoperative", adding that there "no breach, no valid notice, or opportunity to remedy, no permission of the Chief Commissioner, and no possession was ever taken".

Shaunak Kashyap, advocate of Sir Sobha Singh and Sons, said the government had alleged that the lease was breached by the construction of the Hotel Block and laundry block. "We led copious evidence over 108 exhibits, sanc-



The company was asked to appear before the Estate Officer on Friday. FILE

tion maps, interrogatories, evidence to establish it was built with their sanction and active participation," he said.

The firm also submitted a map sanctioned by the NDMC (New Delhi Municipal Committee) in 1951 that included the hotel block. The next hearing before the Estate Officer is scheduled on July 3.

The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) did not respond to a request by *The Indian Express* for comment on Friday's proceedings.

The British Indian government had given the 7.58-acre land on perpetual lease to the company in 1945 to construct 100 flats. During the course of World War II, the flats were to be used by the government to house military officials, after which it was to give 50% of the flats to the company, while retaining 50% for its own officials to use.

Legal disputes over breaches and payment of ground rent have been ongoing between the two for decades. On April 30, L&DO issued a demand notice seeking Rs.940 crore in payment for breach of lease conditions.



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

12 साल विश्वास के, विकास के, जनकल्याण के



जन कल्याण शिविर

सेवा, सुविधा और समाधान

18 से 20 जून 2026
सुबह 10:00 बजे से शाम 05:00 बजे तक

केंद्र सरकार एवं दिल्ली सरकार की विभिन्न जन कल्याणकारी योजनाओं की जानकारी पाएं और लाभ उठाएं

सेवाएं

- पिक कार्ड
- राशन कार्ड
- ई-श्रम कार्ड
- जन धन खाता
- लक्ष्मि विदिया योजना

- पीएम-उदय योजना
- प्रधानमंत्री स्वनिधि योजना
- आधार पंजीकरण काउंटर
- टैलेंट हंट - दौसलों की उड़ा
- राष्ट्रीय वयोश्री योजना (ALIMCO)

- गृह कर (House Tax) संबंधी सेवाएं
- सोलर पावर-प्रधानमंत्री सूर्य घर योजना
- MSME/ उद्योगों के लिए ऋण सुविधा
- "एक पेड़ माँ के नाम" अभियान हेतु पौधा वितरण
- SC/ST योजनाएं: छात्रवृत्ति, उच्च अध्ययन सहायता, जाति प्रमाणपत्र, इत्यादि

- प्रधानमंत्री मातृ वंदना योजना
- विधवा पुत्री विवाह सहायता
- LPSC - DJB के अंतर्गत जल कनेक्शन का नियमितीकरण
- विधवा एवं दिव्यांग पेंशन तथा अन्य पेंशनधारकों के अभिलेखों का अद्यतन
- 70+ आयु के वरिष्ठ नागरिकों एवं BPL कार्डधारकों के लिए आयुष्मान कार्ड

शिविर स्थलों एवं अन्य जानकारी के लिए QR स्कैन करें





Rs 350-cr fraud: Doctor held over procurement discrepancies at Delhi hospitals

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi, June 19

THE ANTI-CORRUPTION Branch (ACB) of the Delhi government has arrested a doctor in connection with a Rs 350-crore fraud case involving the procurement of medicines and medical equipment for government hospitals in the Capital.

The accused, Dr Vinod Kumar Ranga, was serving as the Head of Office of the Central Procurement Agency (CPA), the nodal agency responsible for procuring medicines and equipment for public healthcare facilities. He had been suspended after the Directorate of Vigilance conducted raids at the CPA office in May.

According to ACB sources, Dr Ranga was called for questioning at the agency's office in North Delhi on Thursday evening. The arrest was made following several hours of questioning.

According to ACB officials, the Directorate of Vigilance, GNCTD, had submitted a complaint alleging large-scale irregularities in the procurement of medicines, surgical items, consumables and medical equipment by the CPA under the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS). It was alleged that certain public servants and private individuals entered into a criminal conspiracy and manipulated procurement processes, tender conditions and technical specifications to provide undue advantage to selected firms and suppliers, causing wrongful loss to the government exchequer and gain to private parties.

Sources claimed that complaints had been received regarding the procurement of medicines and medical equipment worth more than Rs 350 crore at prices allegedly higher than prevailing market rates. Questions were also raised over the necessity of some purchases, adherence to procurement procedures and possible financial irregularities.

The case was registered on June 2 under Section 7A of the Prevention of Corruption Act and Section 61(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The ACB registered an FIR and launched a comprehensive investigation.

Amid the allegations, the Delhi government had transferred all the members of the CPA team, including the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) Dr Vatsala Aggarwal.

The allegations relate to the procurement of portable X-Ray Machines, bedsheets and linen items, C-Arm radiological equipment, anaesthesia workstations, ORS, surgical consumables and medicines at allegedly inflated rates through manipulated procurement processes. Investigators suspect that tailor-made specifications were framed to favour select suppliers, while genuine competitors were excluded from the bidding process and government funds worth several hundred crores of rupees were misutilised.

During the probe, officials found that several key procurement files relating to the purchases under scrutiny were not available. Investigators said these files were allegedly in the personal custody of Dr Ranga.

Amid the probe, the ACB sought details of all the procurement files, payment records, Government e Marketplace bid documents, and related records pertaining to multiple items and categories. The retrieval, compilation, and verification of such records require due process and appropriate administrative approvals from the competent authority. Officials in the state health department said some of the files related to it have also gone missing causing hindrance in the investigation.

Dr Ranga allegedly failed to provide satisfactory explanations regarding the missing records and other material aspects of the case. ACB officials said his custodial interrogation was necessary to recover missing files, identify other beneficiaries and co-conspirators, trace the money trail and recover documentary and electronic evidence.

Dr Ranga was arrested on Thursday and produced on Friday before a court, which granted the ACB four days' custody. Investigators are also examining the role of others in the conspiracy.

CM recommends transfer of 39 doctors amid irregularity probe

New Delhi: Amid an investigation into alleged large-scale irregularities in medicine procurement, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta recommended the transfer of 39 doctors to Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday.

The doctors have served in Tihar and Mandoli jails for five years or more. Available information indicates that several of them have remained posted at the same location since 2014, with their tenure exceeding 11 years, the CMO said. The proposal also mentions around 35 doctors to replace them. Thus, in total, approximately 74 transfers have been proposed. PTI

Dermatologist kills house help: Could not sense my decision to not fire her triggered him, says wife

Pragnesh
New Delhi, June 19

A DAY after a dermatologist allegedly killed his house help by battering her with a bat and then stabbing her with a knife in South Delhi's upscale Kailash Hills, his wife Tina on Thursday told the police that she never sensed that he would be so "triggered" by her decision of not firing the 45-year-old victim.

"Tina said Dr Manish Gupta had asked her to fire the house help. She refused, but Manish never made a fuss about it. He never said anything to her (Meena) either. Manish felt Meena was not cleaning the house properly. He had been requesting his wife to fire her



Accused Manish; (right) outside his house in Kailash Hills.

for two to three years," said a senior police officer.

Police said that the 54-year-old accused, who was also on antidepressants, was arrested



and sent to two-day police custody by a Delhi court.

Police are trying to find out if there is any other history of violence associated with the

doctor, even though Tina claimed that he has always been "mild-mannered" inside the house.

The accused runs his own clinic near his house in Mount Kailash. Police officers said that during questioning, the accused told them that the victim "brought bad energy" to the house.

Police said initial questioning revealed that Meena had been working at the house for the past 10 years.

On Thursday morning, Manish allegedly followed Meena to the rooftop of his third-floor house while she was going to hang washed clothes for sun-drying. "In a room adjacent to the rooftop, there was a bat and a knife. He first hit her with the bat, after which she fell to the ground. He then stabbed her multiple times," said an officer.

Police said the incident came to light when a call was received at the Amar Colony police station at 11.30 am from one of Manish's neighbours about a body being found.

"The caller said the body was lying, soaked in blood..." Deputy Commissioner of Police (Southeast) Hemant Tiwari said on Thursday.

When police reached the spot, they found the accused squatting near the body.

"The accused was beside the body. He admitted to hitting the victim with a bat and later stabbing her with a knife," DCPTiwari had said.

बैंक ऑफ़ बड़ोदा
Bank of Baroda
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Bank of Baroda, one of India's largest Banks is looking for Professionals on Fixed Term Employment basis for various senior positions in the Bank's Information Technology Department:

S No	Positions	Vacancies
1	Vice President: Head- AI	1
2	Vice President: Head Platform Engineering	1
3	Dy. Vice President: Dy. Head Cloud CoE (Centre of Excellence)	1
4	Dy. Vice President: Dy. Head IT Infrastructure	1
5	Dy. Vice President : Dy. Head Platform Engineering	1
Total		5

Eligibility criteria (age, qualification & experience) and other details are available in the respective detailed advertisement on Bank's website. Interested candidates are advised to visit the Bank's website <https://bankofbaroda.bank.in> ➡ Career Page ➡ Current Opportunities ➡ Advt No. BOB/HRM/REC/ADVT/2026/12

Candidates are advised to go through the detailed advertisements, ensuring their eligibility & other details before applying and remitting fees.

Any addendum/ corrigendum/ modification shall be notified only on the Bank's website.

Date for filling Online Application: 20.06.2026 to 10.07.2026 (23:59 hours).

Place: Mumbai Chief General Manager (HRM & Marketing)

Date: 20.06.2026

West Bengal's Progress, Strengthening the Resolve of Viksit Bharat

Foundation Stone Laying, Inauguration, Launch and Dedication to the Nation of Various Development Projects in **Railways, Agriculture, Roads, Animal Husbandry and Fisheries**

Laying of Foundation Stone for

- New Divisional Railway Hospital, Howrah, West Bengal
- Road Over Bridge between Haur & Radhamohanpur, Purba Medinipur, West Bengal

Inauguration of

- 315.22 km of Rural Roads under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY-III) in Various Districts of West Bengal constructed at a sanctioned cost of ₹213.12 Crore
- Goat Semen Production Laboratory & Semen Bank at Haringhata in Nadia district of West Bengal
- Modern, Capacity Expanded Fishing Harbour, Frasergunj
- Modern Fish Market, Sainthia, Birbhum, West Bengal

Launch of

- Digital Agriculture Mission in West Bengal
- Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana/Restructured Weather Based Crop Insurance Scheme
- National Mission on Natural Farming in West Bengal
- Prime Minister Dhan Dhaanya Krishi Yojana

Dedication to the Nation of

- Rail link line between Sankrail & Santragachi in Howrah, West Bengal

Release of

- 23rd instalment of PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi worth more than ₹ 18,880 crore to more than 9.44 Crore farmers

by

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

Better Connectivity • Stronger Agriculture • Enhanced Livelihoods • Inclusive Development

Railway Infrastructure & Connectivity

- Railway Infrastructure projects worth ₹591 crore
- New modern hospital in Howrah with over 300 beds
- Better connectivity through the Sankrail-Santaragachi rail link
- Enhanced safety and smoother movement through the Haur-Radhamohanpur Road Over Bridge

Farmers' Welfare & Agricultural Development

- Crores of farmers to be benefited
- Crop protection through PM crop insurance schemes
- Promotion of digital agriculture through AgriStack
- Increased farmer income through the PM Dhan-Dhaanya Scheme

Fisheries & Livelihood Improvement

- Modernization of Frasergunj Fishing Harbour
- New modern fish market at Sainthia
- Better income and livelihood opportunities for fishermen

Animal Husbandry & Dairy Development

- Eastern India's first Regional Semen Production Laboratory and Semen Bank for Black Bengal Goats established at Haringhata, Nadia
- A major milestone to preserve and promote the germplasm of Black Bengal Goat, a pride of West Bengal
- Accessing germplasm at low cost by the farmers

Overall Impact

- Improved infrastructure through roads, railways and hospitals
- Better connectivity, facilities and public services
- Higher incomes and better quality of life for farmers, fishermen and rural communities
- Enhanced livelihood opportunities
- Faster, inclusive and sustainable socio-economic development

In the august presence of

R.N. Ravi
Governor, West Bengal

Suvendu Adhikari
Chief Minister, West Bengal

Shivraj Singh Chouhan
Union Minister of Rural Development, Agriculture & Farmers Welfare

Rajiv Ranjan Singh
Union Minister of Panchayati Raj, Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying

Ashwini Vaishnaw
Union Minister for Railways, Information & Broadcasting and Electronics & Information Technology

Shantanu Thakur
Union MoS for Ports, Shipping and Waterways

Dr. Sukanta Majumdar
Union MoS for Education and Development of North Eastern Region

Samik Bhattacharya
Member of Parliament

Saturday, 20th June, 2026 03:15 PM Hooghly, West Bengal

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CRITICS SAY MANDATE WOULD UNDERMINE CONSUMER WELFARE

Govt digs in heels against pushback, no new petrol 2-wheelers from Apr '28

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 19

EVEN AS it has been facing pushback, the Delhi government has decided to go ahead with the proposed ban on the registration of new Internal Combustion Engine (ICE) two-wheelers from April 2028 under its new Electric Vehicle (EV) policy 2.0, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The *Indian Express* had reported on May 8 that the electrification mandate had drawn sharp opposition from manufacturers and other stakeholders, who had argued that there is a lack of alternatives for personal mobility for a large segment of the population that buys motorcycles.

Many even argued that India's still-import-dependent battery and rare-earth supply chains, heavily reliant on China, are not yet equipped to support a transition at this scale.

Top industry bodies, including the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), had also written to the government that "a mandate prohibiting ICE vehicles, would be counter-productive, potentially undermining consumer welfare and broader economic stability".

The industry bodies, in the



The draft was made public in April. FILE

communication, also pointed out that "despite Rs 75,000+ crore investments... by domestic battery giants, the current technology is still lagging in terms of performance and safety standards with respect to Chinese cell manufacturers".

They had also questioned the net environmental benefit of EV adoption at current energy mix levels and pointed out that around 71% of India's electricity comes from coal-based power generation (fossil fuels).

The government had released the draft EV policy 2.0 for suggestions and feedback from the public on April 11.

As per the draft, only electric two-wheelers will be permitted for new registrations in the Cap-

ital from April 2028. On similar lines, CNG autos will be banned from January next year.

The policy is expected to be tabled at the Cabinet meeting in the coming week and be implemented from next month, after the current policy, which has been extended multiple times till June 30, expires. Once implemented, it will be valid till 2030.

The proposed two-wheeler electrification mandate and the subsidy on hybrid vehicles have become the most controversial aspects of the policy.

"The government has taken a call on a two-wheeler electrification mandate, but the subsidy on hybrid vehicles is still under consideration," a source said. Similar to the mandate for two-wheelers and three-wheelers, the policy also proposes mandates for schools buses, fleet aggregators and delivery service providers.

Experts argue that large-scale fleet transitions require such kinds of mandates. "Countries that have successfully accelerated EV adoption have gone beyond purchase incentives. While incentives can help kick-start electrification, large-scale fleet transition requires strong regulatory signals such as Zero-Emission Vehicle (ZEV) mandates or phasing out of ICE vehicles," says Amit Bhatt, Ma-

ning Director for India at International Council on Clean Transport (ICCT).

"These policies provide automakers with confidence that demand for EVs will be sustained over the long term, encouraging them to ramp up production, invest in innovation, and expand model offerings. Over time, this leads to economies of scale, lower costs, and greater consumer choice, creating a virtuous cycle for EV adoption," Bhatt argues.

Two-wheelers constitute about 67% of the city's total vehicle stock, making their electrification crucial for reducing emissions. Electric two-wheelers have accounted for more than 7% of two-wheeler registrations in the last two financial years. So, the government has also proposed major purchase incentives. Buyers purchasing an electric two-wheeler priced up to Rs 2.25 lakh (ex-showroom) will receive an incentive of Rs 10,000 per kWh, up to a maximum of Rs 30,000 in the first year after the date of notification. The incentive will be reduced yearly. In the second year, buyers will receive Rs 6,600 per kWh, capped at Rs 20,000, while in the third year, the incentive will drop to Rs 3,300 per kWh, up to a maximum of Rs 10,000.

No fuel without PUCC: Capital readies plan to beat pollution in winter

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

NO FUEL for vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC) at petrol pumps in Delhi from November 1 and doubled parking charges at authorised facilities: these measures are part of the 'Proactive Winter Air Quality Management Framework' notified by the Delhi government with an eye on curbing pollution in peak season.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Friday that the framework lays down a series of measures that may be implemented between November and February to tackle seasonal air pollution, including staggered office timings and limits on physical attendance at offices, and tighter controls on construction activities.

The entry of non-BS-VI commercial vehicles registered outside Delhi will be restricted from November 1 to January 31. Exemptions will be provided to CNG and electric vehicles,

emergency service vehicles, and those engaged in government work, according to a statement from the Chief Minister's Office.

Parking charges at authorised parking facilities will be doubled from November 1 to February 28. "If necessary, staggered office timings may be implemented and government and private offices may operate with up to 50% physical attendance," Gupta said.

Residents and stakeholders, the CM pointed out, were usually informed about restrictions and measures only after air quality deteriorated during winter or when the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) came into force.

"This often left citizens, industries, institutions and commercial establishments with insufficient time to prepare, leading to inconvenience. This year, the government has decided to change that approach. We have notified the framework as early as June for pollution control in winter," she said.

• Skywatch

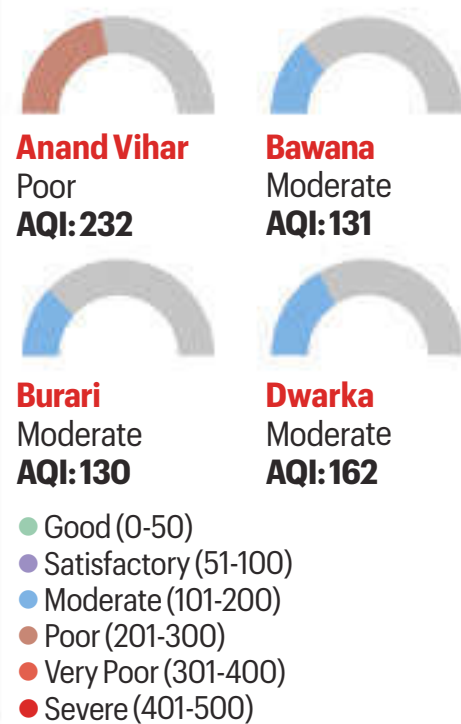


Forecast: June 20, 2026
Partly cloudy sky. Very light to light rain likely
MAX: 37-29
0.4°C above normal

MIN: 25-27
1°C below normal

• **Sunrise:** 5:24 AM (June 21)
• **Sunset:** 7:22 PM (June 20)
• **Moonrise:** 11:49 AM (June 21)
• **Moonset:** 11:40 PM (June 20)

• AQI Tracker



CJP gears up for Jantar Mantar protest today

THE COCKROACH Janta Party (CJP) is set to hold its second major protest at Jantar Mantar on Saturday, with founder Abhijeet Dipke urging participants to bring "plates and spoons" as the Internet-born outfit intensifies its campaign against exam paper leaks and student suicides. The protest is scheduled to begin at 1 pm at Jantar Mantar and is expected to draw students from Delhi and neighbouring states. In an appeal on social media, Dipke asked participants to bring plates and spoons to the protest. Dipke also wrote an open letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday expressing concern over what he described as an escalating crisis. **PTI**

MCD launches anti-dengue drive in city

WITH MONSOON around the corner and the capital reporting 162 dengue cases so far this year, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Friday launched a citywide awareness and fogging drive to curb spread of vector-borne diseases. As part of the drive, Delhi Mayor Praveesh Wahi flagged off 100 auto-rickshaws equipped with fogging machines, banners and pamphlets that will travel across all 250 municipal wards to spread awareness about the prevention of dengue, malaria and chikungunya. Speaking at the campaign launch, Wahi said the civic body is stepping up preparedness ahead of monsoon, adding that the awareness is being spread across city. **PTI**

'Future was locked away due to delayed project': Ghaziabad homebuyers win 15-year battle

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, June 19

IN 2010, two families invested in what they believed would be their future homes — 3BHK apartments in Palm Wood Enclave, a housing project developed by Sanchar Nest in Wave City, Ghaziabad. They were promised possession by 2012. However, they spent the next 15 years waiting.

The project was initially launched in Noida but after alleged land disputes, it shifted to Ghaziabad. Fresh agreements were signed in 2013, but the project comprising 506 flats remained incomplete.

This month, the Delhi consumer commission ruled in the buyers' favour. It ordered Sanchar Nest Sahakari Awas Samiti Ltd, a cooperative society, to refund Rs 79.43 lakh to the two buyers along with an additional Rs 5 lakh in compensation for mental agony and litigation costs. "This judgment means closure, relief, and justice after years of uncertainty," said one of the homebuyers.

The homebuyer said when they booked the house, they were investing in their future and their family's security. "Unfortunately, those dreams were repeatedly postponed due to delays beyond our control."

The other homebuyer described a similar ordeal: "Every passing year brought uncertainty about when or even whether we would finally receive what had been promised."

The prolonged delay came at a steep cost. The two buyers redirected their savings over the



Key infra work at the project remains unfinished. PRAVEEN KHANNA

years into their future home, only for the money to remain locked in an incomplete project.

Even today, key infrastructure work at the project remains unfinished. According to the Uttar Pradesh Real Estate Regulatory Authority (RERA) portal, essential development works, including road work, water supply, and sewer systems, are still listed as "BEING DONE". The portal also shows that there are currently 23 complaints against this specific project.

In an order dated June 8, the Delhi State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission observed: "The Opposite Party (the housing society) was deficient in rendering services to the complainants (homebuyers) by failing to hand over possession of the flats within a reasonable period and kept the amounts deposited by the complainants for almost 16 years from the date of agreements."

"The Opposite Party continued extending the date of completion and simultaneously raised additional demands under different heads, thereby

increasing the financial burden upon the complainants," the Commission noted.

It further said it was evident that while the complainants duly fulfilled their obligations by making payments as demanded and by availing loan facilities, the "Opposite Party failed to fulfil its obligation of delivering possession of the flats within a reasonable period of 42 to 48 months from the date of the agreements despite receipt of the aforesaid substantial amount".

"Purchasing this house was one of the most significant financial decisions of our lives. It required years of savings, careful financial planning, and considerable sacrifices by our family," one homebuyer shared. The other said the judgment restored confidence in the legal system.

Advocate Sarvesh Roy, who represented the homebuyers, said, "The judgment sends a clear message that the dreams and life savings of ordinary citizens cannot be treated casually by developers."

SYNDICATE WAS RUNNING OUT OF HOSPITAL IN NORTHWEST DELHI

Infants called as 'files', payments in cash: Probe deepens into trafficking racket

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, June 19

HIRA MULTI Speciality Hospital in Northwest Delhi's Begumpur — the epicentre of an alleged interstate child trafficking network — on Friday wore a deserted look with shutters down even as posters on the services offered could still be seen outside. The owner of the medical facility, Dr Viveki, is among the 13 people who have been arrested in the last 15 days for their alleged involvement in the syndicate that had been running for more than a year.

A few kilometres away, at her residence in Rohini, a kin said she was unaware of the alleged racket. "The doctor's husband is a government employee... her daughters are also preparing for the medical entrance exam," an officer said.

As the investigation into the racket gathers pace, police have begun piecing together the stories of couples who allegedly purchased newborn babies — some of them were purchased for prices going as high as Rs 10 lakh, said officers. Raids are being carried out in parts of Uttar Pradesh to recover two infants even as five have been rescued so far. A parallel probe, said officers, is going on to identify the couples who sold their children.

Among the 13 arrested are Mukesh (37) and his wife, Reema Pal, from Gwalior — they had allegedly purchased two newborns, according to officers, after they were unable to have their own children. Mukesh, a truck driver, earned a modest but steady income, and



Hira Multispeciality Hospital. GAJENDRA YADAV

despite repeated attempts, the couple — married for nearly eight years — could not conceive due to medical complications, according to police.

Last year, they visited several IVF centres in Delhi and Gurgaon in hope of becoming parents. It was during this period, said police, that they came in contact with another accused, Pratibha, who has also been arrested. She allegedly offered them a ray of hope. According to investigators, the couple then allegedly lied to their family that Reema was expecting, and shifted to Gurgaon in September 2025, claiming she needed to stay in the city for better medical care.

This year, on May 17, Pratibha allegedly told the couple to come to Hira Hospital. Upon their arrival, hospital records and admission documents were allegedly prepared to make it appear as though Reema had been admitted for delivery, according to police. Initially, the couple was allegedly offered a newborn boy for Rs 8 lakh. How-

ever, since a newborn girl was also available, the accused allegedly offered both babies together for Rs 9 lakh. Police claim the entire payment was made in cash. Investigators have also arrested another couple — Sunny Arora and Ritu Arora hailing from Haryana's Panipat. According to the police, they allegedly purchased a baby boy, who was handed over to them in March this year, for Rs 6 lakh in cash.

The mastermind has been identified as Sayabhai Ghamar alias Kalia who was arrested from Sanwar Kantha Officials privy to the investigation said Kalia initially assisted a man named as 'Sardar' who he met outside a temple where newborns were allegedly being sold and he was given Rs 5,000 for it. "For the society and people who knew him, Kalia worked as a farmer and also drove a van which belonged to his relative. He is married and has three children. He continued assisting Sardar and realised he could make this a business on his own.

He then bypassed him and contacted Pratibha and the two then started the business separately," an officer privy to investigation said.

Police said the gang members used to address the infants as 'files'.

All payments were allegedly made in cash and apart from an infant girl from Delhi, other newborns were transported by car. "Driver Vipin (arrested) along with Jyoti or Shalu would, by car, travel to Pali in Rajasthan from where they would give the money to Kalia and take the child and bring back. A man usually accompanied them so that in case of suspicion they could pretend to be a family and pass off. The babies were then kept at Heera Hospital from where they were transported to customers at their location or some were called to hospital and given," the officer added. On Thursday, DCP, Central Rohit Rajbir Singh said that three accused — Jyoti alias Kamlesh, Shalu and Lalit — were nabbed as they attempted to sell a newborn infant to decoy customers arranged by the police team.

"Central District conducted a decoy operation near RK Ashram Metro Station after relieving tip-offs," an officer said. Others who have been arrested have been identified as Vipin, Omwati, and Sarika. Officers said the operation and subsequent investigation was carried out by Sub Inspector Pragati, SI Yamini Vats, ASI Hamender, HC Sushma, ASI Sunil, HC Anuj, HC Mohit and Constable Inderjeet under the supervision of Inspector Sandeep Yadav and ACP Operations Padam Singh Rana.

Delhi gets its first women police station; LG says key milestone



LG Sandhu at the police station.

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

DELHI ON Friday got its first women police station dedicated to handling cases of crimes against women and children in the national capital. Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu inaugurated the police station, established in North Delhi's Sabzi Mandi.

A female inspector has been appointed as the Station House Officer. The police station will have a staff strength of 58, including 38 female officers.

The police station, notified on May 25, will have under its jurisdiction the entire North district. The existing Crime Against Women (CAW) Cell of the district has been merged into the new facility, which has been created to provide a safe, accessible, and victim-centric policing environment. Addressing the gathering, LG Sandhu described the inauguration as a significant milestone in the city's efforts to strengthen the safety, dignity, and empowerment of women and children. He also emphasised that the station would not only probe crimes, but also serve as a symbol of confidence and trust for women.

• ACTION AGAINST 'ILLEGAL' CONSTRUCTIONS FOLLOWS DIRECTIVE OF PUNJAB AND HARYANA HIGH COURT

Hotel, PGs, hospital sealed over violations amid crackdown in Gurgaon's DLF -3

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, June 19

A HOSPITAL, a hotel, several paying guest (PG) accommodations: Gurgaon's Department of Town and Country Planning (DTCP) cracked down on illegal commercial activities and unauthorised constructions at Nathupur Road in DLF Phase 3 on Thursday.

Acting on the directives of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, which ordered an interim stay on still-plus-4-storey constructions, the enforcement wing of the DTCP, accompanied by a heavy police force and district administration officials, sealed 11 establishments operat-

ing in violation of norms.

The drive

Led by District Town Planner (Enforcement) Amit Madholia, the drive commenced around noon at S Block on Nathupur Road. Among major commercial properties sealed were 'Hotel Moonlight' (operating from plot number NR-5) and 'The Medicity' hospital (located at NR-45). An illegal commercial office on plot NR-2 was also shut down.

The department also came down heavily on unauthorised PG accommodations. The team sealed a 48-room PG operating out of a building named Amaltas Apartments (S-23/1); a 72-

room facility spanning four floors at S-24/9; and another 25-room PG and basement beauty parlor at S-24/1.

On Friday, only security guards remained at the affected properties.

A guard standing outside Amaltas said, "The owner, who is from Gurgaon, has arranged alternate accommodation for the 40+ tenants at different parts of the city. Next week, he will formally apply for permission to restart operations under a commercial licence."

"The Town Planner had first come at 2 pm to look at the property once; soon, a team came and sealed it. Some tenants argued with him, including one



Outside the Medicity hospital in Gurgaon. EXPRESS

from an Armed Forces family, saying more notices and time were needed. But the official said it cannot be helped," the guard added.

Outside Medicity hospital, a guard in a safari suit said no one is at the site now, including the owner. "There were patients inside at the time... they have been

shifted," he said, adding "We are a proper hospital."

In a first for the DLF Phase 3 area, officials also put an earth-mover into stilt parking spaces to raze illegal structures. An unauthorised office built inside the stilt parking of S-23/5 was demolished, along with illegal construction in the side setback of one Pristine Care Clinic on plot NR-38.

The drive also targeted multiple houses where property owners had illegally constructed servant quarters, drawing rooms, and leisure rooms in stilt areas and rear setbacks.

The DTCP also cleared the Right of Way (RoW) by demolishing four unauthorised guard

rooms and removing iron grilles encroaching upon public roads.

Broader crackdown

Thursday's action is part of an ongoing, broader crackdown by the DTCP enforcement wing.

Over the past two years, drives led by Madholia have consistently targeted rampant zoning violations across upscale Gurgaon colonies, including Shant Lok-1, South City, and other DLF phases.

Past actions have repeatedly focused on the illegal conversion of residential stilt parking and basements into commercial shops, eateries, and micro-apartments, which blatantly violate the Haryana Building Code.

Officials confirmed that the current wave of enforcement will not be limited to Phase-3.

"The action is being taken in strict compliance with the High Court's orders. The campaign against illegal constructions and unauthorised commercial activities will continue across DLF Phases 1 to 5," DTP Madholia said. He further warned that FIRs would be registered against anyone attempting to obstruct the government proceedings.

In April, Madholia had led a 5-day drive against 7,500 illegal encroachments and constructions at private colonies along and around Golf Course Road.

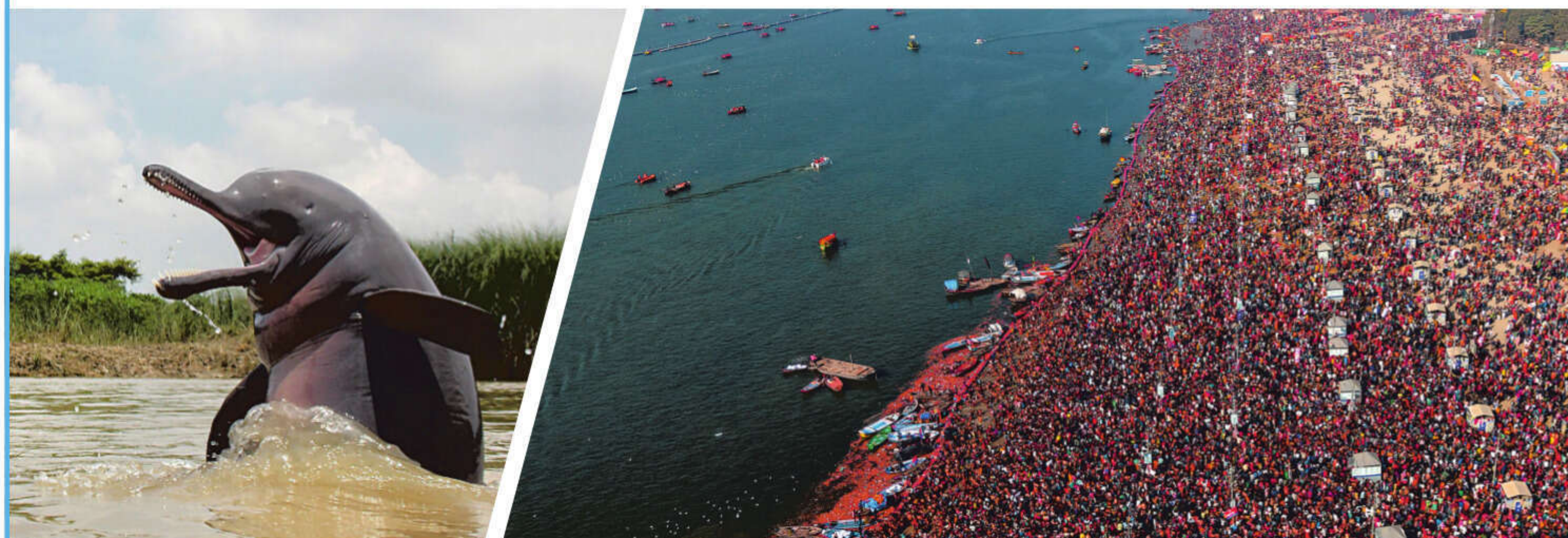
Thursday's drive is set to continue till Saturday.



What has changed along the Ganga goes beyond appearances... People's faith has also been restored.

— NAMAMI GANGE —

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Afforestation across more than 33,000 hectares has strengthened the environment and enriched biodiversity along Maa Ganga.

A Transformational Leap in Wastewater Treatment

Treatment capacity has increased nearly 38 times, from 110 MLD to 4,153 MLD, significantly reducing the flow of polluted water into Maa Ganga.

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At Prayagraj Mahakumbh 2025, more than 660 million devotees experienced the spiritual significance of a cleaner and rejuvenated Maa Ganga.

Leadership by Example

Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi dedicated the proceeds from the auction of his memorabilia to support the Namami Gange mission.

Ganga is India's lifeline.
Conserving Ganga means
safeguarding India's future.

— Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



12 Saal *Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-kalyan ke*

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Research for Better Medicines

Raising awareness about Excessive Daytime Sleepiness (EDS) to maximize true potential

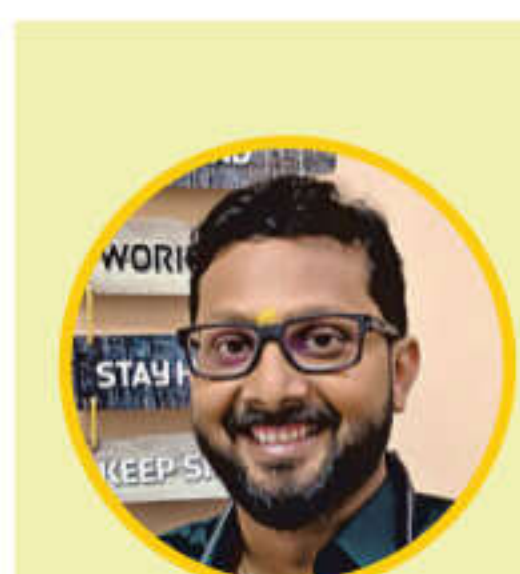
Why Treatment Sometimes Falls Short: Gaps in Managing Excessive Daytime Sleepiness



Dr. Paramjeet Singh
Psychiatrist, New Delhi

Treatment for excessive daytime sleepiness often falls short because the cause is not always found or fully treated. Sleep apnea, depression, medication effects, circadian rhythm problems, narcolepsy, and idiopathic hypersomnia can all look similar, so people may receive the wrong diagnosis or delayed care. Even when the diagnosis is correct, many treatments mainly reduce symptoms rather than fix the underlying brain or sleep problem. Some patients still have sleepiness despite regular sleep

habits and medicines, while others cannot continue treatment because of side effects, cost, or limited access to sleep testing and specialist care. Short follow-up visits may also miss residual sleepiness, poor adherence, or safety concerns such as driving risk. This is why a complete sleep history, careful review of medicines, and ongoing monitoring are important. Better results usually come from combining lifestyle measures, treatment of the underlying disorder, and individualized follow-up with a sleep specialist.



Dr. Sashi Bhushan Kumar Gupta
Psychiatrist, New Delhi

Digital Burnout: What You Can Do to Counteract the Effects of Digital Burnout

Digital burnout is a growing mental health problem caused by constant emails, notifications, messages, and multitasking in today's hyper-connected world. While technology keeps us connected, it also fragments our attention, reduces productivity, and increases stress levels.

The more frequently we switch between tasks, such as responding to emails while working on an assignment, the greater the cognitive switching penalty. These constant interruptions drain mental energy, shorten attention spans, and contribute to fatigue and anxiety by the end of the day. To protect mental health, it is

important to establish clear Digital Boundaries. One effective strategy is scheduling "Focus Hours" twice a day for two-hour periods, allowing complete concentration on a single task without interruptions. Another important boundary is exercising the "Right to Disconnect" by avoiding work-related communication outside

working hours. Recovery from cognitive fatigue requires completely stepping away from technology during personal time. Protecting personal time from digital intrusion is not a luxury—it is essential for maintaining long-term mental health, resilience, well-being, and sustained productivity.

Daytime Sleepiness: A Possible Sign of Underlying Brain Conditions

Persistent daytime sleepiness is often dismissed as stress, poor sleep, or overwork, but doctors warn it can also signal a neurological problem. In recent studies, excessive daytime sleepiness has been linked to Parkinson's disease, dementia, stroke recovery, epilepsy and multiple sclerosis, showing that the symptom may reflect disrupted brain systems that regulate wakefulness. The key concern is unexplained sleepiness that continues despite adequate rest. A 2025 meta-analysis of 65,501 people found that excessive daytime sleepiness was associated with a higher risk of cognitive decline and all-cause dementia. In Parkinson's disease, newer research has connected sleepiness with disease burden and brain-network changes. Initial evaluation typically focuses on common causes such as sleep apnea, depression, medication side effects, and circadian rhythm disturbances. However, when persistent drowsiness is



Dr. Saurabh Nandwani
Neuro Physician, New Delhi

accompanied by symptoms like memory changes, tremors, seizures, or frequent headaches, it may indicate a more serious underlying condition and warrants prompt assessment. The broader message is clear: sleepiness is not merely a sign of fatigue—it can be an important symptom, and at times, the brain's way of signaling that it needs attention.

When Sleepiness Signals More: A Neurological Perspective

Sleepiness during the day may seem harmless, it can sometimes point to disease rather than lifestyle. Excessive daytime sleepiness is common in neurological disorders because the brain circuits that govern arousal, REM sleep and circadian rhythm can be affected by illness, injury or medication. The most important distinction is between ordinary tiredness and persistent sleepiness that causes nodding off, reduced attention or an inability to stay awake in meetings or while reading. Recent evidence suggests this symptom can be seen in Parkinson's disease, stroke recovery, epilepsy, multiple sclerosis and dementia. A large 2025 analysis found that excessive daytime sleepiness was associated with increased risk of cognitive decline and dementia. Not every sleepy patient has a neurological disorder. Sleep apnea, depression and sedating drugs are frequent causes and must be checked first. Still, closer attention is needed when sleepiness arrives with imbalance, memory loss,



Dr. Shahbaz Anees
Neuro Physician, New Delhi

tremor, seizures or new headaches. In neurology, drowsiness is not just a complaint; it can be a clue.

From Brain Circuits to Daily Function: A Holistic Approach to Managing Daytime Sleepiness



Dr. Shikha Priya
Neuro Physician, New Delhi

Daytime sleepiness is often linked to the brain's sleep-wake system, which uses light, the body's internal clock, and chemical messengers to balance alertness and rest. When this system is disrupted by poor sleep, irregular schedules, sleep disorders, stress, medications, or certain medical conditions, people may feel tired, unfocused, emotionally drained, or unsafe during the day. A holistic approach starts with regular sleep and wake times, enough nightly sleep, and a dark, quiet bedroom environment that supports uninterrupted rest. Daily physical activity, healthy meals, morning

sunlight exposure, hydration, and limiting alcohol, nicotine, or late caffeine can also improve alertness and mental clarity. Short planned naps may help some people, but persistent sleepiness should never be ignored. Because daytime sleepiness can signal an underlying neurological, metabolic, or psychiatric disorder, ongoing symptoms deserve medical evaluation. Treating the root cause, improving sleep habits, and supporting overall brain health together can help restore safer, clearer, and more productive daytime functioning. Early attention may prevent accidents, memory problems, and worsening health.

A public awareness initiative from



The Brain-Sleep Connection: Why Daytime Alertness Matters



Dr. Shivani Singh
Neuro Physician, New Delhi

Daytime alertness is more than a comfort issue; it is a window into brain health. Research shows that excessive daytime sleepiness can be associated with neurological disease, reduced function and, in some studies, future cognitive decline.

The brain's sleep-wake system relies on multiple networks, including arousal and REM-regulation pathways. When those systems are disturbed by Parkinson's disease, stroke, epilepsy, multiple sclerosis or dementia, the result can be persistent drowsiness. A 2025 analysis of 65,501 participants found that excessive daytime sleepiness was associated with increased risk of cognitive decline and all-cause dementia. In Parkinson's disease, newer research has reinforced the importance of recognizing sleepiness as a non-motor symptom. At the same time, specialists caution against overinterpreting every sleepy day as a neurological warning. Sleep apnea, depression, shift work and medications remain common causes and should be assessed first. Still, the broader message is timely: if sleepiness is persistent, unexplained or changing over time, it should not be ignored. Paying attention to alertness may help clinicians detect brain-related illness earlier.

Sleepiness as a Symptom: Looking Beyond Poor Sleep



Dr. Sumirini P
Neuro Physician, New Delhi

Sleepiness is often blamed on poor sleep alone, but medical experts say the symptom can reflect much more. In neurological care, excessive daytime sleepiness may signal disrupted wakefulness pathways, brain disease, medication effects or a sleep disorder happening alongside another condition.

That broader view matters because the causes differ. Sleep apnea and depression are common and must be ruled out first. But neurological causes are increasingly recognized, including Parkinson's disease, stroke, epilepsy, multiple sclerosis and dementia-related changes. A 2025 pooled analysis also linked excessive daytime sleepiness with higher risk of cognitive decline and all-cause dementia. The best approach is to ask what the symptom looks like in daily life. Is the person simply exhausted, or do they actually fall asleep unintentionally? Is there snoring, memory loss, tremor, weakness or confusion? Those details can help separate a sleep problem from a neurological one. The message for the public is clear: persistent sleepiness deserves attention, especially when it is new, unexplained or accompanied by other brain-related symptoms.

Mental Health and productivity: Focus on daytime sleepiness.

Productivity can have different meanings ranging from output and efficiency, to balance and purpose and feeling of contentedness. Optimum mental health is a prerequisite for whatever meaning of productivity one looks at. Globally, mental health issues are leading causes of disability. Apart from suffering of millions of individuals and families, mental illnesses have a major impact on the economic growth and prosperity of Nations. All



Dr. Sumit Kumar Gupta
Psychiatrist, New Delhi

this suffering and potential economic loss can be minimized with scientific evidence backed management of such illnesses. Excessive daytime sleepiness is more than a nuisance. Sleepiness can be both a cause or effect of brain or mind illnesses. Common causes include sleep apnea, depression and medication effects. In older women, increasing sleepiness over five years has been reported

as a possible early warning sign of dementia. That does not mean every sleepy person is developing dementia, but it does mean persistent drowsiness should not be ignored. Rather, not getting adequate time for sleep is amongst the most common cause of sleepiness. The takeaway is practical: healthy brain depends on healthy sleep, and unexplained sleepiness may deserve a second look.

Why Treatment Sometimes Falls Short: Gaps in Managing Excessive Daytime Sleepiness

Treatment for excessive daytime sleepiness often falls short because the cause is not always found or fully treated. Sleep apnea, depression, medication effects, circadian rhythm problems, narcolepsy, and idiopathic hypersomnia can all look similar, so people may receive the wrong diagnosis or delayed care. Even when the diagnosis is correct, many treatments mainly reduce symptoms rather than fix the underlying brain or sleep problem. Some patients still have sleepiness despite regular sleep habits



Dr. Vikas Singhal
Psychiatrist, New Delhi

and medicines, while others cannot continue treatment because of side effects, cost, or limited access to sleep testing and specialist care. Short follow-up visits may also miss residual sleepiness, poor adherence, or safety concerns such as driving risk. This is why a complete sleep history, careful review of medicines, and ongoing monitoring are important. Better results usually come from combining lifestyle measures, treatment of the underlying disorder, and individualized follow-up with a sleep specialist.

"This is a patient awareness initiative by MSN labs. The views and opinions expressed here are based on the expertise of the doctors and is not endorsed by MSN labs. Reader's are advised to seek to necessary medical advice from a qualified medical practitioner."





Taking Lead

THE PARTY with least electoral experience in Uttar Pradesh Assembly polls next year may make the first move soon. Interviews of probable candidates for Chandrashekhar-led Azad Samaj Party (ASP) are on and it may release a list of 25-30 candidates in the next seven days, it is learnt. While the party is preparing to contest all 403 seats in Uttar Pradesh, it is still exploring the possibility of alliance with like-minded parties, said sources.

B'day Thaw

THE RELATION between Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi may not be cordial in the House, the two had a friendly conversation on the latter's 56th birthday on Friday. Sources in Rahul's office said Birla had called the LoP on Friday to wish him on his birthday. Rahul thanked Birla and the conversation lingered on to Rahul's recent visit to Kota, which happens to be Birla's constituency, where the Congress leader addressed students. Birla told Rahul that he watched the programme online, according to sources.

Left Out

A THREE-MEMBER AICC panel led by Ajay Maken recently visited Punjab to assess the political situation in the poll-bound state. The panel was meant to take stock of the state unit's affairs and suggest changes in order to strengthen party prospects in the elections due early next year. The panel learnt to have done extensive consultations with more than 70 leaders. However, sources said, the panel didn't speak with former Union minister Manish Tewari, who represented Ludhiana from 2009-2014, Anandpur Sahib from 2019-2024 and is the sitting Lok Sabha MP from Chandigarh, the joint capital of Punjab and Haryana.

SIR deletions in Bengal: Expedite lawyer's case, SC directs Tribunal

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

THE SUPREME Court Friday asked the Tribunal hearing appeals against removal of names from the voters' list after the SIR in West Bengal to decide expeditiously the case of an advocate who said he had been deleted from the list. A bench of CJI Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana asked the Tribunal to decide his appeal preferably within two months. The plea by Md Yean Ali said he is a lawyer from Murshidabad and was enrolled with the state Bar Council in 1977. He said his appeal under the Representation of the People Act-1950 was yet to be heard. The counsel appearing for Ali pointed out that the appeal has been pending since March 27, 2026. He said Ali has been practising as an advocate for over 50 years and has also been voting all along and no one had disputed his status. The court remarked that it had put in place a mechanism comprising former High Court judges to adjudicate claims of deletion and the petitioner should approach it. "...I received a letter communication from the Chief of the High Court that there are so many appeals... So, in your case, we are passing an order directing them to provide you out of turn hearing and decide your matter," the CJI said.

'WE HAVE LEFT IT TO THE SPEAKER'S WISDOM'

Abhishek urges Speaker to disqualify 20 rebel TMC MPs

Speaker told us he will get back after consulting the other faction, says TMC MP

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, June 19

A DELEGATION of TMC leaders led by its national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Friday and submitted petitions against the 20 rebel party MPs, seeking their disqualification for defecting.

Abhishek said the rebel MPs

have sold their "conscience" and if they have an issue with the TMC, they should first resign from the Lok Sabha membership and go for fresh polls. He was accompanied by TMC MPs Kalyan Banerjee, Mahua Moitra, Saugata Roy and Derek O'Brien. Abhishek said TMC hopes that being the custodian of the House, Speaker functions as per the Constitution.

The Friday meeting comes amid a dispute after a group of party MPs led by Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar had last week approached the Speaker, claiming that they had merged with the NCPI, a political party based in Tripura, and should be allowed to function as a separate bloc in Lok Sabha.

After meeting the Speaker,



TMC national general secretary and MP Abhishek Banerjee, along with other party MPs, meets Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Friday. ANI

Abhishek said: "We have kept our case in front of the Speaker. If he functions as per the Constitution and Supreme Court orders, then these MPs should be disqualified. We have left it

to the Speaker's wisdom. We hope he gives a fair judgement..." He appealed to the 20 rebel MPs of the TMC to resign first and seek the people's mandate to return to Parliament.

UDDHAV MAKES EMOTIONAL APPEAL TO CADRE; SHINDE SAYS SENA (UBT) EXODUS 'JUST TRAILER'

Sena vs Sena: Charges fly on party day

At rival rallies, Uddhav, Shinde stake claim to Bal Thackeray's legacy; six Sena (UBT) MPs at centre of defection buzz skip both events

Vallabh Ozarkar & Alok Deshpande
Mumbai, June 19

AMID THE rebellion buzz in Shiv Sena (UBT) with six of its Lok Sabha MPs being speculated to be crossing over to the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, the rival factions used the party's 60th Foundation Day on Friday to draw battle lines over the legacy of Bal Thackeray and the future of the Sena.

While Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray made an emotional appeal to party workers, even offering to step down if they lost faith in him, Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde declared, "Yeh toh sirf trailer hai, picture abhi baaki hai" (This is just a trailer; the movie is still not over)."

Significantly, the six MPs whose names have figured in discussions over a possible crossover — Sanjay Jadhav, Om-raje Nimbalkar, Nagesh Ashtikar, Babasaheb Wakchaure, Sanjay Deshmukh and Sanjay Dina Patil — skipped the foundation day events, fuelling speculation over their next move.

Addressing party workers at Mumbai's Shanmukhananda Hall, Thackeray sought to rally the cadre amid the looming crisis. "You all know how I work, and I don't believe in clinging to a post if someone points a finger at me. I want to ask all of you: I am ready to step down. I am not greedy for a post. But if a man with a traitor's blood falsely accuses me, then I expect you to answer him. I am not going to buckle under difficulties and will not run away from respon-



Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray during the party's 60th foundation day at Shanmukhananda Hall in Mumbai on Friday; (right) Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and Shiv Sena leader Eknath Shinde speaks at his party event at NESCO in Goregaon.

sibility. I will continue only as long as you have faith in me. The moment you lose that faith, I will quit this post," he said.

The gathering responded with loud slogans urging him not to step down. Taking aim at the rebel MPs, Thackeray said, "I apologise to the voters from the constituencies where these traitors won. They defeated Narendra Modi because of Balasaheb's legacy and my support. These MPs are now backstabbing the voters." Urging workers to directly question and confront these MPs, he said, "I asked you to ensure their victory. Why do you need another order to confront them? Do not lose your right to question those individuals. Go and confront them."

Warning against what he described as the BJP's attempts to dominate the political landscape, Thackeray said, "If things continue in this manner, we will have to come together and undertake Operation Lotus. The

country is moving towards anarchy. What will be the future of a country where the youth are labelled as cockroaches? They (the BJP) are moving towards one party and no polls. But I have a small piece of advice for BJP: our Independence was not achieved by winning polls, but through the rebellion of youngsters."

Rejecting speculation that Sena (UBT) could merge with the Congress, he said, "We stayed with the BJP for 30 years. We never became the BJP. What makes you think we will merge with the Congress? The situation is such that the Maharashtra BJP will merge with Mindhe (Eknath Shinde)... Shiv Sena is not going to merge with anyone..." Invoking his father's legacy, he said, "I know that I, Uddhav Thackeray, am immaterial. But Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray is not."

The four parliamentarians who have stayed with Sena (UBT) — Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut and Lok Sabha MPs Ar-



AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

vind Sawant, Anil Desai and Rajabhau Vaze — were felicitated before Thackeray's speech. He claimed that besides these leaders, 20 MLAs, corporators and thousands of workers continued to stand by him.

At NESCO in Goregaon, Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde used the Foundation Day event to defend his 2022 rebellion and sharpen his attack on the rival faction. Without naming Thackeray, he said, "They are surrounded by people who only flatter them. How will the party grow like this? Times have changed and politics must change too. Stop saying 'main, main, main (I, I, I)'. Say 'we'. Ravana's Lanka was destroyed because of ego. People understand everything."

Making a direct claim over Balasaheb Thackeray's political legacy, Shinde said, "Balasaheb Thackeray's true heirs are Shiv Sainiks. Succession is not determined by blood relations but by

"If you have been elected on a symbol and two years later, you are claiming that I am joining another party, then your membership of the Lok Sabha should end. The second claim is that they are merging with another party and have two-thirds majority, then point 4 of the 10th Schedule of the Constitution says that it will be considered a merger, when two-third of a political party merges, and not just the Legislative party... This means that if the office-bearers merge, then it should be considered a merger," he said.

Abhishek said he submitted 20 disqualification petitions to the Speaker against the defected group of MPs. "They [rebel MPs] have sold their conscience and the people of Bengal will never

forgive them. Some of them have got central security. I say they go to Bengal and face the people. They want to save themselves from ED, CBI, or they are being threatened or they are being given money. If any MP feels this is offensive — that I am saying they are being bought — then they can go to court and I will prove it before the court of law..." Abhishek said.

"We have appealed to the Speaker to take a decision on this soon after hearing both sides. If he goes as per the Constitution or Supreme Court orders, then the decision will come against the MPs," he said, adding that "the honourable Speaker... has said he will hear the other side and call us again. We hope that he works as per

the Constitutional provisions and won't strangle it."

Abhishek had last week written to Birla, opposing any recognition, status or facilities being granted to what he described as a "purported separate group or faction" of the All India Trinamool Congress. Those in the camp of the 20 defected MPs, led by Dastidar, believe they will not be disqualified since over two-thirds of the MPs — 20 of the party's 28 lawmakers — have merged with another party. However, the Mamata Banerjee faction believes the rebels will face disqualification and argues that the anti-defection law requires a broader "twin test" to establish whether a valid merger of the original political party has taken place.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, along with Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and MoS Shobha Karandlaje, disburse incentives worth Rs 2,400 crore under the PM-VBRY, in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

70 lakh jobs created under PM-VBRY: PM

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi said on Friday that around 70 lakh jobs have been created so far under the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana (PM-VBRY) and out of these, about 20 lakh youths have already completed six months in their first job.

Participating in the incentive disbursal programme under the PM-VBRY, he said, "Around 70 lakh jobs have been created so far with the support of Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana, and first-time employees have also gained the protection of social security. Nearly 20 lakh young people have completed six months in their first jobs, and today, about 10 lakh of them received incentives for completing this six-month milestone."

"A sum, or over Rs 2,000 crore has been credited to their accounts. This amount is not just economic support, it is a recognition of their hard work. This is an expression of the country's trust in their bright future," the PM said.

The PM-VBRY, which came into effect on August 1, 2025, aims to incentivise the creation

of over 3.5 crore jobs over a two-year period. The government has provided a total outlay of Rs 99,446 crore.

According to a statement issued by the PMO, around 1.92 crore beneficiaries are expected to be first-time entrants into the workforce. The scheme is playing a transformative role in expanding formal employment, strengthening social security coverage, and advancing the vision of a Viksit Bharat, it said. Under the PM-VBRY, first-time employees are eligible for an incentive of up to Rs 15,000. Employers generating additional employment are eligible for incentives of up to Rs 3,000 per month per additional employee.

The PM also expressed satisfaction about those institutions who have provided jobs to these youths. Stating that the world is talking about India's youth power today, Modi said that India's youth will be at the forefront of driving global growth, innovation and entrepreneurship in the years to come. "To compete globally, we must meet the highest quality standards," he said, adding that the aspirations, skills and potential of our youth shape the path to a Viksit Bharat.

Revised Kerala Budget: 'Knowledge Valley' for students, 'silver economy' for senior citizens

Shajhu Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 19

POSITIONING KERALA as a maritime and aviation logistics hub, setting up a Knowledge Valley to stem student migration, promoting a "silver economy" to harness the expertise of senior citizens, and bringing a comprehensive land management policy to attract investment are among the key initiatives announced in the revised Budget for the current fiscal year, presented by Chief Minister V D Satheesan on Friday.

KIIFB overhaul

One of the major Budget announcements that Satheesan, who also holds the Finance portfolio, made is the proposed restructuring of the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB), which the previous Left government had turned into a vehicle for off-budget borrowing and infrastructure financing. "The debt repayment obligation of KIIFB is Rs 20,000 crore. KIIFB relies on off-budget borrowings at interest rates significantly higher than those incurred on standard sovereign state borrowings. This has inexorably pushed the



Kerala CM V D Satheesan, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala and others during the Budget session of the Assembly on Friday. PTI

state's borrowings and debt burden beyond permissible limits, triggering grave macro-economic imbalances. Taking cognisance of these challenges, we will constitute an expert committee to initiate comprehensive structural reforms and overhaul of KIIFB's current operational framework," he said.

Maritime, aviation hub

Satheesan also announced the Rs 400-crore Mission Samudra, which is aimed at positioning Kerala as a global maritime hub by leveraging ports such as Vizhinjam and 17 others along Kerala's coastline. With an allocation of Rs 200 crore,

the government also aims to tap the potential of the state's four international airports to position it as an aviation hub.

Minerals corridor

To tap the critical mineral resources and rare earth deposits along the coast of Kerala, the Budget also proposed a Southern Kerala Economic Corridor & Rare Earth and Critical Minerals Corridor. This is expected to boost the space and technology institutions in the region.

Silver economy

Highlighting Kerala's ageing population, the government proposed developing a

"silver economy" through world-class facilities for senior citizens, entrepreneurship programmes, institutional support and measures to utilise their expertise and experience.

Karuthal Mission

To support poor families facing rising healthcare and education expenses, the government launched the One Kerala Karuthal Mission, a tech-driven platform to provide direct assistance to eligible beneficiaries.

Job watch

The government will establish a Global Job Watch Tower, a state-level future skills and employment intelligence mission aimed at aligning education and skill-development programmes.

Knowledge Valley

To curb the outflow of students seeking higher education outside the state, the government announced the establishment of Kerala Knowledge Valley, envisioned as a world-class higher education hub. This will bring together advanced academic programmes, research parks and centres of excellence, and seek to attract leading Indian and international universities through a legislative framework.

Waited 500 years for Ram temple, give SIT 15 days: UP CM in Ayodhya

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, June 19

BREAKING HIS silence on the allegations of misappropriation of donations and valuables at the Ram Temple, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Friday urged critics to submit any evidence they possess to the SIT that is conducting an inquiry and wait for the outcome of the probe, rather than "defame" Ayodhya.

"Trust ke anurodh par SIT jaanch karayi gayi hai. SIT jaanch doodh ka doodh, pani kapani karegi. (The SIT inquiry was ordered at the request of the trust. It will establish the truth and separate facts from falsehood)," he said in Ayodhya. The three-member SIT has been examining records and statements in Ayodhya and is likely to submit its findings to the state government after completing the investigation.

He appealed to Ram devotees to remain patient, saying those who had waited 500 years for the temple construction could wait another 15 days for the SIT to complete its inquiry. "My humble appeal to Ram devotees is that Lord Ram taught us the path of dignity and restraint. We struggled in a disciplined manner for 500



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath at Maa Kamakhya Temple in Ayodhya's Rudauli on Friday. PTI

years to reclaim Ram Janmabhoomi. Wait another 15 days, be patient, and don't worry." He cautioned devotees against being influenced by attempts to tarnish the image of Ayodhya and the Ram Temple.

Attacking the Congress, he accused it of opposing the Ram Temple movement and questioning the existence of Lord Ram. "Jo Congress Ayodhya mein Bhagwan Ram ka mandir na banne paye uske liye poori taqat laga rahi thi... Supreme Court mein shapath patra dekar keh rahi thi ki Ram hain hi nahi. Jisne aapki asmita aur pehchan par sankat khada kiya tha, woh Congress aaj Ayodhya mein badi machal rahi hai" (Congress used

all its strength to prevent the construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and even filed affidavits in the Supreme Court questioning the existence of Lord Ram. The same Congress, which challenged your identity and beliefs, is now appearing deeply agitated over developments in Ayodhya)," he said.

Targeting the SP over the Ayodhya movement, he said, "Those who ordered firing on Ram devotees and kar sevaks, and had people beaten for chanting Jai Shri Ram are today preaching to others." He said it was ironic that parties which had opposed the Ram Janmabhoomi movement were claiming to speak on behalf of Ram devotees.

‘Ragging’ at Gujarat medical college: Six suspended

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, June 19

SIX STUDENTS of the Government Medical College’s orthopaedic department in Bhavnagar were suspended on Friday for periods ranging from six months to two years in connection with allegations of ragging. “Students are made to sit (by seniors) in a roster position on tables till cramps develop in muscles, or made to do sit-ups till they lose consciousness, and told to write ‘apology note’ 500-1,000 times,” one of the first year students at the college told *The Indian Express*, alleging that they were subjected to “mental and physical harassment.”

This is the second such instance reported from a government medical college in Gujarat in a span of three days. On June 17, three PG students of the orthopaedic department of B J Medical College, Ahmedabad, were suspended for up to a year for allegedly ragging juniors.

In a written complaint to the college authorities, some first year students have also alleged that they were forced to spend Rs 2 lakh – “including expenditure on food and alcohol” – by the seniors concerned.

Health Minister Pansheriya asserted that if any student faces ragging, mental harassment, pressure, threat or any other kind of inhumane behaviour, they should fearlessly inform the Anti-Ragging Committee of the college, college administration or authorities immediately. “No student should tolerate such pressure or any inhumane act. The Anti-Ragging Committee and the Health Department are fully committed to the safety and justice of every student and immediate and strict action will be taken on every complaint received,” he added.

Right to walk on safe footpaths a fundamental right, says SC

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, June 19

THE SUPREME Court on Friday held that the right to walk on secured footpaths is a fundamental right and urged the government to bring a law that declares this right and recognises the duty of municipal authorities and local bodies to build, demarcate, and maintain necessary pedestrian infrastructure.

“The right to walk is a fundamental right under Part III of the Constitution... The fundamental right to walk will take within its sweep the right to demarcated footpaths. These rights are primary and shall have priority over movement by motorised

vehicles,” said the bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Atul S Chandurkar.

The court said that the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths has a correlative duty. “If the road exists, there is a duty to ensure that there are demarcated... The duty bearers are the urban development authorities, municipal corporations, municipalities and even panchayats, who must endeavour to demarcate, construct, maintain, and safeguard footpaths and other necessary pedestrian infrastructure, as walking is integral to life,” the bench said.

It further added that “the violation of the right to walk on de-

marcated footpaths will entitle the citizens to invoke constitutional and legal remedies against duty bearers for restitution and compensation. This remedy is independent of the remedies that are available under the Motor Vehicles (MV) Act, 1988.” The judgment came in a motor accident claim case related to a five-year-old boy’s death. A man and his son were walking toward his school when a tanker hit the boy, crushing his waist and lower body later succumbing to the injuries.

On May 30, 2016, the Motor Accidents Claims Tribunal (MACT) granted compensation of Rs 7.82 lakh, with 6 per cent interest per annum. The Supreme

Court enhanced it to Rs 11,44,628, and directed that it be paid within two months.

The Supreme Court noted “there was neither a footpath nor a pedestrian crossing” on the stretch of road where the accident happened and added that such incidents “continue to occur... till we restructure our rights regime as regards access to roads and recognise their correlative duties”. “It is rather strange that we failed to focus on recognising and securing this ‘right to walk’. It may be because wheels eclipsed our imagination, and our municipal administration was busy creating roads that are suitable for motorised vehicles,” the court added.



Rahul Gandhi turns 56

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi blows a candle during his birthday celebrations at AICC headquarters in New Delhi on Friday. Party president Mallikarjun Kharge, party leader Priyanka Gandhi and others were also present. PM Narendra Modi extended greetings to Gandhi, wishing him good health and a long life. PTI

Pushpa 2 stampede: Summons issued against Allu Arjun

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, June 19

THE IX Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate at the Nampally Court Complex issued summons to Telugu actor Allu Arjun and 19 others to appear on Monday in connection with the December 2024 Sandhya Theatre stampede case as the trial is set to begin next week.

The chargesheet, filed on December 27 last year, names Arjun as accused. The stampede occurred on December 4, 2024, outside Sandhya Theatre at the premiere screening of *Pushpa 2: The Rule*, starring Arjun. A woman was killed in the stampede. An FIR was lodged against Arjun and others under BNS provisions relating to culpable homicide not amounting to murder and voluntarily causing hurt.

Shah sets three-year justice delivery target

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah on Friday said the government is working towards ensuring that the entire criminal justice process — from registration of an FIR to conviction and appeals — is completed within three years, as he stressed greater use of technology, artificial intelligence and scientific evidence in crime investigation.

Addressing the inaugural session of the 26th All India Fin-

gerprint Conference 2026 in Delhi, Shah said the Narendra Modi government has undertaken comprehensive reforms of criminal laws since 2019 with the objective of making science and technology an integral part of the criminal justice system.

“NCRB-Abhigyan, CrPI, e-Prosecution 2.0 and e-Forensics 2.0 applications launched today will facilitate the speedy disposal of pending cases and help ensure timely delivery of justice,” Shah said after launching the applications developed by

the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB).

Shah said ensuring justice within three years from the registration of an FIR to conviction is a key objective of the government’s criminal justice reforms, and claimed India has moved close to achieving that goal over the past seven years.

Emphasising the importance of scientific probe, he said fingerprints remain among the most crucial forms of evidence and urged states to strengthen the National Automated Fin-

gerprint Identification System (NAFIS) database by uploading fingerprints collected from crime scenes.

“No matter how cunning a criminal may be, he cannot escape the combined power of law and science,” Shah said.

Shah also outlined plans for a predictive policing framework that would use artificial intelligence, machine learning and pattern analysis to identify repeat offenders and interstate criminal networks before crimes are committed.

**NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY**

E-Tendering Tender Notice
No. 32/2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.)
N.E. Railways, Izatnagar For and on behalf of President of India invites **"OPEN" E-Tender** through Online (E-Tendering) for the following work:-
Description of works: Provision of 02 stabling line in CBJ yard associated with IZN yard, Bareilly.;
Approx. Value(₹): ₹1,34,04,145.95;
E.M.D. Money(₹): ₹2,68,100/-
Cost of Tender Forms: ₹Nil; **Completion time/period from the date of issue of acceptance letter:** 06 Months. 1. Online E-Tender can be submitted upto **15:00 hrs. of dated 09.07.2026**. 2. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in
Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.)
CPROW-184 Izatnagar
DO NOT SMOKE BIDI/CIGARETTE IN TRAINS

Punjab, Haryana rift over Malwa canal at zonal meet

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, June 19

FRESH DIFFERENCES over water management surfaced among Punjab, Haryana, and the Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB) Friday, with Punjab questioning the availability of water for a proposed irrigation canal in the Malwa region and challenging the assessment methods being used by the Board.

Once completed, the project aims to provide irrigation facilities to four districts of Punjab’s Malwa belt by drawing water from the Harike barrage.

During the 22nd meeting of the Standing Committee of the Northern Zonal Council held in Shimla, Haryana officials also sought access to the Detailed Project Report (DPR) of the proposed canal project, stating they needed complete technical details before any further discussions could take place.

Punjab questioned whether the BBMB possessed accurate measurements and reliable data regarding the quantity of water available in the reservoirs. In response, BBMB officials said that the matter had already been referred to the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Ropar, for a detailed scientific study and assessment.

Principal Secretary (Punjab) Krishan Kumar,

strongly objected to the demand of Haryana officials, who were seeking a DPR of the proposed canal.

“Krishan Kumar strongly said that it is a project of Punjab within the Punjab. Haryana has nothing to do with it. Punjab needs a canal from Harike barrage where BBMB regulates the flow of water. Haryana doesn’t figure in the picture,” a source said.

Emphasising the need for cooperative federalism, Srivastava remarked that Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, and Chandigarh were once part of an erstwhile single administrative entity and should work together to address issues of common interest.

Representatives from the National Capital Territory of Delhi, Union Territories of Chandigarh, Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh also attended the meeting. Rajasthan officials participated in the meeting virtually. The Standing Committee reviewed a wide range of inter-state issues relating to law and order, social welfare, health, education, urban development, agriculture, and cooperative sectors.

Meanwhile the Delhi government raised the issue of imposing a complete ban on the manufacturing, storage, sale, including online sale and delivery, and bursting of all kinds of firecrackers.

**उत्तर प्रदेश पावर ट्रान्समिशन कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड, कार्यालय मुख्य अभियंता (पाद०२००), आगरा जैम बिड एवं कार्य का सक्षिप्त खिचण, निम्नालिखित कार्य हेतु आमंत्रित जैम निविदा संख्या**

GEM/2026/B/7601828, GEM/2026/B/7598447, GEM/2026/B/7641283, GEM/2026/B/7675675, GEM/2026/B/7668832, GEM/2026/B/7665134, GEM/2026/B/7664948 को तकनीकी कारणोंवश: निरस्त करने हुए पुन: निम्नालिखित जैम निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है।
1. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7683236 - Work for revetment of Tower no. 59 (A+) of D/C 132 KV Gokul-Manth Line/132 KV Manth-Manth(220) Line Under ETD Mathura/ETC Mathura धरोहर राशि ₹ 22,000.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय-13.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक।
2. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7683283 - Work for revetment of Tower no. 67 (A+) of D/C 132 KV Gokul-Manth Line/132 KV Manth-Manth(220) Line Under ETD Mathura/ETC Mathura धरोहर राशि ₹ 22,000.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय 13.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक।
3. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7683324 - Work for Revetment Of Tower Loc. No. 129 B+5 type for 220 KV Pilipokhar Agra (400)-IOCL (Mathura) DC Line Under ETD. Mathura/ETC Mathura धरोहर राशि ₹ 22,000.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय 13.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक।
4. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7683171 - Work of Supply and Installation, Testing & Commissioning Of Numerical Relays at various 220 KV Sub-Stations Under ETC Aligarh धरोहर राशि ₹ 32,000.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय- 13.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक।
5. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7682973- पारेषण दक्षिण- पश्चिम क्षेत्र आगरा के अधीन विभिन्न 400 केवी, 220 केवी उपकेन्द्रों हेतु GPS Clock के क्रय एवं स्थापना के कार्य हेतु। धरोहर राशि ₹ 44,500.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय 03.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक।
6. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7682767-Work of Supply, Retrofitting, Testing & Commissioning of Different Relays at Various Substations under ETD Mathura/ETC Mathura धरोहर राशि ₹ 38,500.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय-03.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक।
7. जैम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7681846- Installation and Supply Of Battery Set(Exide make) 110V 200AH, 300AH, 48V200AH & 48V300 AH Tubular Lead Acid Type OPzS with Standard Accessories (each of 02 Volt) for various Sub-Stations Under Transmission South West Zone Agra. धरोहर राशि ₹ 81,000.00 मात्र। निविदा जैम पोर्टल पर स्वीकार करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय-03.07.2026 समय 12:00 बजे तक। विस्तृत जानकारी एवं प्रश्न- जैम पोर्टल वेबसाइट पर उपलब्ध है। अंग्रेज समस्त सूचनाई जैम पोर्टल वेबसाइट पर ही प्रदर्शित की जाएगी।
हस्ता./-(अरविन्द कुमार), अधीक्षण अभियंता (सं०), पत्रांक 1762/मु०अभि० (पाद०२०) आ००/जैम निविदा, दिनांक-19/06/2026

**GOVERNMENT OF MADHYA PRADESH ENERGY DEPARTMENT**

MANTRALAYA, VALLABH BHAWAN
In order to invite applications from eligible candidates fulfilling the qualifications for the post of Chairperson, M.P. Electricity Regulatory Commission, a public notice No. 3001/2195683/2024 /13/04 dated 05.05.2026 has been issued and the last date of receiving applications is 19.06.2026. It has now been decided to extend the date for receiving of application for the post of Chairperson, MPERC by 21.07.2026. Interested person(s) may now submit application(s) latest by 21.07.2026 at the following address: -
Additional Chief Secretary,
Government of Madhya Pradesh,
Energy Department, 2nd Floor,
Mantralaya, Vallabh Bhawan-II,
Bhopal-462004 (M.P.)
Note:
Such applicants, who had applied for subject reference against old Vacancy Circular dated 13.08.2024 (or extension thereof), which was scraped vide public notice dated 13.04.2026, shall also have to apply afresh against this Vacancy Circular. The above public notice is available at the web portal of Energy Department, Government of Madhya Pradesh <http://energy.mp.gov.in>
Sd/-
Officer on Special Duty,
Govt. of Madhya Pradesh,
Energy Department

**National Gallery of Modern Art (Ministry of Culture) Government of India**
Jaipur House, New Delhi-110003

Appointment on Deputation
Applications are invited for filling up (i) one post of Public Relation Officer (PRO) (ii) two posts of Office Superintendent (iii) two posts of Upper Division Clerks (UDC) (iv) one post of Administrative Officer, on deputation (including short term contract) basis (v) one post of Security Officer on deputation / re-employment of armed forced personnel and (vi) one Curator (Restoration) on Composite method [deputation(including short term contract) plus promotion] basis in National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi and its branch at Mumbai. This is sub-ordinate office under Ministry of Culture and a premier museum of India with rich and exquisite collection of contemporary paintings.
Applications, in duplicate, in the prescribed proforma must reach the undersigned within a period of 30 days from the date of publication of the advertisement in the Employment News through proper channel. For details visit Ministry of Culture website <http://www.culture.gov.in> and NGMAs website www.ngmaindia.gov.in.
(Sushmit Sharma)
Head of Office (NGMA)
Email id: delhi.ngma@gov.in
Jaipur House, New Delhi - 110003
CBC-09110/11/0002/2627

Fines for spitting, littering in Bengal from Sept 1: Minister

Kolkata: People found spitting on roads, using plastic indiscriminately or urinating in public places in urban areas of West Bengal will face monetary penalties from September 1 as part

of a drive to improve civic cleanliness, state Urban Development and Municipal Affairs Minister Agnimitra Paul said on Friday. “If someone spits in a public place, the fine will be Rs 100. The

use of plastic, littering and urinating in public places will attract a penalty of Rs 200,” Paul told *PTI*. She said the penalties would be imposed under existing municipal laws. PTI

DIRECTORATE GENERAL BORDER SECURITY FORCE, BLOCK NO.10, CGO COMPLEX, LODHI ROAD, NEW DELHI, 110003

No. 19/01/2026-Estt/BSF/13515
Dated 25th May 2026
FILLING UP THE POST OF GROUP 'B' & 'C' (COMBATISED POST) IN THE BORDER SECURITY FORCE, AIR WING ON DEPUTATION (INCLUDING SHORT TERM CONTRACT)/ ABSORPTION/RE-EMPLOYMENT BASIS.

Applications are invited on the prescribed proforma from eligible candidates for filling up the following Group 'B' & 'C' posts (Combatized post) in the BSF, Air Wing on Deputation (including short term contract)/ Absorption/Re-employment basis:-

S. No	Posts vacant	Pay Matrix	Vacancies
1.	Senior Flight Engineer (Inspector)	Pay Matrix Level - 7	02
2.	Senior Flight Gunner (Inspector)	Pay Matrix Level - 7	04
3.	Junior Flight Engineer (Sub-Inspector)	Pay Matrix Level - 6	02
4.	Junior Flight Gunner (Sub Inspector)	Pay Matrix Level - 6	08
5.	Assistant Aircraft Mechanic (Assistant Sub-Inspector)	Pay Matrix Level - 5	08
6.	Assistant Radio Mechanic (Assistant Sub-Inspector)	Pay Matrix Level - 5	03
7.	CT(Maintenance)	Pay Matrix Level - 3	01
Total			28

2.

Details of Advertisement containing Application Form, eligibility conditions, method and modalities of recruitment, Aircraft wise & stream wise vacancies, vacancy updation etc. can be seen / downloaded from the BSF website www.bsf.gov.in. Step to see the advertisement - firstly go to web site and further on “BSF Recruitment”.

3.

The Advertisement is open for one year subject to availability of vacancies as per requirement. Eligible candidates may apply upto one year from the date of publication of this Advertisement in the Employment News. Last date for receipt of applications will be the last working day of the 12th month from the date of publication of the advertisement in the Employment News. Vacancies and criteria are subject to change as per the requirement.

4.

For any enquiry contact telephone No. 011-24364851 to 55. Extension- 2612 & 2658.

Sd/-
Deputy Inspector General (Estt)
CBC 19110/11/0014/2627
Telephone No. 011-24361877

**North Eastern Indira Gandhi Regional Institute of Health & Medical Sciences, Director's Block, Mawdiangdiang, Shillong (An Autonomous Institute under Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India)**

Advertisement No.EST-II-RSRD0APSR/1/2024-Estt.II dated 19.05.2026
RECRUITMENT NOTICE
ROLLING ADVERTISEMENT FOR RECRUITMENT OF SENIOR RESIDENT DOCTORS AT NEIGRIHMS, SHILLONG

North Eastern Indira Gandhi Regional Institute of Health & Medical Sciences, Shillong an autonomous Medical Institution under the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Govt. of India declares Walk-in-interview for recruitment for the post of Senior Resident Doctors under Govt. of India Residency Scheme for 3(three) years tenure. **This being a rolling Advertisement, further vacancies along with the Eligibility Criteria, Selection Procedure, Application Procedure, Terms and Conditions etc as amended from time to time will be uploaded on our Institute website only** and not be published in either Employment News or any News Papers. The aspiring applicants satisfying the eligibility in all respect can submit their applications in prescribed proforma alongwith scanned copy of their certificates by email to neigrihms.recruitment@gmail.com. The application form will be available on NEIGRIHMS official website.

The 1st cut of date for submission of applications is 21 days from the date of publication of advertisement in Employment News. A notice for the subsequent cut of dates will be issued on NEIGRIHMS official website only
NEIGRIHMS, Shillong reserves the right to continue more cycles. Once all positions are filled, no more applications will be considered.

The vacant posts of Senior Resident are given below:

S. No	Departments	Vacancy	Reservation
1	Anaesthesiology	9	4-UR, 3-OBC*, 2-SC*
2	Anatomy	2	1-SC, 1-UR
3	Burns & Plastic Surgery	1	1-UR
4	Cardiology	1	1-OBC*
5	CTVS	1	1-OBC*
6	Dermatology	1	1-OBC*
7	ENT	1	1-OBC
8	General Medicine	7	6-OBC*, 1-SC*
9	General Surgery	4	4-OBC
10	Microbiology	1	1-SC
11	Neurology	3	1-UR & 2-OBC*
12	Neurosurgery	2	1-UR, 1-OBC*
13	Obstetrics & Gynaecology	3	2-OBC, 1-SC
14	Ophthalmology	1	1-UR
15	Paediatrics	3	1-OBC*, 2-SC*
16	Paediatrics Surgery	1	1-UR
17	Pain & Palliative Care	1	1-UR
18	Pharmacology	1	1-SC*
19	Physiology	1	1-OBC
20	Radiodiagnosis	4	1-SC*, 2-OBC & 1-ST
21	Radiation Oncology	2	1-SC, 1-OBC
22	Surgical Oncology	3	3-OBC*
23	TB & Respiratory Diseases	1	1-UR
24	Urology	1	1-OBC
Total			55 (Fifty-five)

*** The numbers of vacant posts indicated above are inclusive of backlog vacancies.**
3 (three) posts reserved for Persons with Benchmark Disabilities in the non surgical departments as per Government of India policy:
For further details regarding essential qualification, age, pay scale, prescribed application form & general information etc. of the advertisement are available on NEIGRIHMS, Shillong website <http://neigrihms.gov.in>. All applicants are advised to keep visiting NEIGRIHMS website on regular basis for any further updates.
For queries contact Establishment Section at Phone No. (0364) 2538020, 2539215/216.

Sd/-
Deputy Director (Admn)
NEIGRIHMS
CBC 17119/11/0007/2627



epaper.indianexpress.com



US diktat on AI makes case for global regulation

THE US GOVERNMENT’S directive requiring Anthropic to suspend access for foreign nationals to its AI models, Fable 5 and Mythos 5, has sparked a wider debate over the development and deployment of artificial intelligence and raised concerns across the world. Calls for technological sovereignty are growing louder, with national worries increasing about the implications of a single government being able to restrict access to the most advanced AI systems without consultation or transparency. Equally pressing are concerns about the risks associated with deploying such frontier models in the absence of independent oversight and a robust global governance framework.

The demand for a credible and robust regulatory framework is also gaining momentum, with even industry leaders making the case for stronger oversight. A few days ago, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei argued that “it is time to go beyond transparency to more serious and binding regulation of AI”. While the current issue reportedly stems from concerns about the circumvention of existing safeguards, the manner in which the decision has unfolded raises deeper questions. As Anthropic itself noted, the directive “did not provide specific details of its national security concern”. The fundamental question is: Who gets to decide access to frontier AI models? Should such decisions rest with governments, which have previously used chip export controls to restrict access to critical AI hardware, or with executives of private companies, whose decisions may be shaped by commercial and strategic considerations? What is needed is a transparent framework built on clearly defined principles and procedures. In fact, even Amodei has argued that frontier models “should be required to go through technical testing and auditing, and their release should be blocked or reversed as a threat to public safety if they do not meet high standards of safety”. He recommended that testing be carried out “by a qualified third party”.

Given the transformative and borderless nature of AI, these complex issues cannot be resolved by any one country acting alone. They must be negotiated at the global level through a governance architecture built on broad consensus and inclusive participation. All stakeholders need a seat at the table. India, with one of the world’s largest AI user bases and vast amounts of data that contribute to the value and capabilities of global AI systems, is a critical stakeholder in this debate. It must play an active role in shaping the international regulatory framework that will govern AI’s future.

Delhi’s unfinished fight against prejudice

OVER 10 years after the Delhi Police established a specialised cell in an effort to crack down on racially motivated crimes against people from Northeast India, the numbers tell a dismal story. As reported in this newspaper, only 33 cases out of the 2,656 FIRs filed between 2014 and 2026 have resulted in convictions. More than half of those accused have remained “untraced”. This glacial progress stands in stark contrast to the continuing experience of discrimination faced by people from the Northeast; earlier this year, two women from Assam reported being assaulted and subjected to racist slurs in Nehru Place, and three women from Arunachal Pradesh complained about racist abuse from neighbours in Malviya Nagar.

The persistence of such complaints, combined with the poor rate of progress on reported crimes, point to serious shortfalls in existing mechanisms. Earlier this year, the Union Home Ministry urged cities across the National Capital Region to appoint nodal officers to address racism faced by people from the Northeast. Delhi already has a nodal officer at the rank of joint commissioner who is responsible for coordinating with its 15 police districts. Gurugram, too, has a helpline that is handled by an officer of the deputy commissioner rank. What is missing is awareness, leading to a culture of impunity and a deepening trust deficit between law enforcement and affected communities.

All too often, as youth from the Northeast, like their counterparts from elsewhere in India, move to different parts of the country for education and jobs, they find their experiences being shaped by slurs and suspicion, housing and employment discrimination, even violence. In 2014, the MP Bezbaruah Committee, formed after the killing in Delhi of 19-year-old Nido Taniam from Arunachal Pradesh, warned that only time-bound action against racial crime would keep the prejudice from festering and fuelling the “already strong feeling of alienation” among youth from the Northeast. Yet, it takes a tragedy — like the stabbing of 24-year-old Anjel Chakma from Tripura in Dehradun last year — to acknowledge the cost of ignoring these faultlines. Outrage can serve as a necessary driver of urgency, but it’s not a substitute for the granular work of better outreach, sensitisation of police personnel to diversity and greater transparency and accountability.

Grammys learn to listen to the world

AS GLOBAL music listening trends continue to blur boundaries of language and genre, with artists from Seoul to San Juan and Jalandhar to Tokyo commanding a global fan base through streaming platforms, the Recording Academy, the Grammys’ governing body, has decided to reflect this reality in next year’s awards. It has introduced five new categories, including Best Asian pop, Latin pop music, two new categories for traditional folk and one for Best R&B collaboration.

The new categories will be a part of the Grammys next year. This is a highly anticipated change, spurred by the success of K-pop and the achievements of Puerto Rican artists like Bad Bunny, whose 100 per cent Spanish album at last year’s Grammys challenged the popular notion that English-language music alone defines the mainstream. This shift also reflects the inclusion of more Korean and Latin voting members in the Academy.

The development is especially significant for Indian music, now a global cultural export with artists like Diljit Dosanjh, Karan Aujla and AP Dhillon, who don’t owe their fan base to Western music industries. It will allow musicians like Sid Sriram and Hanumankind, who often make music in Tamil and Malayalam, a better chance at the hallowed gramophone as they will be evaluated within their musical ecosystems. Musicians from historically underrepresented nations like Iran, Afghanistan, Indonesia, and Sri Lanka, who possess rich musical traditions but are rarely in the running for global recognition, could stand a better chance at the Grammys without having to pander to Western standards. With music being shaped by many voices, it is reassuring to see that its highest honours want to mirror that diversity.

Biggest lesson for Tata today: Institution is bigger than individuals



R GOPALAKRISHNAN & NOSHIR SOONAWALA

MANY ARE sad that Tata is facing internal conflict. As retired directors, who together served Tata for many decades, we feel enormous pain and also that the dispute is existential.

Differences are common, but leaders can rely on proven methods to resolve disputes. The Mahabharata and Ramayana, among others, suggest the method: One, apply *rajadharma*; two, seek compromise before conflict; three, protect both the institution and the weak; and four, use wise advisors.

Tata’s enterprise and philanthropy institutions must align to avoid losing the plot. Together, they are collaborators; individually, they become competitors. American investor Ray Dalio’s formula for nations applies equally to companies: Educate your people, earn more than you spend, and avoid internal and external fights. The late Ratan Tata transformed a tradition-bound Tata into a growth-oriented, entrepreneurial organisation. Based on what they read, however, the modern commentariat makes its own sombre prognostications.

Globally, the corporate world is seeing early signs of shared power rather than a single all-powerful CEO (See Pilita Clark, ‘Why co-CEOs might suit our tumultuous times’, *Financial Times*, May 3). Future CEOs may be less able to exercise unidimensional power than their predecessors did. The styles of Jack Welch and Lee Iacocca have a lower chance of success now-

adays. Shared leadership styles must complement rather than compete.

Though leaders will seek power and glory, they must combine adaptiveness and humility. There is no magic formula to reconcile ambiguities. However, there is value in a self-questionnaire: One, do I listen enough? Two, do I shun cliques and gossip? Three, do my actions convey that the institution is bigger than myself? Four, are responsibilities clear so that there is tight accountability for results?

Our own epics suggest native wisdom regarding the resolution of disputes.

In the Mahabharata, Krishna undertook a peace mission to resolve the Pandava-Kaurava dispute over the rightful inheritance of the kingdom. Krishna proposed a compromise that the Pandavas would accept even a modest five villages. Duryodhana was adamant and arrogant. When disputes cannot be resolved by any means, undesirable war and annihilation follow. Peaceful negotiations should never be abjured.

In the Ramayana, Sugriva complains to Rama about his brother Vali’s unjust act of taking away his wife and kingdom. As a mediator, Rama listened to Sugriva, verified his claim, and took steps to restore the throne to him. Unfortunately, this meant killing Vali.

King Shibi’s story from the Mahabharata and the Jataka tales is redolent of a Biblical story (Book 1 Kings 3:16-28), in which King Solomon intervened in a dispute between two mothers claiming the same baby as their own. Shibi offered his own flesh to a predatory hawk to protect a fleeing, innocent dove. The denouement of the story demonstrates Shibi’s personal sacrifice to protect *rajadharma*.

Tata faces the Thucydides trap, whereby the very acquisition of power by two parties increases their chances of conflict. Herein lie the dilemmas for the Tata enterprise and philanthropy leaders. Our

Globally, the corporate world is seeing early signs of shared power rather than a single all-powerful CEO. Future CEOs may be less able to exercise unidimensional power

Government that swears by nari shakti keeps failing women



SHAMA MOHAMED

EQUALITY WAS one of the basic principles of India’s freedom movement. The country’s founding fathers strove for equality irrespective of religion, caste, or gender. They ensured that women got equal rights to vote, own property, and participate in public life. Independent India aspired to be a progressive nation that treated its women with dignity, respect, and justice. It is, therefore, disturbing that, as India approaches the 79th year of Independence, women’s safety remains in crisis. According to the Women, Peace and Security Index 2023, India ranks 131st out of 177 countries, placing it behind several of its regional peers. For a nation that prides itself on being a global power, this is a sobering reality.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has promised to implement the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, which seeks to increase women’s representation in legislatures. To fast-track it, the government introduced the 131st Amendment Bill, which couldn’t muster the required two-thirds majority. Today, the BJP seems to be using unfair means to break the TMC and the Shiv Sena to get that majority. A question must also be asked of the party whose leader has often used the “*Beti Bachao Beti Padhao*” slogan: What has it done for the security of women on the ground?

The case of Bilkis Bano offers a troubling answer. In August 2022, the 11 men convicted of gang-raping her during the 2002 Gujarat riots were released under a remission policy. Images of the convicts being garlanded upon release by some BJP members shocked the nation. The BJP MP from Dahod, Jaswantsinh Bhabhor, and his brother, the party’s MLA from Limkheda, Shaileshbhai Bhabhor, even shared the stage with Shailesh Chimanlal Bhatt, one of the 11 men convicted for gang-raping Bilkis Bano. All this gave the message that even in one of the country’s most notorious cases of sexual violence, justice appeared negotiable.

Similarly disturbing is the treatment of self-styled godman Asaram Bapu, who

is serving life sentences in two rape cases. He got parole recently and reportedly visited the Ram Mandir and delivered *satsangs* in Varanasi. What does this say about the government’s commitment to women?

Then there is Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, convicted of rape and murder, who has been granted parole on numerous occasions since his conviction in 2017. Parole decisions ultimately require the involvement of state authorities. The frequency with which such relief has been granted has fuelled concerns that political considerations often outweigh sensitivity toward victims and their families.

In 2023, several friends from other countries called me to ask why PM Modi was not listening to India’s celebrated women wrestlers, including Olympic medalists, who had accused BJP MP and then Wrestling Federation of India chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh of sexual harassment. Instead of receiving swift justice, the athletes found themselves protesting on the streets of the national capital. The images of the wrestlers being detained by the police while the accused remained politically influential sparked outrage both within India and abroad.

The broader statistics paint an equally troubling picture. Crimes against women remain alarmingly high, with hundreds of thousands of cases registered annually. According to the National Crime Records Bureau, in 2023, 15,000 dowry cases were recorded, with 6,100 deaths — a 14 per cent increase from the previous year. Cases of crimes against women rose from 4.45 lakh in 2022 to 4.48 lakh in 2023.

In which civilised nation is this acceptable? In numerous cases of dowry deaths, domestic violence, sexual assault, and harassment, women continue to face harassment and conviction rates often remain low. It is time for society to show the BJP government the mirror and hold it accountable.

The writer is national spokesperson, Indian National Congress

memories are jogged by two long-forgotten Greek and Turkish stories.

Emperor Darius II ruled the Persian Empire for 17 years, from 421 to 404 BCE, with two sons, Artaxerxes the Elder and Cyrus the Younger. Artaxerxes had the credential of primogeniture and was named as successor to Darius II. Cyrus was born after Darius II became king, hence he was “born into the purple”. Persian scholars opined that Cyrus could succeed Darius II. Both felt entitled. Cyrus mounted a battle against Artaxerxes by recruiting Xenophon, along with 10,000 mercenaries. Xenophon was a great warrior, strategist, and philosopher. However, Cyrus died in battle. Artaxerxes ruled Persia for four decades.

What is relevant in this story is how conversations, congruence, and commitment proved fruitful among people with low spirits and strongly held differing opinions when Xenophon led his fractious men out of enemy territory. He reframed the narrative, invoked ancestral pride, and encouraged rich conversations to achieve convergence and commitment. He was scholarly and had been a student of the wise Socrates. He was selfless but understood that it takes more than altruism to be an effective leader. That is how Xenophon learnt the 4C lesson on conflict resolution — converting conflict into conversations, convergence, and commitment. How can opinionated leaders converse or converge while deeply embedded in power, ambition, and glory? History is useful only if we heed the lessons.

Among the Ottomans, the temporal and the spiritual were combined in one leader, who acted as Sultan-cum-Caliph for centuries. The temporal had to succeed for the spiritual to be effective. During the 1914-1918 war, Sultan Mehmed VI was Ottoman Sultan-cum-Caliph. The temporal failed; Turkey became a republic and ceased to have a Sultan. Thereafter, Abdulmejid II became

Caliph, but only for a short time. The lesson is that there is strength in unity, and the success of the temporal is a sine qua non for the spiritual to be effective.

In the 1990s, Lou Gerstner arrived at IBM with a hugely adaptive and inclusive approach; however, Carly Fiorina is held out as having the right strategy but being less inclusive. The lesson for leaders is that they must combine the skills of heart and mind artfully because one or the other skill alone has less chance of success. Hubris poisons the minds of leaders. Gerstner captured his experience through *Who Says Elephants Cannot Dance*, and Fiorina through *Tough Choices*. Xenophon wrote *Anabasis*, from which I quote: “Your obstacles are not rivers or mountains or other people; your obstacle is yourself”.

Conflicting opinions and resultant conflicts have tested leaders forever. During the US President’s visit to China recently, following several months of aggressive statements, both leaders opted for “constructive strategic stability”. The 4Cs of conflict resolution always help in reducing differences of opinion and personality, though with no guarantee of results.

Recall Plato, “Opinion is the lowest form of knowledge. It requires no accountability, no understanding... highest knowledge requires purpose larger than the self.” Many centuries later, Ernest Hemingway famously said, “It takes two years to learn to speak and sixty years to learn to keep quiet.”

Although what we write appears simple and obvious, think about how often leaders ignore such obvious simplicity. There is magic in the journey from conflict to conversation, and on to convergence and commitment. In every case, the institution should be treated as bigger than the individual leaders.

The writers were both directors of Tata Sons and its several companies, both together for over seven decades

India must not wait for the next Hormuz crisis



ARYA ROY BARDHAN

IRAN’S CLOSURE of the Strait of Hormuz disrupted a route carrying roughly one-fifth of global oil supplies. Between February 27 and its March 31 peak, Brent crude surged 63.3 per cent. Global natural-gas futures rose as much as 16.7 per cent. India imports more than 88 per cent of its crude oil requirements. After Trump and Iran confirmed the MoU to halt the war on all fronts, Brent prices hit a three-month low.

India’s dependence on the strait was uneven yet extensive. Before the war, around 40 per cent of crude imports passed through it. The exposure was greater for gas. India imports approximately 60 per cent of the LPG it consumes, with 90 per cent of those imports travelling through Hormuz. So, over half of domestic consumption was stuck at the chokepoint. Similarly, Hormuz accounted for around 55-60 per cent of India’s LNG imports.

The blockade created a price shock and a supply shock. India’s crude imports fell 13 per cent between February and March, while inventories declined about 15 per cent after the war began. April crude-import volumes were 4.3 per cent lower year-on-year, but the amount paid for them surged 52.3 per cent. This captures the peculiar burden of an oil shock that leads to stagflation. LPG imports fell to nearly half their February level, while domestic LPG production declined around 10 per cent from its March peak. LNG imports contracted 29.6 per cent year-on-year in April. Substitution required longer routes and higher procurement costs.

April wholesale inflation rose to 8.3 per cent, with fuel-and-power inflation reaching 24.7 per cent and crude-petroleum inflation 88.1 per cent. The merchandise trade deficit widened from \$20.7 billion in March to \$28.38 billion in April. Consumer inflation remained relatively contained because retail petrol and diesel prices did not fully reflect the increase in crude costs. This insulation, however, transferred part of the burden from consumers to oil-marketing companies and the government.

The rupee weakened from roughly Rs 91 per dollar just before the war to a record low near Rs 97. Foreign-exchange reserves declined from a record \$728.5 billion on February 27 to \$681.6 billion by June 5, that is, a 6.4 per cent depletion. The crisis confronted the RBI with a policy dilemma. Raising interest rates to contain imported inflation would have weakened domestic demand and jeopardised India’s strong growth momentum. Defending the rupee through sustained dollar sales would have depleted foreign-exchange reserves. Yet inaction risked allowing higher energy, freight and input costs to spread across the economy.

A durable reopening of the strait relaxes these constraints. Lower crude prices reduce the import bill and inflationary pressures, support the rupee and give the RBI greater freedom for policy. But depleted inventories, replacement contracts, and delayed inflation pass-through will persist. Broader sourcing from Russia, the Americas and Africa can reduce dependence on any one route. Adopting renewable electricity, storage, electric mobility, and biofuels would reduce the economy’s petroleum intensity.

The writer is junior fellow, ORF

40 YEARS AGO

June 20, 1986



South Africa sanctions vetoed

DESPITE INDIA’S plea not to send out “wrong signals”, the US and UK killed a non-aligned move for sanctions against racist South Africa, which raided Angola’s Namibe port on June 5. The veto left Angola in “despair and frustration.” This was the second time in a month the Western powers cast a double veto to protect South Africa from sanctions.

Package deal on transfer likely

A PACKAGE deal is being worked out to solve the problem of effecting the simultaneous

transfer of Chandigarh and 70,000 acres of Punjab territory to Haryana. An official spokesman said the Centre was hopeful an amicable solution would be found by June 21.

Punjab Speaker roughed up

AN UNPRECEDENTED pandemonium in the Punjab Vidhan Sabha, caused by the raiding of the Speaker’s podium by irate dissident Akali members, led to the adjournment of the proceedings five times, for a total of nearly three hours. The trouble started when the Speaker, Surjit Singh Minhas, did not permit the dissident Akali members to raise points of

order on the agenda before the House.

Dismay over Gen Zia’s remarks

INDIA NOTED with “deep dismay” Pakistan President Zia ul Haq’s “baseless claim” that Benazir Bhutto and her Pakistan People’s Party were receiving funds from India to hold large public meetings in Pakistan. An MEA spokesman recalled that the former minister for external affairs, B R Bhagat, had on May 4 expressed astonishment that a head of state should make such baseless allegations, while at the same time repeatedly professing his keenness to improve India-Pakistan relations.



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● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
Western governments must ensure industrial policy does not turn into unchecked state expansion.
— *Financial Times*

A reply to CEA: What's missing in India is not ambition, but competition



NAUSHAD FORBES

THE CHIEF economic advisor, V Anantha Nageswaran, has written a two-part series in this paper on why Indian industry under-invests in R&D. His articles deserve deep consideration as the problem is vital. He says, "National and shareholder interests converge in the long run. The private sector that fails to recognise this convergence will eventually discover it the hard way." I agree with him that our industrial future and the national future depend on the willingness of Indian industry to invest strongly in in-house R&D for the long-term.

Nageswaran is also right when he says that the future of Indian industry depends not on the government but on "... decisions taken in corporate boardrooms: About R&D budgets, talent, the willingness to absorb short-term costs in pursuit of long-run competitive advantage". I have a different view, though, of both the sources of our problem and their remedies. I believe we need to complement his cultural argument with the right economics.

Nageswaran says that Indian industry is too inwardly focused on the Indian market: "Why develop a better product when the existing one sells readily?" The obvious remedy lies in economic policy, in a better trade policy: We should not protect the Indian market. The past 10 years have seen tariffs raised on over half the items we import. The best way to get Indian industry to "develop a better product" is to provide the option of buying a better imported one. We need to see our tariffs converge on the rates of Southeast Asia, Europe and the Far East, and the wholesale cancellation of quality control orders — import restrictions dressed up in a fancy phrase.

The argument that uncertainty deters long-term investment is, of course, right. This uncertainty, Nageswaran says, comes from "competitive popular democracy" and from external challenges (Covid, wars in Europe and Asia, the Trump tariffs). My argument would be that policy uncertainty

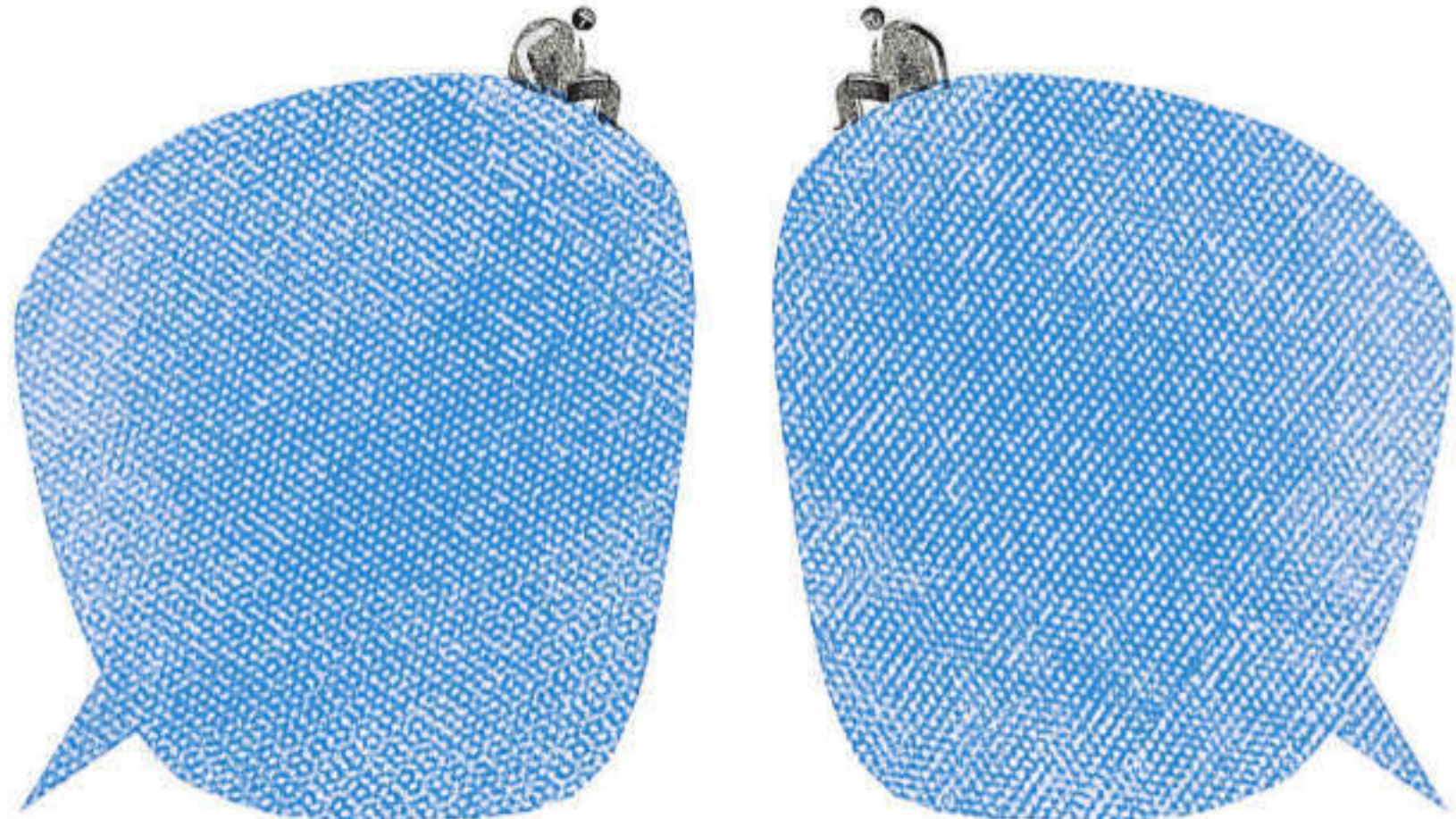


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

compounds this uncertainty we have no control over. Post 1991, we increasingly moved to the market determining prices, but there are too many areas where policy still chooses to play god. Domestic oil prices for consumers have increased 10 per cent when international oil prices have increased 50 per cent. Urea prices in India are a fraction of international prices. Prices determined by the market would drive conservation much more effectively than exhortation. To address our tariffs, if we provided a clear and credible timeline for their reduction to zero over, say, the next five years, it would give industry both the incentive to invest in building competitive advantage and the time to get newer capabilities in place.

Nageswaran repeats an allegation against family business: "The founder builds with hunger, the second generation consolidates, and by the third, the urgency has often dissipated." This allegation may be common, but it is wrong. As any careful study of family business shows, if one compares a 70-year-old professionally run firm with a family business in the third generation, also around 70 years old, one finds just as much diversity in performance and ambition. A family business I know intimately celebrated its centenary last month. I can vouch for the fourth generation having just as much ambition and na-

We need the reforms that will, again, unleash the ambition of all of Indian industry, not just of the Tatas, Ambani and Adani. The reform express must leave the station

tional commitment as the first generation in 1926. You may say that is an anecdotal argument of one business, which is true, but the allegation is based on equally anecdotal evidence. The best argument in favour of family business is provided by Nageswaran himself. He cites a study that found US public firms were much more concerned about short-run results than private firms, and so, invested less. The long-term outlook of family business is — worldwide — its greatest attribute. Thinking in generations instead of quarters can greatly enhance the willingness to invest in long-run technical capability.

The sources identified by him affect long-run investment in general. That is not, in my view, Indian industry's problem. It is investment specifically in R&D. Take our three largest groups — the Tatas, the Ambanis and the Adani group. Each has committed hundreds of thousands of crores for capacity in everything from semiconductor to infrastructure to alternative energy to petrochemicals. But except for a few Tata companies, their investments in technology remain limited. We need to understand why they underinvest in R&D when they are willing to invest for the long term in new capacity. Industrial policy must, however, enable the ambition of all Indian industry, not just a few large groups.

When *The Indian Express* asked me to write, the idea was to reflect on

the recent SpaceX listing and consider why we do not see the same backing of an idea at a grand scale that this listing represents. I believe that question is in the same league as questions around why we do not have our own Google or Apple.

I have spent over 40 years studying how nations and firms become innovative. Building technical capability is a hard slog; it has to be learnt step by step. If I think of our own firm, we started investing significantly in R&D in 1991 to develop new products different from everyone else. We had a well-qualified team, but one primarily focussed on indigenisation. It took us three years before we got our first moderately successful product out, five or six years before we learnt enough to count on a flow of innovative new products, year on year. The results show in success, in India and overseas. But we are still learning: Focussed now on deepening technical capability with a closer connection with academic research, in India and overseas.

Our story is also the story of firms in South Korea and Taiwan, which built R&D capabilities step by step, starting in the 1970s. Today, we might admire TSMC or Samsung, with their trillion-dollar valuations reflecting long-term commitments to R&D. But those reflect decades of growing investment in R&D, beginning with incremental process innovation, moving onto incremental product innovation, and only in recent years operating at the cutting edge of the latest developments in technology. I do not know how to short-circuit this process. Perhaps the newer US tech firms, with experienced tech entrepreneurs using their fortunes to back billion-dollar start-ups, will prove to be the exception. But I would still push for Indian industry to learn, step by step, how to invest in R&D and make new products a rising share of future success.

Let me return to policy: The trigger for our choice in Forbes Marshall to invest in R&D in 1991 was the Narasimha Rao/Mamohan Singh reforms. The reforms delivered a new and powerful trajectory for our firm, triggering us to take decisions that increased R&D budgets, and a willingness to absorb short-term costs in pursuit of long-run competitiveness. We need the reforms that will, again, unleash the ambition of all of Indian industry, not just of the Tatas, Ambani and Adani. The reform express must leave the station.

The writer is co-chairman, Forbes Marshall

Buffers built in past decade shielded economy from energy shock



ANIL BALUNI

AT THE start of 2026, the global economy faced its deepest and most perilous disruption in a generation. Yet, India stood as a defiant beacon of stability under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. At a time when the global economy is faltering, Modi has not only ensured that India remains the world's fastest-growing major economy with a GDP growth of 7.7 per cent, but has also positioned the country as a pivotal anchor of the global system.

This was the result of strategic policies implemented under the Modi government, which spent a decade building defensive buffers. It focused on accumulating foreign exchange reserves, providing the RBI with ammunition to stabilise the currency. It had also diversified its crude oil procurement channels, which helped lower its absolute dependence on West Asian supply routes.

The strategic vision extended into domestic infrastructure. From the outset, the Prime Minister prioritised developing piped natural gas infrastructure across Tier-I and Tier-II cities to secure energy supply and shield citizens from cooking-gas shortages. Now, this network is scaling into rural areas. Initiatives like the PM Surya Ghar Yojana, clean nuclear energy developments, and ethanol-blended petrol demonstrate that a visionary approach can create solutions to complex energy challenges and logistical bottlenecks.

The geopolitical crisis culminated in a total shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz, triggering what the IMF classified as the largest oil-supply shock ever recorded. On paper, no country appeared more structurally vulnerable to this energy shock than India, which relies on imports for nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements. Furthermore, roughly 61 per cent of India's Liquefied Natural Gas is sourced directly from West Asia. Standard economic models dictated that a blockade would devastate India's fiscal health, spark hyperinflation in food supply chains, and flatten its growth trajectory.

Rather than succumbing to the crisis, India achieved a stunning real GDP growth rate of 7.7 percent in 2025-26 thanks to the leadership of PM Modi. This was the highest growth rate recorded by any major economy in the world during that period. While rival global economies decelerated under the weight of surging energy costs, India under PM Modi accelerated, refusing to stumble despite facing a direct hit to its core vulnerabilities.

A deeper look reveals a permanent upgrade to India's industrial engine. The manufacturing sector delivered spectacular double-digit growth. Simultaneously, India's focus on self-reliance manifested in its defence industry. The annual defence production had surged to an all-time high of Rs 1.78 lakh crore during 2025-26. Furthermore, the massive deployment of next-generation digital infrastructure over the past decade enabled targeted, swift policy responses. Through infrastructure spending and steady income growth, the domestic market deepened. When international trade networks seized up, India's massive domestic market stepped in. By maintaining a conservative monetary framework, the government ensured that the RBI retained the flexibility to intervene when it mattered most.

The global financial community took note of India's triumph. At the peak of the West Asia crisis, IMF Chief Economist Pierre-Olivier Gourinchas commended the country's performance, stating that India "has been doing very, very well". The World Bank's April 2026 India Development Update concluded that India "remains among the fastest-growing major economies in the world". World Bank President Ajay Banga said India "has demonstrated that it can show exceptional growth", pointing to its forex reserves, low domestic inflation, healthy banking sector, and a public debt structure denominated predominantly in its own rupee.

Domestically, this vitality was validated by real-time data. Rising GST collections provided a real-time indicator that the domestic economy was generating substantial internal commercial activity rather than simply surviving the external shock.

The crisis of 2026 put India to the ultimate test, and the nation answered with an acceleration rather than a stumble. While the government built the vital macroeconomic buffers, this "resilience dividend" ultimately belongs to the people of India — driven by the daily actions of farmers, entrepreneurs, and consumers. Through a powerful combination of visionary leadership and domestic resolve, India converted a global energy crisis into a definitive demonstration of its economic sovereignty.



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

The writer is Lok Sabha MP (Garhwal, Uttarakhand) and national media head, BJP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Iran deal

IF THE start of the US-Iran war was an unexpected development for many, the truce is in line with the expectations of billions worldwide ("Look beyond winners and losers in US, Iran, IE, June 19). The war brought only destruction, loss of life, and the waste of resources that could have been utilised for the betterment of life on Earth. The result is that Iran has had to toil to restore normalcy, whereas the US, whose economy has already suffered, has to commit resources to rebuilding.

Jiji Panicker K, Alappuzha

Rights or reform

THE FIRST Amendment adjusted the constitutional balance so the state could pursue urgent social reforms ("75 years on, the First Amendment still casts a long shadow", IE, June 19). It helped clear the path for abolishing *zamindari* and reducing landlord power, which meant millions of small farmers gained more secure rights to their land. It also reinforced the legal basis for affirmative action. None of this makes the amendment above criticism. The risks to free speech and judicial checks are real and must be guarded against. But it is also important to recognise the amendment's human impact: it enabled policies that changed lives, often for the better.

Arshnoor, Chandigarh

Burden on teachers

SCHOOLS, ESPECIALLY government schools, have been reduced to mere buildings ("For teachers, the last period never arrives", IE, June 19). Teachers are burdened with non-academic tasks and are expected to teach effectively at the same time. Teaching has been given such a broad interpretation that its core meaning has been lost somewhere in the hustle and bustle of opening bank accounts, distributing incentives, conducting census work, handling payments, and preparing reports.

Ankita Mishra, Ranchi



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

KARNATAKA HOME Minister Priyank Kharge's letter to the chief of the RSS, Mohan Bhagwat, has dominated the news. "Under which Indian law is the RSS functioning?" Kharge cribbed, demanding that the RSS must clarify its "legal status, registration, office bearers, funding, expenditure, taxation and permissions for public activities". Predictably, Bhagwat dismissed Kharge's letter as "politics" and refused to respond to it.

In a TV interview, Kharge insisted that all he was asking the RSS was to abide by the laws of the land. When the interviewer asked him what laws the RSS had violated, he had no answer. He said that he didn't know under which law the RSS was operating. Article 19 (1) (c) of the Constitution explicitly states, "All citizens shall have the right to form associations or unions or co-operative societies". It is this constitutional provision that gives the RSS the right to freely run its activities in the country.

Kharge's demand that the RSS produce its registration certificate is frivolous. The RSS has been operating in this country for the past 100 years, 75 of them under the Constitution. In the wake of the ban, on the false allegation of RSS involvement in Gandhi's murder, the Nehru gov-

Priyank Kharge's demand that the RSS should produce its registration certificate is frivolous

ernment demanded that it produce its constitution. The organisation duly complied in 1949. The constitution of the RSS, accepted as the basis by the government for lifting the ban, explained its *raison d'être* clearly, including the method of collecting funds.

RSS activities continued in the country thereafter as per the constitution it submitted to the government. PM Lal Bahadur Shastri invited the RSS chief, M S Golwalkar, for consultations during the 1965 war. When Golwalkar died in 1973, PM Indira Gandhi made an obituary reference in Parliament saying, "We have lost in Guru Golwalkar a famous personality, who was not a Member of this House. He held a respected position in the nation by the force of his personality and the intensity of his convictions." None of them ever asked why the RSS was not registered.

Under the 1961 Income Tax Act, the RSS was legally recognised as a "Body of Individuals", an informal group of citizens operating as a body without being incorporated as a company, a public trust or a registered society. In its constitution, the RSS explained the fundraising method saying that "On the 'Vyas Poomima' function of every year or any other sacred day fixed for the purpose, every branch will celebrate the 'Dakshina Day' and will receive voluntary offerings." It also stated

Where have all the children's films gone?



KRITIKA MEHTA

INDIAN CHILDREN have never had more screens competing for their attention. Yet in the world's most prolific film-producing nation, few movies are made specifically for them. Paradoxically, children are everywhere in Indian cinema — as symbols of innocence, subjects of anxiety, or catalysts for adult transformation. But much rarer are films that allow children to be protagonists of their own stories, with their own ways of seeing the world.

The neglect is not historical. In 1955, eight years after Independence, the Children's Film Society, India (CFSI) was launched. The first film it produced, *Jaldeep* (1956), won the

Best Children's Film prize at the Venice Film Festival in 1957. Over the next decades, it produced more than 250 films, documentaries, animation and puppet films in Indian languages, while organising subsidised screenings across the country. A young republic, struggling with food shortages and with industrial ambitions, found the bandwidth to worry about what its children watched. Strikingly, some of India's finest filmmakers chose to make them. Satyajit Ray's *Goopy Gyne Bagha Byne*, Sai Paranjpye's *Jadu Ka Shankh*, and later films like *Halo*, *The Blue Umbrella*, *Makdee*, *I Am Kalam* and *Stanley Ka Dabba* treated children as audiences worthy of complexity and artistic ambition.

The decline of that ecosystem was gradual. Following the merger of CFSI into larger institutional structures in 2022, children's cinema lost one of its few dedicated cham-

pions. Producers argue that children's films are commercially difficult, that they rarely guarantee blockbuster returns. Those concerns are not entirely unfounded. But such a risk alone cannot explain the neglect. The industry invests crores in franchise launches and star vehicles whose success is far from guaranteed. Children's cinema, in contrast, is rarely given such opportunities.

Audience behaviour tells a different story.

Across major markets, children's and family films are among the most reliable performers. What has weakened is the ecosystem for developing, distributing and exhibiting them

Across major markets, children's and family films are among the most reliable performers in theatres and on streaming platforms. What has weakened is the ecosystem for developing, distributing and exhibiting them. Yet creativity has persisted. Some of the most significant work in children's cinema is emerging from regional industries. This year, the Manipuri film *Boong*, directed by Lakshmi Priya Devi, became the first Indian film to win the BAFTA award for Best Children's and Family Film. Before that, *Naal 2* and *Sumi* (Marathi), *Gandhi & Co.* (Gujarati), *Momo* in Dubai (Malayalam), and *Kundan Satti* (Tamil) demonstrated the richness of stories told through the eyes of children. Yet most of them circulated through festivals and limited screenings, struggling to secure theatrical release or sustained distribution. The gap is particularly striking in anima-

tion. India is a global hub for animation, VFX and digital production, yet it has produced few original animated works. While countries such as Japan have built enduring institutions like Studio Ghibli, India's animation success remains largely measured in services rendered rather than stories created.

Filmmaker Hrishikesh Mukherjee once warned that without good children's films, the future of adult cinema would be bleak. Nearly 430 million Indians are below the age of 18. India often speaks of this demographic dividend and its aspiration to become a global storytelling power. Those ambitions will ring hollow if one of the world's largest child populations continues to inherit a film culture with so little to say to them.

The writer is assistant film research officer, FTII, Pune. Views are personal

STATE GOVT CHALLENGES ACQUITTAL

Complainant had to face trial-like scrutiny: Goa to HC in Tejpal case

‘Was asked about views on drinking, sex... she was forthright in testimony’

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, June 19

CHALLENGING THE acquittal of Tarun Tejpal, the former editor-in-chief of Tehelka who was accused of sexually assaulting his then colleague in a Goa hotel in 2013, the Goa government on Friday argued before the High Court that the complainant in the case was virtually put on trial, but remained “sterling”, “steadfast” and “forthright” in her testimony.

The woman had complained that Tejpal sexually assaulted her in the hotel elevator on November 7 and 8, 2013. In 2021, a sessions court in Goa acquitted Tejpal of all charges, observing that the complainant “did not demonstrate any kind of normative behaviour” that a victim of sexual assault “might plausibly show”. The Goa government subsequently filed an appeal in the High Court of Bombay at Goa challenging the acquittal, and arguments in the case are ongoing.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state government, told the High Court that during her cross-examination, the complainant was virtually put on trial. “She was being targeted that you are drinking, you are smoking, you don’t believe that sex is a taboo... and she said, yeah, it’s not a taboo, provided it is consensual,” he said.

Citing statements from her testimony, he said when the defence counsel posed a question on whether it is immoral to have consensual sex with different persons, the witness in her response said she did not



Tarun Tejpal

believe there was anything immoral about consensual sex. “See the truthfulness of this witness... She says that consensual sex is not wrong, provided there is consent... an untruthful witness would say... no, it is bad, it is not good for society. She is forthright,” he said.

He said when the defence counsel put up a question on whether it is immoral to consume alcohol voluntarily or smoke cigarettes voluntarily, the witness replied that there is nothing immoral about it, if someone is an adult and it does not violate their religion. “This is what a true witness, what is called a sterling witness, answers... Whenever put a luring question when she can improve upon her version, she has resisted it. She has remained sterlingly steadfastly the same from day one. She was virtually put on trial, as if she is kind of a woman of easy virtue...,” he said.

The state government had on Thursday told the High Court that the trial court had done everything “which it could not have done and ought not to have done” in the case, and the manner in which it dealt with the sensitive case was “perturbing”.

Last seen in a mall in Finland, Hyderabad teen goes missing

Nikhila Henry

Hyderabad, June 19

THE LAST image of Manideep Reddy Gujja that Finland police got was of him casually walking along the aisles of a shopping mall in Helsinki, about 100 kilometres from his residence in Lahti, on May 5. The 18-year-old has been missing ever since, and his parents have approached the Telangana High Court, seeking directions to authorities to trace their son.

Originally from Hyderabad, Gujja was a student of the University of Lappeenranta-Lahti University of Technology (LUT) in Finland and regularly attended classes, his parents, Mamata Reddy and G Muthyam Reddy, said.

“He never really socialised. His day began with college and

ended at the living quarters, which he shared with his roommate,” Mamata said.

On May 5, according to his parents, Gujja asked for Rs 5,000. “He called me to ask for this small amount of money, and I transferred it,” his mother said. Since then, using about Rs 2,500, he travelled for over 100 kilometres by bus and reached Helsinki, Finnish police found. The reason for the journey remains a mystery. In Helsinki, he was seen having a bite at an eatery and walking into a shopping mall. His phone became unreachable shortly afterwards. “We don’t know what happened to him,” his mother said, weeping.

Gujja had moved to Finland in 2025 to study to become an engineer. “We thought that he would come back and do well in a good job,” the mother said.

3 indigenously built naval ships to be commissioned tomorrow

Dunagiri is stealth frigate, *Agray* anti-submarine warfare craft and *Sanshodhak* is survey vessel

Amrita Nayak Dutta

New Delhi, June 19

THE INDIAN Navy will commission three indigenously built frontline platforms — *Dunagiri*, *Sanshodhak*, and *Agray* — in Kolkata on Sunday, and the ceremony will be presided over by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Dunagiri is an advanced stealth frigate, *Sanshodhak* is a survey vessel (large), and *Agray* is an anti-submarine warfare shallow water craft.

In a statement issued Friday, the Navy said the platforms represent key operational capabilities across maritime combat, hydrographic surveying, and anti-submarine warfare. They have



Dunagiri is equipped with advanced weapons and sensors, including BrahMos surface-to-surface missiles and the medium range surface-to-air missile system. PTI

been designed by the Indian Navy’s Warship Design Bureau and constructed by Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata.

“Together, they reflect the Navy’s balanced approach to capability development, strengthening blue-water operations, enhancing maritime domain awareness, and securing coastal waters against evolving threats,” it said.

Dunagiri, the fifth Project

17A stealth frigate, is equipped with advanced weapons and sensors, including BrahMos surface-to-surface missiles and the medium range surface-to-air missile system, significantly enhancing the Navy’s combat capability.

Sanshodhak, the fourth survey vessel (large), is designed for coastal and deep-water hydrographic surveys and collection of oceanographic and geophysical data

A day to go for NEET retest, 12 suicides in 37 days

Express News Service

June 19

AFTER TAKING the NEET exam on May 3, the 22-year-old told his father in a village in Rajasthan’s Jhunjhunu district that it had gone so well that even “God can’t stop me from qualifying”. So when a retest was announced later that month following a paper leak, the Dalit youth was distraught. Hedied by suicide three days later.

The 22-year-old was one of at least 12 students who died by suicide in the little over a month between the cancellation of NEET-UG 2026 on May 12 and the June 21 retest. The re-examination was ordered after the suspected leak of a 150-page ‘guess paper’ circulated in Rajasthan’s Sikar, with investigators finding links to an interstate network based in Maharashtra’s Latur.

All 12 aspirants were scheduled to take the June 21 retest. In at least five of the 12 cases, no suicide note was found.

Rajasthan

On May 18, the 22-year-old’s sister had gone to take a shower when he took the extreme step. “After his sister found him, he was rushed to a nearby hospital where he was declared dead,” his landlord said.

The son of a daily wage labourer, he lived in Sikar with one of his three sisters. Since his death, the family has refused to immerse his ashes in the Ganga until its demands are met, including Rs 2 crore aid and a government job for a sibling.

For another family in Sikar, June 15 began like any other day. That morning, the son of a Mumbai-based businessman re-

turned home after dropping his mother at their native village in Jhunjhunu and found that his brother and sister had left for coaching classes.

According to the police, the siblings returned in the evening to a quiet house and a suicide note that read: “I’m going away from this world, I’m sorry”. The 22-year-old had hanged himself from a ceiling fan.

Goa

In a note found at his home on May 12, the 17-year-old wrote that he “no longer wished to appear for competitive exams”. An athlete who had represented his school in several hockey tournaments, the teenager died by suicide between 10 pm and 11 pm that night, the police said.

While it remains unclear whether the suicide was linked to the exam cancellation, a panchanama recorded by police cites his family as attributing it to “pressure of exam performance”.

Uttarakhand

When the mother of the 24-year-old found her room locked on June 16, she panicked and immediately alerted her husband, a retired Army personnel, police said. She had not come out for breakfast that morning, and the family knew of the intense pressure she was under ahead of the June 21 retest.

When they forced open the door, they found her hanging from a ceiling fan with a dupatta. The suicide note she left was apologetic, police said. “I love you, Papa; I am sorry. This is not due to anyone’s fault; this is due to my incompetence,” the letter said.



An IAF Mi-17 helicopter takes part in a trial run ahead of the NEET-UG re-examination, in Tamil Nadu. The exercise was conducted as part of arrangements to airlift sealed question papers under enhanced security measures for the re-examination scheduled on June 21. PTI

Gujarat

A neighbour potted him lying by the building in a pool of blood past midnight on June 18. The 17-year-old had cut the pigeon net on his sixth-floor balcony before taking the plunge, police said.

“He died by the time the paramedics arrived,” Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) D.V. Rana of Ahmedabad’s L Division said.

For the family, the death came as a shock. “He was not only taking the NEET retest but had also applied for a pharmacy course,” his uncle said.

Tamil Nadu

Days before she was scheduled to take the retest, the 19-year-old from Coimbatore wrote a WhatsApp message voicing her distress about the exam. Having already taken it twice, she was uncertain of her chances and sent an emotional message to relatives saying she was

“afraid to take the test again”, police said. On June 17, the 19-year-old died by suicide. No suicide note was recovered, police said.

Madhya Pradesh

In a note to her parents, the 18-year-old from Mauganj district wrote about her shaken faith. The daughter of a cook in Nagpur, she knew her parents had taken a Rs 3 lakh loan to fund her education and believed she had to succeed.

When the retest was announced just days after she felt her exam had gone well, she found her strength waning, police said. On May 20, she died by suicide. According to police, she had appeared for NEET for the first time this May after preparing for several years at a coaching institute in Nagpur.

“She withdrew following the retest announcement,” her father said. “She felt all her hard work had gone to waste.”

Her fears would have been

Navy to get 12 sets of indigenous 1.25 MW gas turbine generators for Kolkata-class ships

Amrita Nayak Dutta

New Delhi, June 19

THE MINISTRY of Defence on Friday signed a contract with Bharat Forge Limited for the acquisition of 12 sets of 1.25 MW gas turbine generators at a cost of around Rs 425 crore for onboard power generation on Kolkata-class ships of the Indian Navy.

The marine gas turbine generators will have at least 60% indigenous content, and the contract will be executed over a period of five years.

The development is significant since the contract marks a major progress towards manufacturing indigenous marine gas turbine generators for Indian ships. So far, Indian warships have been fitted with marine gas turbine generators imported from Russia since the 1980s. Every warship has a combination of two to four marine gas turbine generators and marine diesel generators for power generation. However, over the last three years, the Navy has been working to indigenise gas tur-

bine parts and the compressor to reduce dependence on imports of spare parts for their maintenance and has been in talks with Indian firms. Work has been on to indigenise marine gas turbine generators by BHEL and Bharat Forge Limited.

In a statement issued Friday, the Defence Ministry said the procurement would enhance maritimeself-reliance in critical strategic technologies and bolster the Indian Navy’s operational readiness through indigenous production and end-to-end life-cycle support.

Separately, in a statement, Pune-based Bharat Forge Limited (BFL) said the 1.25 MW gas turbine generators will replace the lower-capacity units currently in service. “Awarded under the Buy (Indian) category of the Defence Acquisition Procedure 2020 (DAP-2020), the contract marks BFL’s entry into the marine gas turbine (GT) business — and will deliver the first indigenous GT-based power plant to operate aboard Indian Naval ships,” it added.

Lakhimpur Kheri took the May 3 exam, he was determined to make it through. This was his third attempt, and he had spent four years preparing in Lucknow. On May 14, he was found hanging in his room. No suicide note was found. While his family linked his death to the uncertainty surrounding the NEET examination, police suspect personal relationship issues may also have played a role.

New Delhi

“This is it,” the 20-year-old from Lal Bagh in North Delhi’s Azadpur told her family when she took the exam for the third time. This time, she was certain she would make it.

Then the exam was cancelled on May 12. Two days later, she was found hanging in her room. “Last year, she missed by just four marks. Her father had pinned all his hopes on her,” said her aunt.

Maharashtra

For as long as she could remember, the 18-year-old from Latur wanted to be a doctor. On May 25, she was found dead in Gondegaon village, with her father alleging that she had been under severe stress since the May 3 exam was cancelled. “She had performed well in the exam and the cancellation left her disturbed,” her father said.

[With inputs from Hamza Khan from Jaipur, Aiswarya Raj from Dehradun, Pavneet Singh Chadha from Panaji, Brendan Dabhi from Ahmedabad, Anand Mohan J from Bhopal, Arun Janardhanan from Chennai, Bhupendra Pandey and Manish Sahu from Lucknow, and Pragynesh from New Delhi]

Heatwaves leading to increased concentrations of ground-level ozone, aggravating health risks: Study

Amitabh Sinha

New Delhi, June 19

HEATWAVES ARE not just a direct threat to human health, they also drive up concentrations of ground-level ozone that sharply aggravate mortality risks, a new study by Indian researchers has shown. In 2024 alone, more than 830 deaths in India could be attributed to increased ozone concentrations caused by extreme heat, according to the study.

The study, ‘Heatwaves trigger severe surface ozone pollution in India: Regional Hotspots, Trends and Health Effects’, has been published in Clean Air, a part of Nature stable of journals, and is the first of its kind attempt to assess the health impacts of increased levels of surface-level ozone concentrations due to heatwaves in India.

Ozone is naturally produced, and found, in the middle atmosphere, at an altitude between 15 km and 50 km from



People use a cloth to shield themselves from the scorching heat on a hot summer day, in Lucknow on Friday. ANI

the Earth’s surface. This ozone protects the Earth from the harmful ultraviolet rays in the sunlight. It absorbs these rays, acting as a natural sunscreen for the Earth. But ozone close to the ground is an air pollutant. Surface-level ozone is not naturally produced, but is by-product of chemical reactions between other common air pollutants like nitrogen oxides (NOx) and volatile organic compounds

(VOCs) in the presence of sunlight. Heat has the effect of accelerating these reactions.

“Ozone concentrations of about 30 parts per billion (ppb) at the ground level is usually considered safe. In most parts of India, this background ozone concentration is around 50-55 ppb. This is particularly true of northwestern India and the Gangetic plains, which carries a very high pollution load. Dur-

ing heatwaves, the ozone concentration is driven up even higher,” said Jayanarayanan Kuttippurath, an associate professor at the Centre for Ocean, River, Atmosphere and Land Sciences at IIT Kharagpur, who authored the study, along with Parambat Sangeetha of Kerala University of Fisheries and Ocean Studies, Kochi.

Exposure to ozone affects lungs and heart, and can lead to Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD) and Ischemic Heart Disease (IHD), apart from cancer and diabetes. A large number of deaths, in tens of thousands every year, is already associated with ozone exposure. The State of Global Air report for 2025 had said there were about 234,000 COPD deaths in India in 2023 in which ozone exposure was the aggravating factor.

Heatwaves are now exacerbating the problem. The summer months in India are generally a relief from air pollution, but the rise in ozone con-

centrations could be adding a new threat.

“Under climate change scenarios, because of general increase in temperatures all across, more and more regions are likely to have high concentrations of ozone. The frequency and severity of heatwaves is expected to rise, and so would the threat from ozone exposure,” Prof. Jayanarayanan said.

He said agencies like the India Meteorological Department (IMD), or the Central Pollution Control Bureau (CPCB), needed to extensively monitor the concentrations of ground-level ozone, as actively as they do for a number of other parameters, and include this information in their bulletins and alerts.

The increased levels of ozone caused by heatwaves persists for about three to four days on an average after the end of the heatwave, the study said based on their analysis of data over the last 21 years.

Accused of threatening Patna family, FIR filed against Tej Pratap

Himanshu Harsh

Patna, June 19

AN FIR has been filed against former Bihar minister Tej Pratap Yadav following a complaint that he allegedly forced himself into a home in Patna, demanding to see his “daughter”, and threatened the family there when they resisted. Yadav has rejected the allegations as “false and fabricated”.

An FIR was filed on the basis of the complaint filed by a man, who claimed that Yadav and an aide allegedly attempted to force their way into the house of the complainant and demanded to see a toddler, whom the former minister referred to as his daughter.

This comes more than a year after a social media controversy involving Tej Pratap Yadav and a woman linked to the complainant’s family.

According to the complainant, when the family purportedly refused to allow Yadav



Ex-Bihar minister rejects allegations, calls them ‘false and fabricated’

to meet the child, he allegedly threatened to have her abducted. He also allegedly invoked his political influence, claimed that no FIR would be registered against him, and warned the family against approaching the police, as per the complaint. The complainant claimed that later, he received a call from a person who claimed to have links to the Lawrence Bishnoi gang.

When contacted, Patna ASP (Law and Order) Divyanjali Jaiswal confirmed that the FIR had been registered and said

the complainant had alleged that the threat call came from a US number. She said police were examining CCTV footage, call records and voice notes, and were also investigating the alleged Bishnoi gang link.

Rejecting the allegations, Tej Pratap Yadav said in a social media post: “It is extremely unfortunate that the person who was legally served a notice regarding his abusive, threatening and anti-social behaviour has, instead of admitting his mistake or expressing regret, attempted to get a false and concocted FIR registered against me out of revenge”. He said he had “full faith in the judiciary” and would not be intimidated.

The FIR follows a social media controversy last year after a Facebook post from Tej Pratap Yadav’s account claimed a long relationship with a woman. The leader later said his account had been hacked, but the post led his father Lalu Prasad to expel him from party.



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• MARKETS

Accenture sends a signal: Tough times for Indian IT

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 19

THE INDIAN IT sector felt the aftershocks of a weaker global technology spending environment, with shares of major domestic IT services companies tumbling by as much as 8% intraday on Friday. The sharp decline followed disappointing signals from global technology and consulting giant Accenture, which late on Thursday cautioned about a softer demand outlook in the months ahead.

Why Accenture's outlook matters

The Irish IT powerhouse cut its revenue guidance for the financial year ending August 2026 to between 3-4% from the previous forecast of 3-5% in constant currency terms. The company also flagged on its earnings call that client budgets remain lukewarm despite higher AI spending and that demand for its consultancy services remains weak.

Accenture's commentary is closely watched by investors as it is often seen as a bellwether for the global IT services industry. The company indicated that clients remain cautious on discretionary technology spending amid ongoing macroeconomic uncertainties, raising concerns

about the pace of recovery in enterprise technology budgets.

• Market impact	
Nifty IT index	3.7% ↓
Infosys	6.5% ↓
TCS	3.06% ↓
Tech Mahindra	2.33% ↓
Wipro	1.28% ↓

*END OF SESSION ON JUNE 19, 2026

demand environment flagged by global IT majors would also mean weak earnings growth for top Indian players.

What this means for Indian IT companies

The subdued outlook sparked fears in the already battered Indian tech industry that demand conditions could remain challenging for outsourcing and digital transformation projects. The warning reverberated across Indian technology stocks — hit by the technology advancements in the AI segment — with investors rushing to reassess growth expectations for the sector.

Subsequent to Accenture's results, Indian IT services majors fell as much as 8% in early trade on Friday before recovering. This pushed the overall market down as well.

"Accenture has effectively confirmed that clients remain highly cautious with their wallets. Because Indian IT firms rely heavily on the same global pipeline for discretionary tech projects, this shift in Accenture's forecast serves as a macroscopic warning for the entire sector, prompting investor selloffs," said Shashwat Singh, fundamental analyst at Bajaj Broking.

Global financial services firm Citi also said it remains cautious on the Indian IT sector. It cited factors such as AI disruption, increased competitive intensity and the West Asia conflict. Nomura said that the conflict could affect revenues and deal bookings in the first quarter of FY 2027, which could continue in the subsequent quarter.

Additionally, the US Federal Reserve's latest commentary this week drove expectations of rate hikes by the Fed in the coming months, including at least one in 2026. Higher interest costs may further dampen the spending of US-based companies on IT outsourcing, the major revenue source for most IT companies, as companies look to also maintain high AI spends.



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Karol Bagh	29 जून शाम 6:00 बजे	29 June 11:30 AM
Noida	29 जून शाम 6:00 बजे	29 June 8:30 AM
Indore	22 जून सुबह 8:00 बजे	24 June 5:30 PM
Lucknow	29 जून शाम 6:00 बजे	24 June 11:30 AM
Prayagraj	29 जून शाम 5:30 बजे	23 June 8:00 AM
Ranchi	एडमिशन आरंभ	Admissions Open
Patna	17 जून सुबह 8:00 बजे	29 June 5:30 PM
Jaipur	24 जून सुबह 11:00 बजे	6 July 8:00 AM

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• CLIMATE

The key hurdle to climate targets: Electrification



AMITABH SINHA

THE MID-YEAR climate talks in Bonn, Germany, that ended this week failed to make much headway on any contentious issue, but did throw up one interesting proposal.

Turkey, which will host the year-ending climate conference COP31 this year, proposed that the world should aim to meet at least a third of its energy needs from electricity by 2035 to reduce emissions. As of now, only about 20% of the world's final energy consumption is met through electricity.

Turkey has suggested that all countries agree to adopt this goal as one of the outcomes from the COP31 conference, which it is hosting together with Australia in the Turkish city of Antalya in November.

The electrification target, if agreed upon, would be one more addition to several other climate-related global goals that are already in place, the foremost being the temperature targets contained in the Paris Agreement. The 2015 Paris Agreement says the world must strive to limit the rise in global temperatures within 2 degrees Celsius, preferably 1.5 degrees Celsius, from pre-industrial times.

The COP (Conference of Parties) climate meetings that are held every year have yielded a few more of these targets — such as increasing the installed capacity of renewable energy, achieving a global net-zero emissions, mobilising climate finance.

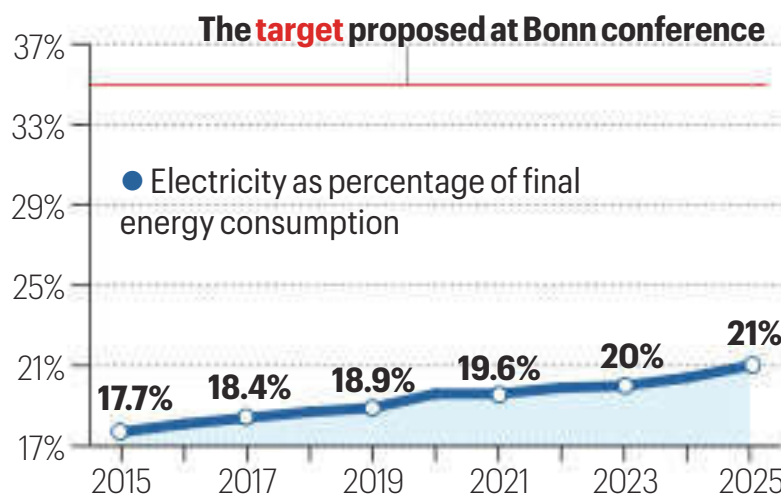
These are all aimed at reducing the world's dependence on fossil fuels and speeding up the process of energy transition, which is the only effective long-term solution for climate change.

Electrification is at the heart of this energy transition. In fact, a complete energy transition, from fossil fuels such as oil, gas and coal, to cleaner sources such as wind and solar, is not even possible without full electrification. Tracking the electrification rate, therefore, is a good measure of the progress on energy transition. It also encapsulates the enormity of the climate challenge better than any other metric.

The electrification challenge

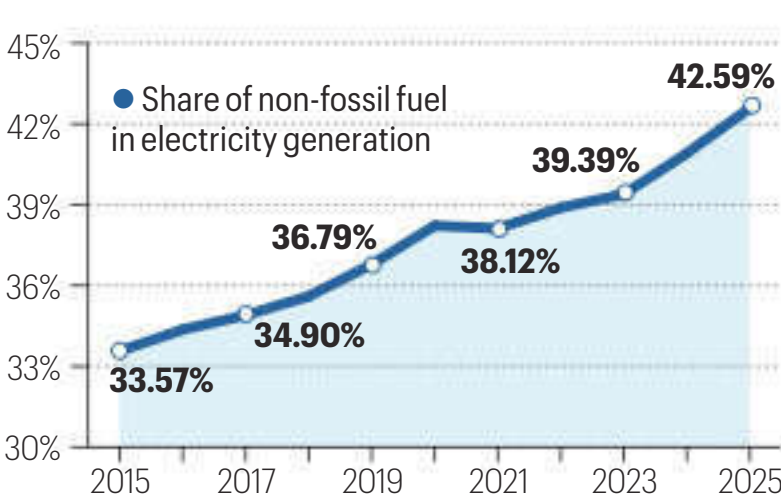
Climate change is the result of global warming which is caused by greenhouse gas emissions. Emissions come primarily from burning fossil fuels such as coal, oil, gas and wood, which are the main sources

• LONG ROAD TO 35% ELECTRIFICATION TARGET



SOURCE: INTERNATIONAL ENERGY AGENCY

• STEADY PROGRESS ON CLEAN POWER



of energy. A solution to the climate crisis, therefore, involves replacing these traditional sources of energy with newer and cleaner sources such as solar, wind, nuclear or hydropower, which have a much smaller carbon footprint. This is the great energy transition that the world has to go through to deal with the climate crisis.

It is not immediately obvious, but there is a fundamental difference between fossil fuels and the newer energy sources that have to replace them. Fossil fuels are direct sources of energy. They only require to be burnt to produce energy. Renewables, however, have to be converted into electricity before they can be put to use.

Replacing fossil fuels with the cleaner sources means that the only way energy would eventually be available would be in the form of electricity. That, in turns, means that every final use of energy would have to be electrified.

Considering how ubiquitous electricity has become, and the transformative impact it has had on the world in the last century and a half, it sometimes comes as a surprise that as of now, electricity meets only a small fraction of the world's total energy needs. According to the International Energy Agency (IEA), electricity accounted for only 21% of the total final energy consumption (TFEC) in the year 2025. In India, the corresponding figure is about 23%, according to government data.

TFEC, or FEC, is a measure of energy that is ultimately used. It excludes all the energy that is consumed in producing, transforming or transporting energy itself. The coal that is burnt to produce electricity, or the energy used for refining petroleum, the diesel burnt for transporting fuel trucks, or the transmission and distribution losses in elec-

A reality check

Only about 20% of the world's energy needs, or 'final energy consumption', is met through electricity.

• Only around 42% of this electricity is generated through clean sources.

• This means that just a little over 8% of the total energy consumed in the world now is clean.

tricity, are not counted in FEC. All these are included in another metric called Total Primary Energy Supply, or TPES, which is a measure of total energy available for use.

Over the years, the amount of electricity being generated, globally, has increased from about 24 terrawatt-hours (TWh) in 2015 to over 32 TWh in 2025, a rise of nearly 33%. But the share of electricity in FEC has had a more modest rise during this period, from 17.7% in 2015 to 21% in 2025.

This is because a large number of sectors and processes are still difficult to electrify. Shipping and aviation, heavy-duty and long-haul trucks, many high-temperature processes in industries like iron and steel, cement, glass and ceramics, and even many residential needs like heating have remained largely unelectrified. This means these processes still cannot run on renewables.

Staring at a crisis

But this is not all. Electricity itself continues to be generated primarily by fossil fuels. In 2025, only about 42% of all the electricity in the world was generated by non-fossil fuel sources — renewables, hydro and nuclear — according to the IEA.

So, here is the stark reality. Only about 21% of total final energy consumption happens in the form of electricity. And only about 42% of electricity is generated through clean sources. That means that just a little over 8% of the total energy consumed in the world now is clean. After nearly three decades of efforts to promote cleaner fuels, through favourable policies, financial incentives, and technology innovation, more than 90% of the current global use of energy continues to depend on fossil fuels.

This is the enormity of the challenge that is not always evident in climate change



A large number of sectors and processes are still difficult to electrify. FILE

or energy transition discussions.

The road ahead is not smooth. Renewables are expected to continue to expand at a fast rate, no doubt, but the share of electricity in FEC is not projected to increase dramatically. According to the latest estimates from IEA, non-fossils (renewables plus hydro and nuclear) are likely to begin producing nearly half of the world's electricity by 2030. But the share of electricity in global FEC is expected to go up to only about 24% by 2030 from the current 21%.

An ambitious target

That is why Turkey's proposal to make efforts to increase it to 35% by 2035 is an ambitious target. The proposal is based on a recent roadmap prepared by the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA).

IRENA says a 35% electrification rate by 2035 is the minimum needed to entertain any hopes of keeping the world on the 1.5-degrees Celsius pathway. But to achieve that level of electrification, an investment of about \$1.2 trillion needs to be pumped into electricity systems every year. A number of other things, including rapid expansion in renewables, and battery storage systems, also need to happen.

It is unclear how wars and geopolitical tensions would affect energy transition. Greater uncertainty in supplies of fossil fuels, and rising oil prices, may force countries to push renewables. But the economic fallout of these wars might squeeze out the budgets available for investing in new technologies and infrastructure. Countries might be tempted to use whatever energy source is easily available to them, regardless of its climate impact.

• SPORT

Referee's cam: This World Cup, a different way of seeing the game

Diya George
New Delhi, June 19

IF YOU have been watching the 2026 FIFA World Cup, you would have noticed visuals from an angle that puts you as close to the centre of action as possible — the referee's point of view.

This has been made possible by the Referee Body Camera, being used in a World Cup for the first time. Referees in this year's edition have been given headsets equipped with small cameras, almost resembling mini CCTV cameras, which capture what FIFA calls "referee view".

Among the over 45 cameras recording every angle of a match at the World Cup, this one perhaps is the most unique.

Has anyone else tried it before?

The referee point-of-view camera is not an entirely new innovation. America's National Football League (NFL) was among the earliest sports leagues to use a referee

camera, as early as 2001. Cricket, too, offers the umpires' view during broadcasts.

The first organisation to introduce this technology in football was the German league — the Bundesliga — in 2024. FIFA itself used it at the 2025 Club World Cup, a precursor to its World Cup coverage. The same year, the Premier League trialled it during pre-season friendlies between English top flight teams before incorporating it into the broadcast set-up.

So, what is unique about the 2026 FIFA World Cup's referee camera?

The latest usage of the referee view has a subtle difference in comparison to its precursors. In previous iterations of the referee cam, the official's constant motion meant that visuals were far from stable. This World Cup, however, the footage is much more stable.

FIFA attributes this to its partnership with Lenovo, which uses AI to stabilise the footage in real time. According to FIFA, this has helped halve motion blur and thus offers



Referees in this year's World Cup wear headsets equipped with small cameras. AP

viewers a more stable viewing experience.

Initially introduced as a tool for the training and development of referees, the referee camera has garnered favourable reactions from the fans. Replays of the first goal of the tournament — Mexico's Julian Quinones' shot going through the legs of

South African goalkeeper Ronwen Williams — were widely shared on social media. The visuals from Lionel Messi's opener against Algeria offered a first-hand view of the master's wizardry. That aside, the referee camera has also offered humour enthusiasts a repertoire of memorable reactions, like the bemusement of France's Désiré Doué after a decision did not go his way in the match against Senegal.

What else does the headset include?

In addition to the camera, referees are also equipped with an audio device. The earpiece allows the referee to receive communications from the rest of the officiating team, including assistant referees, the fourth official, and the VAR room, ensuring that decisions and warnings are relayed instantly.

Internal communications aside, the mechanism also allows the referee to convey a VAR decision to the spectators via a microphone attached to the headset, while providing a justification for the same.

• GLOBAL

Drones, tech, European backing: How Ukraine is punching above its weight



EXPERT EXPLAINS

AMAN K PANDEY

PHD CANDIDATE AT CENTRE FOR RUSSIAN AND CENTRAL ASIAN STUDIES, JNU AND RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, INDIAN COUNCIL OF WORLD AFFAIRS, NEW DELHI

THE RUSSIA-UKRAINE conflict, which has now stretched longer than World War I, is witnessing a shift in gears.

The Ukrainians have halted the Russian summer offensive, and in May, Russia managed to gain only a fraction of the territory it won last year. Thursday's drone strikes on a Moscow refinery, probably the largest since the beginning of the war, showcase Ukraine's enhanced ability and willingness to hit Russia beyond the battle-

field. While the war may not end soon, Ukrainians are interpreting these incidents as momentum shifting in their favour.

At the core of Ukraine's resilience are its technological evolution, military prudence, bold strategic decisions, and a critical but underrated European commitment to Ukraine. It holds lessons in how technological evolution can help smaller powers sustain and prevail against major powers in asymmetrical conflicts.

Russia's stalled advances

Data from the Institute for the Study of War, a US think tank, shows Russia gained control of or infiltrated 40.64 sq km of Ukrainian territory between December 2025 and May 2026. In the same period, it lost 282.1 sq km of previously controlled territories. Between the same months in 2024-25, Russia had gained 515.84 sq km.

Ukraine has turned the frontline into an effective no-go zone, where any and every Russian movement is constantly watched and attacked. Since the Russians are the ones with offensive goals, their battlefield losses are naturally higher.



An oil refinery in Moscow after a Ukrainian drone attack on Thursday.

Part of this success has to do with drones, with Ukraine set to produce over seven million drones this year, a significant increase from four million drones produced

in 2025. The strategy is underpinned by its "fortress belt", a nearly 50 km region running north to south and concentrated around four Ukrainian cities of Sloviansk, Kramatorsk, Druzhkivka, and Kostiantynivka in the region of Donetsk.

Russia has failed to fully occupy this region of eastern Ukraine since 2014. Since then, this defensive line has only evolved to integrate traditional measures with new tactics and technologies to respond to Russia's continued attempts to push forward.

These cities serve as important logistics hubs. While its steeper elevation and water features favour defenders, Ukraine has also built an extensive network of fortifications that include trenches and mines. Controlling this belt would allow Russia to advance at least 80 km into Ukraine, at a time when its advances are measured in metres.

Tactics meet technology

Rapid technological advances on the battlefield revolving around uncrewed systems, electronic warfare, command and control, and surveillance have allowed Kiev to punch above its weight.

Aerial drones have been complemented by battery-operated, remote-controlled unmanned vehicles on the ground fitted with cameras to supply food and munitions, evacuate injured and dead soldiers, and conduct assaults on Russian positions.

These are part of a state-of-the-art digital kill chain, which is battle-tested and integrates sensors, operators, analysts, drone pilots, targeting cells and strike systems into one architecture. This reduces the time between identification, verification and strikes.

On the other hand, Russian operations mainly consist of air strikes, artillery and missile attacks to create gaps in the Ukrainian defensive positions. To counter this, Ukrainian forces operate in small and dispersed groups backed by integrated air defence systems and interceptor drones. Soldiers are also equipped with counter-drone systems, such as jammers, against the Russian first-person view (FPV) drones.

Ukraine is now working to integrate AI in creating a system of remotely operated unmanned defensive positions capable of monitoring Russian movements and providing direct-fire support to soldiers.

A patient approach

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has continuously resisted US pressure to sign a deal with Russia. Europe has emerged as Ukraine's principal supporter in terms of military and financial support. The electoral defeat of Hungary's Viktor Orban and a new pro-European government have eased funding obstacles, with the EU clearing a €90-billion loan facility.

Ukraine's European partners are directly purchasing US weapons for Kiev while investing in Ukraine's defence industry, whose projected production this year is expected to be 55 times higher than in 2022.

The low-profile Victory Day celebration in Moscow this year hinted at the fact that Russia is starting to feel the heat, although it has continued striking Ukraine with greater intensity in recent days.

At the G7 Summit, US President Donald Trump said he had a "very good conversation" with Zelenskyy and Russian President Vladimir Putin. Four years after the war began and several attempted peace plans later, Ukraine's enhanced capabilities showcase its ability to fight till the end.



Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-kalyan ke

UTTAR PRADESH TRANSFORMING SCHOOLS, SHAPING FUTURES



Under the dynamic and visionary leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Uttar Pradesh is witnessing a remarkable transformation in the basic education sector. Government schools, which were once known for poor infrastructure and limited facilities, are now becoming modern, smart, and child-friendly learning centres. With a strong focus on quality education, digital learning, better classrooms, smart schools, and opportunities for every child, the state government is building a brighter future for millions of students. Special attention to girls' education, technology-based teaching, and modern facilities has created a new confidence among parents and students alike. Today, the "Yogi Model" of education is emerging as a symbol of progress, innovation and inclusive development across the country.

Key Achievements and Reforms in Basic Education

- Around 1.32 lakh Parishadiya Vidyalaya transformed under Operation Kayakalp.
- School saturation level increased dramatically from 36% in 2017-18 to 96.30%.

Record Enrolment and Out-of-School Children Brought Back

- 13.22 lakh children enrolled in 2024-25.
- Out-of-school children identified: 7.73 lakh out of which 2.69 lakh children (Classes 1-8) mainstreamed into schools.
- 5.04 lakh children linked to formal education after special training.

PM SHRI Scheme

- 1,722 schools transformed under PM SHRI (1,565 Basic & 157 Secondary Schools).
- Smart Classrooms, ICT Labs & Sports Facilities empowering future-ready learning.

Development of Smart Schools & Strengthening Classroom Infra

- Rapid process underway to provide 3.42 lakh desk-benches in schools.
- Continuous improvement in school buildings, sanitation, drinking water, and electricity facilities.
- Special initiative to convert all primary schools into smart schools.
- Technology-enabled classrooms helping rural students access digital education.
- Smart classes, digital learning tools, laboratories and sports infrastructure being introduced.

Special Focus on Girls' Education

- Decision to establish new Awasiya Balika Vidyalaya in blocks lacking Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas.
- Ensuring safe and quality education for girls from remote and underprivileged regions.
- Free textbooks and workbooks distributed to students from Classes 1 to 8.
- More than 1.30 crore students benefited through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) for: Uniforms, Bags, Shoes, Sweaters & Stationery



150 Chief Minister Model Composite Schools

- 150 Chief Minister Model Composite Schools approved across 75 districts, 2 in each district to deliver quality, modern and holistic education to every region.
- Schools to function from Pre-Primary to Class 12.
- Land selection completed for 141 schools.
- Institutions designed with:
 - Smart classrooms
 - Digital learning systems
 - Science laboratories
 - Sports facilities | Modern teaching infrastructure

75 Chief Minister Abhyudaya Composite Schools

- Development of 75 Abhyudaya Composite Schools for students from Pre-Primary to Class 8.
- Focus on quality education with modern facilities in government schools.

NIPUN Bharat Mission Progress

- Strengthening the foundation of education, 4.53 lakh teachers received FLN (Foundational Literacy & Numeracy) training in 2024-25, followed by another 4.33 lakh teachers in 2025-26.
- 1.32 lakh schools equipped with print-rich learning material and TLM support.
- Under PARAKH-2024, Uttar Pradesh showed notable improvement in language and mathematics competencies.

Inclusive Education Initiatives

- 746 Awasiya Vidyalaya operational for students with special needs from Classes 6-12.
- Around 87,647 girls students benefiting from facilities including:
 - Smart classes
 - ICT labs
 - Assistive devices
 - Therapy support
 - Sports training

Support for Divyang Students

Disability certification, surgery assistance, assistive aids (with ALIMCO support), and transport allowances being provided.

PM POSHAN (Mid-Day Meal)

- Nutritious meals provided to 1.52 crore students in 1.42 lakh schools.
- Weekly distribution of milk and fruits. 3.63 lakh cooks-cum-helpers receive an honorarium of ₹2,000 per month; beneficiaries are also covered under Ayushman Bharat.

Future-Ready Education Vision

- Education reforms aligned with the goals of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
- Uttar Pradesh government emphasizing:
 - Artificial Intelligence (AI)
 - STEM education
 - Digital learning
 - Skill development | Teacher capacity building

CSR and Corporate Participation in Education

- UP CSR Round Table 2026 on Future Ready Education" organized in Noida with participation from 100+ institutions.
- Collaboration proposals received for Digital education, AI-based learning, Teacher training, Scholarships, Skill development initiatives

Towards a Knowledge Economy

- Uttar Pradesh is leveraging its vast youth population to build a knowledge-driven economy.
- Education reforms are focused not just on enrolment, but on creating globally competitive, skilled, and confident students.



● RESULTS

GROUP A

Czechia 1-1 South Africa
Atlanta Stadium

Mexico 1-0 South Korea
Guadalajara Stadium

GROUP B

Switzerland 4-1 Bosnia
Los Angeles Stadium

Canada 6-0 Qatar
Vancouver Stadium

● MATCH SCHEDULE

GROUP D

Turkey vs Paraguay
San Francisco, 8.30 am
(Saturday)

GROUP F

Netherlands vs Sweden
Houston, 10.30 pm
(Saturday)

Tunisia vs Japan

Monterrey, 9.30 am
(Sunday)

GROUP E

Germany vs Ivory Coast
Toronto, 1.30 am
(Sunday)

Ecuador vs Curacao

Kansas City, 5.30 am
(Sunday)

ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS



Luis Romo's goal sent Mexico to the round of 32. AP

Mexico top Group A and seal spot in next stage

MEXICO BOOKED their place in the World Cup knockout stage as Group A winners and secured home advantage for the Round of 32 after Luis Romo's second-half strike earned a 1-0 win over South Korea on Thursday. The victory moved Javier Aguirre's side onto six points from two matches and ensured their first knockout game would be played in Mexico City on June 30. They are the first team to qualify for the knockout stage. Romo broke the deadlock three minutes after the restart, capitalising on a costly mistake by goalkeeper Kim Seung-Gyu. REUTERS

Vozinha's mother to watch him play against Uruguay

CAPE VERDE goalkeeper Vozinha was not too keen to discuss it on Thursday but finally conceded he was very happy his mother had obtained a U.S. visa and would be able to watch him play against Uruguay in the World Cup this weekend. The 40-year-old has become one of the breakout stars of the tournament after his performance helped Cape Verde secure a stunning 0-0 draw with European champions Spain in Atlanta. The U.S. State Department stepped in after his emotional post-match comments went viral, and on Thursday officials confirmed that his mother had received approval to travel. REUTERS

● BAD BLOOD SPILLS OVER

‘Something wasn’t right’: Koné’s horror injury sours Canada’s historic win

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 19

AN EMPHATIC maiden win, 40 years after Canada's World Cup debut, should have led to festivity during the host nation. Instead, concern and anxiety filled the air following a bone-snapping injury to Ismaël Koné in the second half.

Qatar midfielder Assim Madibo's reckless and late tackle from behind marred Les Rouges' 6-0 victory in Vancouver on Friday. Madibo was sent off and he later apologised

FOUR-TIME CHAMPIONS

Germany aim to rediscover rich tradition of tournament-stompers

While Joshua Kimmich wears the armband gently, fans pine for tough leader



Sandip G
New Jersey, June 19

IN THE German pubs in New York, the frenzy has already frothed up. At Berlin NYC near Grand Central, the manager promises beer at a discounted rate for anyone who could name all the four captains that had won Germany the World Cups. “Germans don’t need any discount for beer I am sure, but we need our fans to be super-charged for the World Cup,” says Matthias Weber, the manager.

His shop is decked with German flags and football crests. He would paste a few posters of the legends before the fans started pouring in for the game against Ecuador on June 25, after the second against Ivory Coast on 21. The German football federation has promised free commute from Times Square to the MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford to those associated with fan groups. “We will give our all — both on and off the pitch — to ensure we share a successful and unforgettable tournament,” the email from the football association to fan groups reads. “It’s here we need the 12th man more than ever before. We should restore our image as the tournament team,” he says.

He—and the nation—has a word for it. *Turniermannschaft*. The tournament monster, a team defined by their knack of winning or reaching the fag end of tournaments. Group exists in the last World Cup, premature ousters in the European Championship have dented their image. Reform and redemptions are two words the Germans, from fans to press, players to support staff slip into every sentence.



Anything short of reaching the final will be a huge disappointment for German fans. AP

None, though, got the answer they wanted to hear from manager Julian Nagelsmann, before leaving to the US. “It’s not my job to create euphoria!” he blunted a reporter’s question on his expectations. Suddenly, the most dynamic manager in Germany, who steered a relegation-threatened Hoffenheim to a Champions League spot when he was barely 29, with a dynamic system, a young multicultural group waiting for their ludicrous virtues to be harnessed and a charming talker, became a polarised figure in his country.

Awkward but firm

In the press, he was likened to the Chancellor. Friedrich Merz. Jürgen Mittag, a professor of sports politics and sociology at the German Sport University Cologne, wrote in DW: “Julian Nagelsmann, with all due caution — be compared to Merz: someone who attempts to push through more far-reaching structural reforms, but in doing so also polarises more strongly and does not always strike the most skilful tone in his communication,” Mittag said.

Chancellors and managers — German society and media have always struck parallels. The 2014 World Cup winning manager Joachim Loew was always likened to the then

chancellor Angela Merkel, who religiously attended every big game of her country. Coincidentally, they left the office too in the same year, 2021. “The national team coach thus becomes the focal point of this fragmented public sphere and the broader social discourses associated with it,” Mittag wrote.

Germany is going through a cultural transition with multiculturalism at its forefront. Out of the 26 in the squad, 12 have immigrant backgrounds. At the forefront is Jamal Musiala, born to a German mother and a British-Nigerian father. When a team largely composed of immigrants falls, the public misconceives it as a failure of the immigrants.

Noführungsspieler

The fans have more sporting reasons to worry. They bemoan the absence of a leader. Another tongue flexing German term they have— *Führungsspieler* (führung = lead, spieler = player), embodied by the legendary Franz Beckenbauer, passed onto Lothar Matthäus, Michael Ballack and Philipp Lahm. Joshua Kimmich is their inheritor, but he has not transformed into the powerful leader he was once touted to be. There was a time when he was labelled the next Toni Kroos, but he played. A trustworthy passer and ball circulator, he is bereft

of the command the aforementioned names exuded.

Goalkeeper Manuel Neuer is certainly one that breathes command, but his declining reflexes and proneness to blunder has pushed him into the heart of another debate. The young versus old, Nagelsmann’s reluctance to move away from the past. Two old guards have already retired—Toni Kroos and İlkay Gundogan—but the manager, the criticism goes, has been unable to assimilate new players to function in his system. Talents have surged, Florian Wirtz and Musiala, but both are wildly inconsistent. Glorious one day, banal the other.

The uncertainty rankles the old-timers, a time when Germany could be banked upon. They were not always a wondrously stylish team, but like the automobiles they manufactured, they were sturdy and durable. They produced an electric performance against first-timer Curacao; the forwards bustled, the midfield imposed. But the lone goal they conceded and the few hairy moments the defence whipped up, injected a few doses of cynicism. The victory was taken with guarded optimism. Wait and watch until the duel between a stronger nation - is the theme among German media. So when it comes to the tournament as a whole it is pro-

bably worth withholding judgment on Germany until they have played a team with better pedigree or at least an ability to probe their latent brittleness at set pieces and in defence.

Relying on magic

Their next adversaries, Ivory Coast, are not among the elites, but their slippery forwards could trouble Germany’s makeshift backline. Like in the Curacao game, Germany would over-rely on their forward quartet Kai Havertz, Florian Wirtz, Leroy Sané and Musiala. In rhythm, they are a mouthwatering group capable of dismantling defences. But none are synonymous for consistency.

In that sense, Nagelsmann’s is the most un-German team in principle, relying on individual dazzle rather than collectivism, wildly erratic, at times confused. Then, to play for Germany, or really any big international performance against first-timer Curacao, is to be chased by ghosts of the past: the teams that won, the teams that didn’t. For some teams this can be a weight across their shoulders; for others a wind at their backs. How Nagelsmann and his men deal with the variegated pressures would go a long way in defining both German football and culture. “Just bring the Cup back!” Matthias says. Just be *Turniermannschaft* again.

Manzambi: From goalkeeping dreams to their nightmare



Manzambi scored a brace in Switzerland’s 4-1 win over Bosnia. AP

Sandip G
New Jersey, June 19

THE COMMENTATORS were still figuring out the substitutes and their likely positions when one of them, in fact both of them, combined to produce a thundering strike. The score deadlocked, Switzerland’s frustrations mounting, Ruben Vargas darted down the left and floated a ball into the box. Not a piercing delivery. Bosnia half-cleared it.

Then the theatrics kicked in. A dreadlocked 20-year-old blur pirouetted almost ninety degrees to volley the ball into the net.

The speed gun read 79 miles an hour. Roll the tape, play it again. But every eye was on the goalscorer: his name, his face, his number, the pronunciation. He was buried under a pile of red shirts. Then he turned and pointed to the back of his shirt. It read: Johan Manzambi.

The name echoed around the stands, played on every lip. And it echoed again when he pre-assisted his team’s second and nailed the third, transforming a bland first-half performance into a memorable one for his team and its joyous fans.

His second goal was less theatre but more technically accomplished. Receiving a cut-back from his idol Granit Khaka, he opened his body and swept the ball with a crisp first-time finish. Yet he was not a target-man but a central midfielder, blessed with nimble feet and a face that never stops smiling. His composure belied his age. When he scored the first goal, he was merely seconds into the greatest day of his life, and the youngest debuting substitute to score a brace.

Injecting hope

There was something beyond the goals too. To come on and inject not just calmness but hope, not just to circulate the ball but to advance it, not just to have it but to want it, to enjoy it. Between his goals, he glided through the shadows, covering space and progressing with the ball, almost invisibly.

In the post-match chat, he looked neither too excited nor emotional. “I was not nervous, but just thinking how I could make an impact, how I could carry out the coach’s instructions. I didn’t think of scoring,” he said. After the chat, he grabbed a phone from a spectator and took a selfie.

Growing up in Geneva, he wanted to be neither a striker nor a midfielder, but a goalkeeper. In the backyard, playing with his father and brother, he was content palming and pushing the ball away. “I was

There was something beyond the goals too. To come on and inject not just calmness but hope, not just to circulate the ball but to advance it, not just to have it but to want it, to enjoy it.

very small, I grew up too late. I went through a phase where it was a bit difficult for me, when I had little confidence in myself,” he told Bundesliga.com.

But his father and brother saw that his real gift was with his feet, not his hands.

His father had migrated from Congo during the internal turmoil at the turn of the century and married an Angolan woman who had fled persecution. Manzambi was born in Geneva. His father introduced him to football early, hoping his son might realise the dream he never could. Manzambi was barely four when he was enrolled at local club Servette Geneva.

He didn’t take it seriously until an unexpected growth spurt changed his thinking. “Maybe I was a late bloomer. I was getting taller every day,” he said. He is now exactly six feet tall.

He never missed a game but had no particular favourite. “I don’t really have a role model. But I often watch Messi’s games. You can still learn a lot from him,” he told SC Freiburg’s website. At Freiburg he was deployed as a box-to-box midfielder. “A bit like Yaya Touré,” he would say.

Like the Ivorian, he could put in shifts in markedly different positions.

“Fundamentally I’m a box-to-box midfielder, but I think I can play on the wing and as a playmaker,” he told Bundesliga. Against Bosnia and Herzegovina, he was used as an attacking midfielder just behind the forward line.

The heat map, though, looked like a centre-forward’s. “He is so good in different positions that we are still trying to figure out his best one. He has this incredible hunger to score goals that I have rarely seen,” manager Murat Yakin said before the tournament. He called him a “secret weapon.”

But he was not a complete secret. European clubs had been scouting him for two years, with seven goals and as many assists last season. After this brace, it would not be a shock if a top club cajoles him away from the comforts of Freiburg. He would not be a secret much longer.

The kick-out: Adopted from rugby, mastered by PSG

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 19

IF ONE missed the start of most games this World Cup, you might have just failed to notice rugby’s influence on football. Teams have adopted an unusual kick-off move.

It isn’t always the gentle pass to a teammate after the referee’s whistle. Several teams have commenced play with a long curling ball forward that crosses the sideline. The idea is to kick the ball as close to the opposition’s corner flag so that the rivals can be pressed straightaway as they take a throw-in. So what is to be gained by losing possession? Territory - which accelerates the forward movement.

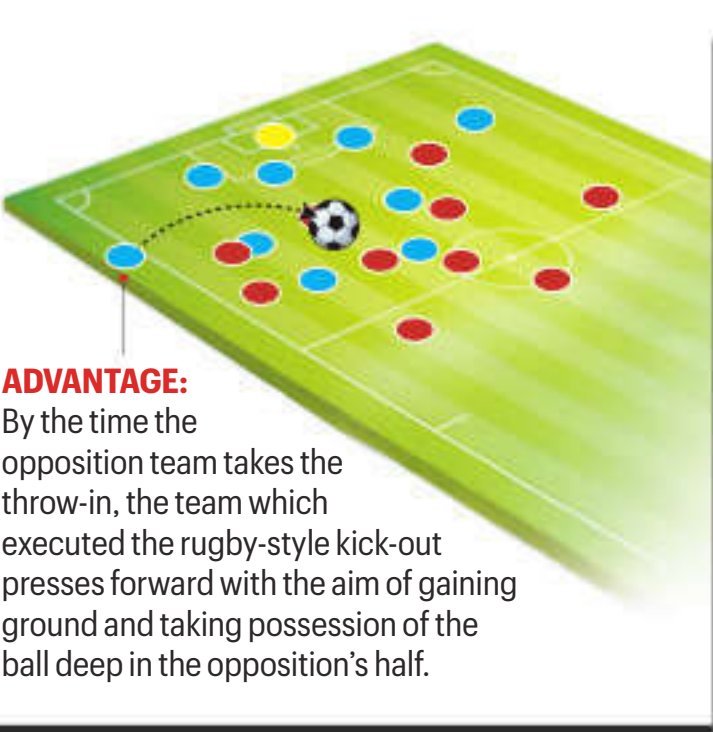
Like in rugby lineouts, the ball sent over the sideline provides the team a dead-ball opportunity pretty deep into the opposition half. A full-field press for throw-ins can put pressure on the team that

● RUGBY-STYLE KICK-OUT



PSG’S TACTIC:

Inspired by Luis Enrique’s Champions League-winning team’s kick-out at kick-off, teams at the FIFA World Cup have sent the ball into the opponents’ half beyond the sidelines to force a throw-in. Morocco, France and USA have adopted this strategy.



ADVANTAGE:

By the time the opposition team takes the throw-in, the team which executed the rugby-style kick-out presses forward with the aim of gaining ground and taking possession of the ball deep in the opposition’s half.

might be still settling in. Rugby lineouts offer a 50-50 chance for either of the jumpers to clasp the ball. It is the same with throw-ins in football.

The chances of an attacking team gaining ball possession

after gifting it away are bright.

This kick-off strategy was noticed earlier this year, from Paris Saint-Germain. The Champions League winners have been at it since defeating Inter Milan in last year’s final. It was a standout

feature of their encore against Arsenal. And now, several teams are trading possession for position, kicking the ball out of touch like rugby’s drop-kick.

What followed at PSG games after the ball was

launched and territory gained was an immediate influx of attackers rushing to capitalise on the aftermath of throw-ins.

Throw-ins don’t move the ball fast enough over a long distance. Teams are not organised for a block and tend to be slow to react, preventing them from starting a coordinated move. And that’s when PSG fill the throw-in zone for an aggressive high press. Chances of a turnover are very high in the chaos, just like line-outs. Against Arsenal, seven PSG players were deep in the Gunners’ half. They cannoned forward right after the kick bounced out, and won back the ball from the ensuing unorganised throw-in for a blitzing transition.

While drop-kicks in rugby fly high, the hangtime in an American football kick-off can go upto 4 seconds, helping the team to rush men forward. It’s why the PSG kicks were arching parabolas.



Canada and Qatar players and staff get into a scuffle after Ismaël Koné had to be stretchered off due to a reckless tackle. AP

this game — and that is what the guys did.”

As for the visiting side, forward Yusuf Abdurisag refused to speak about the gruesome episode, but lauded his teammates for their resilience after Homam Ahmed was sent off in the first half. Qatar played with nine men for 40-plus minutes.

Canada skipper Stephen Eustáquio, one of the first players to reach Koné, knew “something wasn’t right” as soon as he saw the Sassuolo midfielder’s leg. Describing the sequence of events afterwards,

Eustáquio expressed his dismay at Qatar contesting a straight red card to Madibo.

“They tried to defend their players, and we tried to defend ours. I think it’s normal, they still want to go far in this competition, but at the same time it’s a clear red. Like, there’s no debate in that he basically broke his leg. They wanted a yellow, but for me it makes no sense,” he told reporters.

Koné has reportedly fractured his fibula and tibia, and is expected to be out of action for at least three months, depend-

ing on how surgery and subsequent recovery go. His injury appears to have united Canadian players further, evident from their reactions and a solemn post-match huddle.

Les Rouges are a point away from sealing an unprecedented knockout berth. They next face Switzerland on June 25, armed with the knowledge that a win would guarantee them a top spot-finish in Group B.

But in the midst of it all, they continue to have Koné in their thoughts and are certain to miss him.

Shooter Gulia becomes junior world champion, dedicates title to Jaspal



Sameer Gulia in action during the final on Friday. EXPRESS

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, June 19

UPON BECOMING the world junior champion in men's 25m rapid fire pistol on Friday, Sameer Gulia's first thoughts were about his gun's grip. A couple of years ago, Jaspal Rana had advised the Haryana shooter to get his grip changed from Germany. Last week, Rana breathed his last and the 19-year-old chose to dedicate his maiden world title to the legendary coach.

"Jaspal Rana sir was the guiding force for all juniors in the Indian team in recent years and earlier too. Every time I shot with this gun, his motivating words, 'Aur mehnat kar Sameer beta aur dhyan na bhatkana' (Work harder and don't let your focus waver) would ring in my ears," Gulia tells *The Indian Express* after triumphing at the World Junior Championships in Suhli.

An only child, Gulia grew up in Purkhas village near Sonapat, eyeing his mother Anita Devi's medals at home. Devi, who became the 25m pistol national champion in 2013, quit shooting to concentrate on making her son an international star.

In 2016, she got Sameer a 10m air pistol and would take him to train at Delhi's Karni Singh Shooting Range.

With Covid-19 in 2020 caus-

ing shutdown of ranges and academies for some time, Devi built a 25m range in their village with INR 5 lakh from their savings to get her son to train for 25m pistol events too.

Gulia had qualified for the final on Friday after finishing seventh in qualification. The teenager produced a spectacular display from there on to clinch the title, ahead of France's Arnaud Gamaleri.

"There was a bit of pressure when I started but then as I gained my rhythm, I grew in confidence. This is my penultimate year in juniors and I would aim for another world title next year, apart from senior titles," says Gulia.

Last year, Gulia finished 35th in the World Championships in Cairo. With the junior world title on Friday under the new format of eight-shooter final, national coach Rajesh Kumar sees Gulia emerging stronger in coming months.

"Sameer has focused a lot on the 25m pistol in recent years. He has gained height and the main target for us was to adjust to his posture as well grip to the increasing body frame and wrists," Kumar says.

Meanwhile, 16-year-old Rohit Kanyan won the title in the men's 50m rifle 3P final later on Friday evening, while 18-year-old Prachi Gaikwad claimed the silver in women's 50m Rifle 3P final.

The mathematician, the speech and the pass that stopped a WC

Ayyoub Bouaddi grew up in a town 40 minutes north of Paris, won a national eloquence competition at 15, and starred on his World Cup debut

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, June 19

AT 15, Ayyoub Bouaddi was at the French president's place, the Élysée Palace, making a case about how you should play. At 18, against Brazil at the FIFA World Cup, he answered his own question.

In June 2023, the final of the national eloquence competition for French professional football academies was at the Élysée Palace with first lady Brigitte Macron in the audience. The topic given to the youngster from Creil and other finalists was: *Le résultat est-il supérieur à la manière?* Is the result superior to the manner? Bouaddi won.

Creil is a town in the Oise, 40 minutes north of Paris by train. Sofiane Khair coached the football prodigy at AFC Creil from the age of 6 to 15. When Bouaddi began appearing for Lille's first team, Khair told *Eurosport*: "We're the only ones it doesn't surprise." Then he listed why. Maturity. Intelligence. Calm. Self-belief. Courage. And always first at training. And then, after all of that, he mentioned talent. The people who knew him longest mention the talent last. The football world, encountering him at MetLife Stadium last Saturday night, will struggle to find room for anything else.

His father Hassan is a former deputy mayor of Creil, a banking executive, and a former handball player. He be-

longs to that generation of diaspora Moroccan fathers who demand two things - academic excellence and dignity. Not one and then the other. Both, as the same thing.

Bouaddi skipped a year at primary school. He got his *baccalauréat scientifique* (France's national academic science exams for secondary students) with mention *très bien* (the highest grade) at 16, a year earlier than the majority. He is currently enrolled by distance at the Université d'Aix-Marseille, reading mathematics, while playing Champions League football.

When journalists laugh at this — and they do — he is patient. "A lot of people laugh when I say I'm still studying," he said at a Lille press conference in November 2024. "When you study alongside everything else, it keeps your mind alert." Mathematics, he has said elsewhere, is not a backup plan. It is an intellectual necessity.

On October 2, 2024 — his 17th birthday — Lille played Real Madrid in the Champions League. Bouaddi sat at the base of the midfield against Bellingham, Valverde and Camavinga. He completed 43 of 44 passes, according to UEFA match data. Lille won 1-0. At the final whistle the ultras sang him Joyeux Anniversaire - French for Happy Birthday.

His face was on the front page of *L'Equipe* the next morning. The Real Madrid midfield had just spent 90 minutes try-



Ayyoub Bouaddi had captained the France under-21 side as recently as March 2026. AP

ing to find out where the ball had gone.

For months, two federations waited. Bouaddi had captained the France under-21 side as recently as March 2026. Then Zinedine Zidane, widely expected to take the France senior job after this World Cup, called him. Not to make promises. To tell the truth. Journalist Daniel Riolo reported the conversation on *L'After Foot*: "Zidane spoke to Bouaddi and told him: I like you, but I can't promise you anything." That was enough. He did not need a guarantee. He needed to know where he stood.

FIFA approved the switch to Morocco on May 15, 2026. Six weeks before the tournament. At the Mohammed VI Football Complex: "The coach and the president told me immediately that choosing Morocco was the right decision and that I would receive an incredible welcome.

They did not lie."

June 13, 2026. MetLife Stadium. Morocco vs Brazil. Casemiro — the defensive midfielder of his generation — started opposite him. By half-time he had been booked and substituted, his legs heavy, his reactions arriving a half-second late, made to look every one of his 34 years.

No risk

Morocco coach Mohamed Ouahbi had said before the match that picking Bouaddi carried no risk. "I only look at players' performance, not the age. He could be 35, and if he plays well, he'll play.

Or 17." At the final whistle Bouaddi had completed 91% of his passes, per FIFA match data — exceeded only by Brazil's centre-backs. The Moroccan newspaper *Libé* wrote: "Where others seek to impress, he simply seeks to play correctly.

And it is precisely this simplicity that impresses." Afterwards, coach Ouahbi was asked about the teenager who had just controlled a World Cup midfield on debut. "He didn't impress me," he said. "Because I already knew who he was as a player."

There is one moment from the match that did not make the highlights packages but will outlast most of those that did. The 87th minute. The score 1-1. Chadi Riad plays Bouaddi a pass. Bouaddi receives it, stops, and applauds — not the crowd, not a run, but the quality of the pass itself. Then he turns and moves forward, unhurried, as if he has just made a note in a margin.

In the 87th minute. Against Brazil. At a World Cup. On his first competitive international. Three years after the Élysée Palace, Chadi Riad played him the right pass and Bouaddi stopped to tell him so.

On return, Neeraj seals CWG berth with 85.69m throw

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, June 19

THERE WAS speculation whether double Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra would feature at the Commonwealth Games 2026 and when he would start his season.

On the day of CWG squad announcement, the Athletics Federation of India on Sunday added him provisionally to the squad on the condition that he clears the qualification mark of 82.61 metres.

At the Doha Diamond League on Friday, he put all the doubts to rest with a best mark of 85.69m. Neeraj not only breached the qualification mark, he also became the first Indian thrower to cross the 85m mark this year.

Returning from a long injury layoff after the Tokyo World Championships, Neeraj didn't start on a good note. Neeraj recorded a no mark with World Championships bronze medallist Curtis Thompson of the USA leading with 85.99m after the first round.

However, in the second round, Neeraj breached the qualification mark for the Commonwealth Games. With his 82.77m throw, he easily went past the 82.61m mark set by AFI. Anderson Peters took the lead after the second round with a 86.38m throw as Neeraj was stationed in fourth place.

Improving in Rd 3

Improving further in the third round, Neeraj registered a throw of 85.69m and moved to the third spot. Sri Lankan prodigy and world leader Rumesh Pathirage recorded 88.68m in his fourth throw to take the lead pushing Neeraj to fourth place. Rumesh Pathirage has been the best javelin thrower this season by miles with the top three marks in the world. He is also the only thrower to cross the 90m mark with 92.62m.

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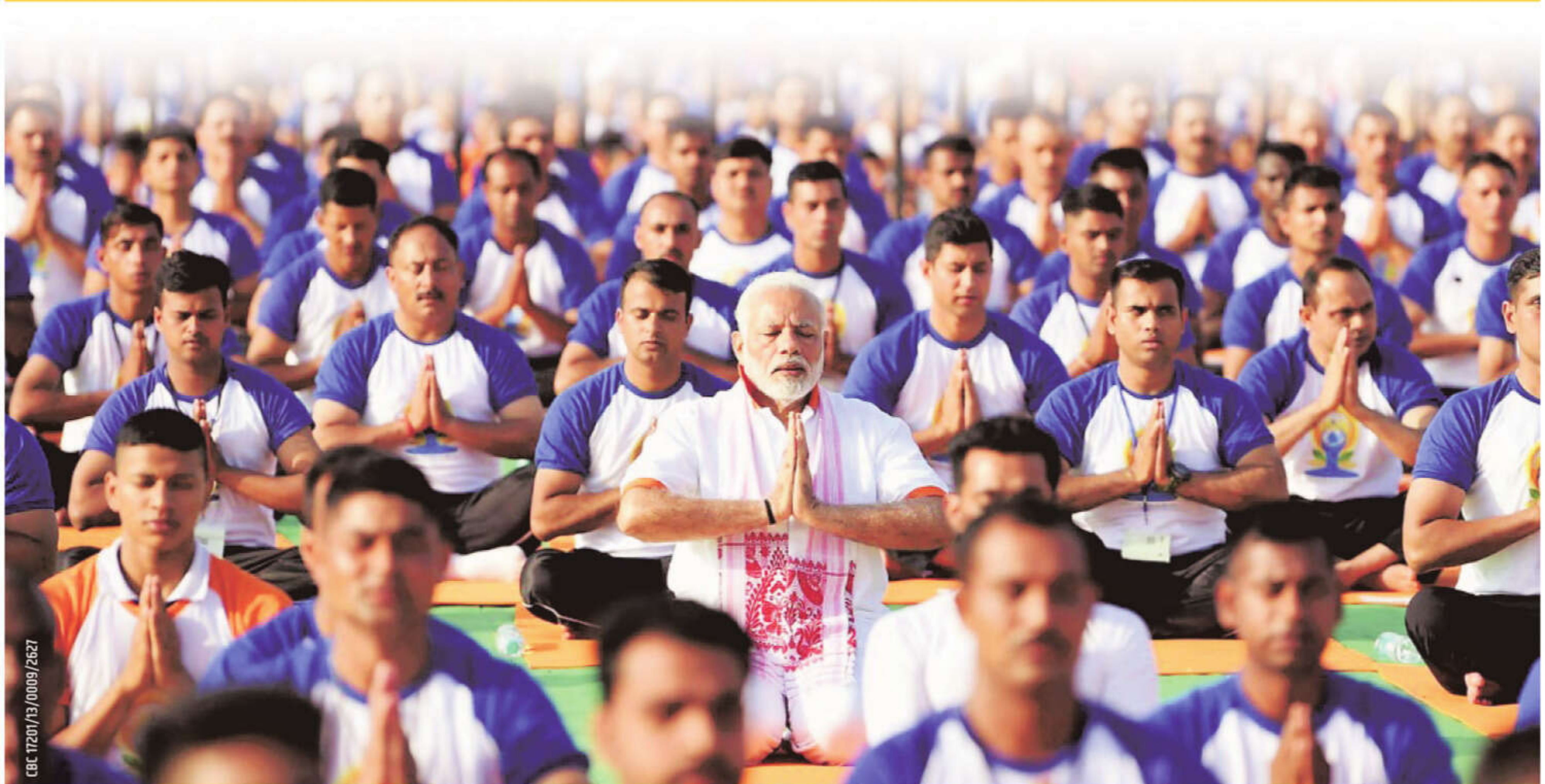
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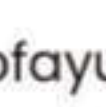
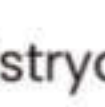
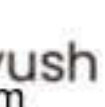
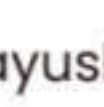
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GLOBAL I.T. GIANT FLAGGED A WEAKER DEMAND OUTLOOK

Nifty IT index falls to 3-year low after Accenture caution

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 19

INDIAN IT stocks fell 6.5%, and the Nifty IT index hit a 3-year low on Friday after global technology giant Accenture lowered its revenue growth guidance and flagged a weaker demand outlook during its third quarter earnings late on Thursday.

The Irish IT major slashed its revenue outlook for the financial year ending August 2026 to between 3-4% from the previous forecast of 3-5% in constant currency terms.

On its earnings call, the company flagged that client budgets remained lukewarm despite higher AI spending, and that demand for its consultancy services was also weak.

Hours later, the Indian IT services majors fell nearly 8% in early trade on Friday.

The Nifty IT index fell 6.4% intraday to a 3-year low, but recovered a bit to end the session down 3.7% at 27,426.85. Infosys also slumped to a 52-week low intraday and ended 6.5% lower. Other big names such as TCS, Wipro, and Tech Mahindra lost 1-4%. Infosys is already down by 39% from the 52-week high of Rs 1727.85. TCS has also fallen by 39% from the 52-week high level. Tech shares were hit by slowing global technology spending and AI disruption concerns.

The BSE IT index ended 3.6% lower. The fall in IT stocks dragged the overall market down, with the benchmark Nifty 50 and Sensex index falling as much as 1.2% in morning trade. Both indices recovered a bit in the last half hour of the session, with the Sensex ending 607.08 points or 0.8% lower at 76,802.90. The Nifty 50 ended down 0.6% at 24,013.10. "Volatility is likely to be high in the coming sessions ahead of the quarterly result session of the IT stocks. Pricewise there is still no sign of reversal of the corrective trend, hence suggest to technically avoid at current levels. Nifty IT index remains in a firm downtrend forming lower high and lower low in all time frames," said Pabitra Mukherjee, Deputy Vice President-Technical Research, Bajaj Broking.



The BSE IT index ended 3.6% lower. REUTERS

The cautious commentary from the global IT bellwether reignited worries around discretionary spending, delayed deal conversions and impact of geopolitical uncertainties on client spending patterns. Forecasters from global IT majors such as Accenture provide a peek into the future earnings performances for Indian IT majors, who often depend on a similar pipeline of US- and Europe-based clients for a majority of their revenue.

GRIM OUTLOOK

THE CAUTIOUS commentary from Accenture reignites worries around discretionary spending, delayed deal conversions and impact of global uncertainties on client spending patterns

FORECASTS FROM global IT majors provide a peek into the future earnings performances for Indian IT majors, who often depend on a similar pipeline of US- and Europe-based clients

AFTER ACCENTURE'S earnings, Citi flagged the Nifty IT trades at a significantly higher valuation (16 times its 1-year forward earnings) than Accenture (10 times its 1-year forward earnings)

Post Accenture's earnings, global firm Citi said it remained cautious on the Indian IT sector, flagging that the Nifty IT trades at a significantly higher valuation (16 times its 1-year forward earnings) than Accenture (10 times its 1-year forward earnings), **CNBC** reported.

"We have been cautious given AI disruption, increased competitive intensity, GCC trends, etc.; the macro uncertainty increases the challenges near term," Citi said.

A host of other firms also flagged near-term challenges for Indian IT services names.

"We believe the Middle East conflict is expected to have some effect on the revenues and deal bookings in 1QFY27F. In our view, the indirect impacts can continue in 2QFY27F, as it is not clear how quickly spending behaviour will normalise, particularly in challenged sectors like automotive," Nomura noted.

Jio files papers for record \$4-bn IPO



Reliance Industries holds 66% stake in Jio Platforms. REUTERS

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 19

THE MUCH--awaited initial public offering (IPO) of Jio Platforms Ltd (JPL), the telecom and digital arm of Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), is set to hit the market soon and is expected to raise Rs 37,000 crore (\$4 billion).

Reliance Industries Chairman and Managing Director Mukesh Ambani said the board of Jio Platforms approved the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) for the IPO and filed it with market regulator SEBI on Friday. The JIO IPO, which is likely to be the largest to hit the market so far, will be a fresh issue of 27 crore equity shares of face value of Rs 10 each at an issue price to be determined through the book building process.

Of the issue proceeds, Rs 27,500 crore will be utilised to repay debt and the balance will be used for general corporate purposes not exceeding 25% of the proceeds.

RIL holds 66.43% stake in JPL while Meta Platforms of the US, founded by Mark Zuckerberg, has 9.98% and Google 7.73%. Not less than 35% of the net issue will

be available for allocation to retail individual investors, according to the DRHP.

With Jio now announcing its IPO plan, two other mega IPOs will raise over Rs 67,000 crore from the market in the coming weeks. The National Stock Exchange (NSE) submitted its IPO documents late on Wednesday. Market estimates suggest the NSE offering could raise around Rs 30,000 crore through an offer for sale. Generally, DRHP is made available on the SEBI and stock exchanges website for at least 21 days and SEBI takes a month to vet the prospectus. This means the mega IPOs will hit the market only in July, according to market analysts.

However, RIL shares closed 1.39% lower at Rs 1309.35 on the BSE on Friday.

"This is a deeply emotional moment for me, for the entire Reliance Family, and millions of its shareholders," Ambani said.

He was addressing the RIL annual general meeting. Akash, Isha and Anant (Mukesh Ambani's children) are heading the Jio IPO process and will lead the next generation of value creation opportunities in the future," he

said. Akash Ambani is the MD of JPL while Isha and Anant Ambani are on its board.

The proposed IPO of Jio Platforms has been one of the most closely watched developments in India's capital markets, largely because of the company's dominant position in telecommunications and its rapidly expanding digital ecosystem.

Since its launch in 2016, Jio transformed the Indian telecom sector through aggressive pricing, widespread 4G and 5G adoption and large-scale investments in network infrastructure. Jio has over 524 million subscribers across India. Jio's network leadership in 5G continued to attract subscribers with a total 5G subscriber base reaching 268 million as of March 2026. Customer engagement also remains robust with 5G now accounting for 55% of total wireless traffic, the company said.

Speculation about a public listing of Jio intensified after Jio Platforms attracted billions of dollars in investments from global technology majors like Meta Platform, Google and Intel in 2020.

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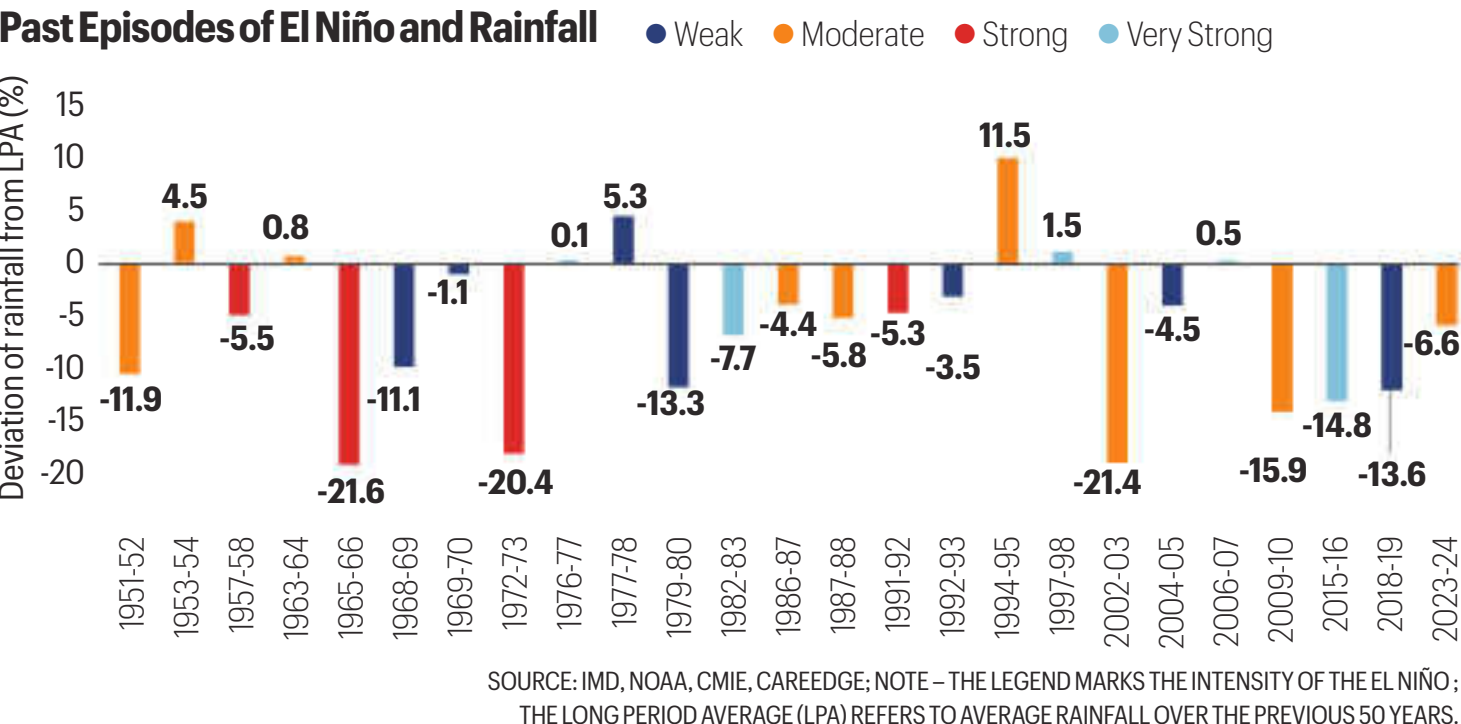
IMPACT OF EL NIÑO

India is seeing the effects of a developing El Niño pattern, which may affect crops and lead to an increase in food inflation. According to CareEdge, the probability distribution of rainfall is skewed towards deficient rainfall, with an 84% likelihood of sub-



normal conditions. Since 1951-52, there have been 25 El Niño episodes. Not all occurrences necessarily imply lower rainfall, but most episodes coincide with below the long-period average rainfall.

IMD's Probability Distribution of Rainfall	
<90 Deficient	60%
90-95 Below Normal	24%
96-104 Normal % of LPA	14%
105-110 Above Normal	2%
>110 Excess	0%



India to assume vice-presidency of FATF for the first time

New Delhi: In a significant decision, India has been chosen for the incoming vice presidency of the Financial Action Task Force (FATF), the global money laundering and terror financing watchdog.

Vivek Aggarwal, a 1994-batch IAS officer and presently Secretary, Ministry of Culture, has been elected and appointed as the vice president of FATF from July 2026 to June 2027. This is the first time India will have a leadership position at the 40-member global body. The vice presidency for India also strengthens its chances for assuming the presidency role at next switch-over. ENS

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MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
76,802.90	24,013.10	₹1,44,970	₹94.33
-607.08	-154.90		
-0.78%	-0.64%	Silver	Oil
		₹2,31,973	\$76.22

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RIL plans sovereign AI ecosystem, homegrown satellite network

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 19

Reliance Industries Chairman and MD Mukesh Ambani on Friday unveiled the company's plan to build a sovereign artificial intelligence (AI) ecosystem in India through its newly-launched Reliance Intelligence initiative.

"Reliance Intelligence is building India's sovereign AI backbone in Jamnagar. This cutting-edge infrastructure will be powered entirely by clean energy from Reliance's own solar generation from the Kutch renewable platform," Ambani said at the RIL AGM.

"The first 120 megawatts will be commissioned by the end of 2026," he said.

In addition, RIL is operationalising an initial fleet of advanced NVIDIA GB300 GPUs. "This next-generation compute capacity is equivalent to more than 75,000 H100 GPUs on an AI-inference basis," he said. As the first 120 megawatts becomes fully operational, this capacity can scale to over two lakh H100-equivalent GPUs, he said. "This capacity places Reliance among the largest AI infrastructure platforms being built anywhere in the world. When compute becomes affordable, innovation becomes inevitable," he said.

"Our Google partnership has deepened into a truly AI-first collaboration. For hundreds of millions of Jio users, Google AI Pro, powered by Gemini, is already accessible free of cost. Our second major partnership is the

joint venture with Meta, which operationalises the LLaMA open-source AI for Indian enterprises," Ambani said.

He said Reliance Intelligence will deliver sovereign hosting within India, with full model transparency and portability that allows every enterprise to own its AI journey. It will be accessible in 22 languages.

Satellite constellation for connectivity

Jio Platforms is evaluating the development of a sovereign Low Earth Orbit satellite constellation for India.

"We are also partnering with the leading global constellation providers by leasing satellite capacity, so that we can accelerate service availability while building our own long-term sovereign capability," Ambani said.

He said this dual approach will enable Jio to meet India's connectivity needs faster, while laying the foundation for the Indian satellite broadband platform of global scale. "To anchor this ambition, Jio is also building its own ground station infrastructure in India," he said.

"These ground stations will support our partner constellations, as well as our own future satellites, creating an end-to-end satellite broadband ecosystem from space to ground," Ambani said. "With this initiative, Jio is strengthening India's atmanirbharta in space, placing India firmly on the global satellite broadband services map," he said.

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SEBI board reintroduces open-market buyback

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 19

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Friday reintroduced the mechanism of allowing corporates to buy back shares through the open market. At the conclusion of its board meeting, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey also announced measures to relax the transfer procedure for securities held by deceased individuals and relaxed the norms for mutual funds to borrow for managing their day-to-day expenses. The most notable measure was the measure to allow corporate buybacks through the open market—a measure previously discontinued between 2023 and 2025 due to concerns over taxation.

Earlier, companies had to pay tax on proceeds from buybacks, effectively leading to existing shareholders not participating in the operation to also share the tax burden.

However, reforms announced in the Union Budget 2026-27, which provided for buybacks to be taxed as capital gains tax, have now allowed SEBI to reintroduce buybacks through the open market.

Currently, companies can only hold share buybacks through rigid mechanisms such as tender offer and book-building.

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MPC minutes: Why central bank opted for status quo on repo rates

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 19

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI's) rate setting panel, Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), preferred to adopt a "wait and watch" approach and remain watchful and wary about the generalisation of inflation in the coming months against the backdrop of the West Asia conflict and its impact, according to minutes of the MPC meeting held on June 5.

"We would continue to be data dependent and remain vigilant about inflation getting generalised, which can unhinge inflation expectations," RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said in the MPC meeting.

The panel had voted unanimously to keep the policy repo rate at 5.25% while retaining its monetary policy stance at 'neutral'. Malhotra said the RBI needs to be watchful of the inflation trajectory. "Going forward, revision in retail prices of petrol and diesel in May would lead to higher fuel inflation in the coming months," he said, as per the minutes.

While the near-term outlook for food prices remains favourable on account of a good rabi crop and adequate stocks, risks have amplified, especially from a below normal monsoon as predicted by the IMD and likely El Niño conditions.

Defending the economy, Malhotra said, "Our economic situation is quite strong and healthy vis-à-vis many of our peers. We are in a much better position today not only in terms of the current shock but also with respect to all earlier shocks. We are one of the fastest growing major economies and our inflation has been benign in the past year."

"While demand-pull inflation may call for pre-emptive action to effectively anchor inflation expectations, cost-push inflation induced by supply shocks warrants greater caution — gradualism — in policy making. In view of these factors, I feel it is prudent to wait for greater clarity to emerge from the data before deciding on any policy action," MPC Member Indranil Bhatta-

charyya said. According to MPC Member Ram Singh, if the inflation-related risks resolve favourably — food inflation remaining stable, global oil prices stabilising below \$80 per barrel, and the Federal Reserve avoiding hawkish decisions — the MPC will have the room to continue to be growth-supportive.

"Despite my concerns, I must cautiously note that, as of early June '26, I do not see material signals of economic overheating. Hence, the policy repo rate is currently appropriate and a status quo at the June 2026 review is likely to have the lowest economic cost," said external MPC member Saugata Bhattacharya.

The RBI policy panel reassessed both its growth and inflation projections, with risks emanating from elevated oil prices, uncertainty in global trade, adverse weather conditions and geopolitical tensions clouding the economic outlook. It lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1%.

BRIEFLY

Govt asks ICANN to set up root server in India

New Delhi: The Centre has asked global internet body ICANN to set up root servers in India, a senior government official said on Friday. Speaking at the NIXI event, Ministry of Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said there should be one root server in India to cater to the needs of the huge population of the country. "We have been pushing for locating a root server in India given the number of people who use the internet," Krishnan said. PTI

PV sales to grow 4-6% in FY27: Icra report

Mumbai: Passenger vehicle sales are likely to grow 4-6% this fiscal, driven by sustained demand momentum, improving affordability following GST rate cuts, and traction in utility vehicles, Icra report said. Passenger vehicle wholesale volumes recorded a strong 27% year-on-year growth in the last fiscal, reaching 4.4 lakh units, while retail sales grew 33% on the back of robust consumer demand, newly launched models. PTI

The Big Picture

SATURDAY, JUNE 20, 2026

22

IT WAS in a police officer's smoke-filled room at Crawford Market in then Bombay that I first heard of Billa, a young drifter from the Sion Koliwada area who had become a terror in parts of Dharavi. Billa, the officer said, would rob homes, accost young couples in the secluded Powai Lake area, and had become a scourge in parts of the city.

Growing up in the late 1970s at *The Indian Express* office at Nariman Point, one of Mumbai's earliest skyscrapers, we lived from one story to the next. It was like feeding a beast that was never satisfied. The battleground for professional rivalry was the crime beat that I handled.

The press room at the Police Commissioner's office was where handouts were circulated, and the "official" line to every story was given. Other eager beavers like me were always waiting for a Deep Throat to land a story in our laps; after all, we were operating in the Watergate era.

The officer — a regular contact who will remain anonymous — would often invite me for a cup of tea and fill me in on the gossip and intelligence doing the rounds. He was also the source who persuaded Haji Mastan, the legendary smuggler, to give me an interview for *The Indian Express*.

On one of those visits, the officer had news: Billa, who had been arrested in a burglary case in April 1978, had escaped from a Crime Branch cell. It was a dramatic escape. Every floor of the Crime Branch building was built like a cage, with iron bars, where undertrials were usually kept chained. Yet, Billa had vanished. He seemed to have chosen the day: May 1, 1978, Maharashtra Day and Labour Day, when most senior officers were occupied with bandobast duties and were busy making arrangements for public rallies.

I broke the story about Billa's escape and it became big news, much to the embarrassment of the police. The Police Commissioner's office was barely a few metres away.

The thrill of the story, however, lasted only a while; soon, I was preparing to leave for Bhopal to take up my new assignment as *The Statesman's* Special Representative.

Meanwhile in Delhi, a different story was building up. Geeta (16) and Sanjay Chopra (14), children of Madan Mohan Chopra, a Captain in the Navy, had been kidnapped — dragged into a moving car — and killed, a crime that shocked the nation.

My two years on the crime beat hadn't prepared me for the twist that was to follow, one that would warrant a follow-up story. Four months later, Billa, along with his associate Ranga, would be arrested for the

The children were kidnapped on a rainy day at about 6.30 pm outside Gol Dak Khana. A passer-by saw the children fighting Ranga and Billa in a mustard Fiat

Geeta and Sanjay Chopra murders.

In Delhi, a twin murder

On August 26, 1978, the children, Geeta and Sanjay, were on their way to the All India Radio office at Sansad Marg to participate in a radio programme. They were to reach the office by 7 pm and their father was to have picked them up at 9 pm. But they never reached the AIR office.

Their bodies were found two days later in the Ridge area. On August 31, 1978, police found a mustard Fiat car, though they were unconvinced that it was linked to the crime. Contrary to some accounts, the car was recovered in the Majlis Park area, not in the Buddha Jayanti Ridge area where the bodies were found.

The horrific nature of the case had made it a national story. As expected, *The Indian Express* team covered the case and its developments closely.

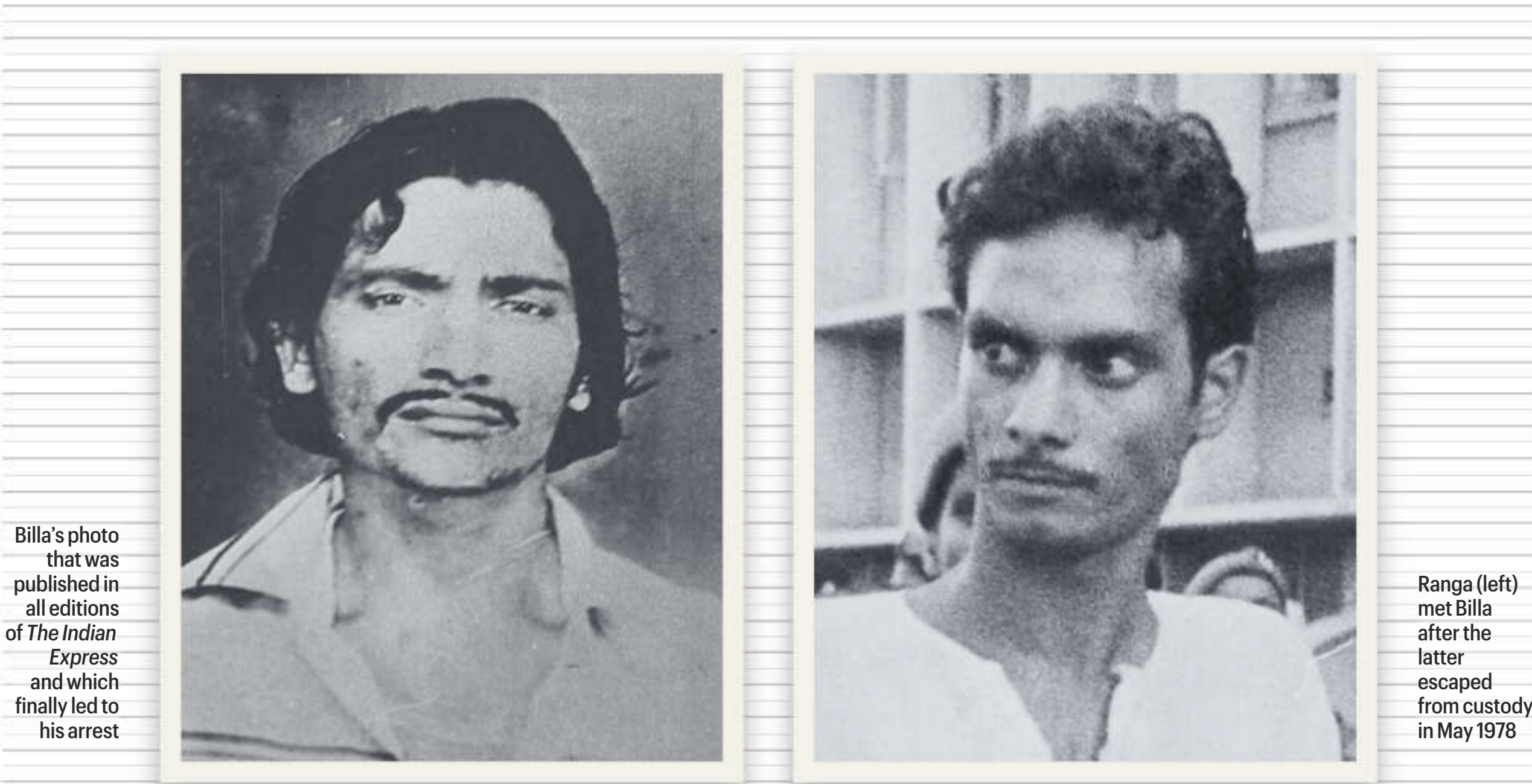
Looking back now, the timing was extraordinary. The year-old Morarji Desai-led government looked increasingly fragile as it battled coalition stressors and internal rivalries. Although Mrs Gandhi had been voted out of office the previous year, the Congress was snapping at the heels of the ruling Janata Party, waiting for an opportunity to come back. Officials were nervous, and the police administration was under intense pressure. The Shah Commission was probing excesses committed during the Emergency years.

The kidnapping and murder of the siblings couldn't have come at a worse time for the government that was already firefighting on other fronts. A few days earlier, Suresh Ram, the son of Defence Minister Jagjivan Ram, was allegedly implicated in a sex scandal. Also, the alleged encounter killing of the dacoit Sunder had brought several police officers under scrutiny.

When the Sanjay-Geeta case broke, the Delhi Police was divided. While some believed the kidnap theory, others tried to link it to the controversy surrounding Suresh Ram. Some even saw a Congress conspiracy behind it, especially since the party's student wing had been organising rallies demanding answers. When Atal Bihari Vajpayee, who was then the Minister for External Affairs, arrived at one such rally, a stone hurled at him struck his nose. The crowd was eventually dispersed with tear gas.

In Bombay, a hunt for Billa

Back in Bombay, the police were on the lookout for Billa, who had found a new associate in Ranga. Police and court documents say it was Shyam Singh, one of Billa's associates, who had introduced him to Ranga. Shyam Singh had grown weary of Billa's violent temper and unpredictable mood swings. He had earlier witnessed firsthand the murder of two Arab tourists



Billa's photo that was published in all editions of *The Indian Express* and which finally led to his arrest

Ranga (left) met Billa after the latter escaped from custody in May 1978

BILLA & RANGA

A reporter's diary

In the Bombay of the 1970s, RAJU SANTHANAM, a young crime reporter in *The Indian Express* newsroom, gets a break: Billa, a notorious name in the city, had escaped from a Crime Branch cell. Days later in Delhi, two children, Geeta and Sanjay Chopra, are found dead. A story of how a photograph sealed one of the most high-stakes manhunts in police records



(Clockwise from right) News reports on the case published in *The Indian Express*; Billa and Ranga were arrested from the New Delhi Railway Station; the spot in Delhi's Buddha Jayanti Park where the bodies of Geeta and Sanjay Chopra were found on August 28, 1978

• AS IT HAPPENED

1978

MAY 1: Billa, arrested in a burglary case, escapes Bombay Crime Branch cell

AUGUST 26: Geeta (16) and Sanjay Chopra (14), children of a Navy captain, hitch a ride outside Delhi's Gol Dak Khana. Father later reports them missing

AUGUST 28: The siblings' bodies are found in Buddha Jayanti Ridge area in Delhi

AUGUST 31: Police find the mustard Fiat — in which the children were kidnapped — abandoned in Delhi's Majlis Park area

SEPTEMBER 8: Billa and Ranga are arrested at New Delhi railway station after jawans on Kalka Mail recognise the former from his photo in the newspaper

1981

APRIL 21: Supreme Court upholds the death penalty for Billa and Ranga

1982

JANUARY 31: The two are hanged at Delhi's Tihar Jail

and knew that Billa was becoming increasingly dangerous.

Believing that Billa needed someone younger to work with, Shyam introduced him to Ranga. Tall, powerfully built, and nearly six feet tall, Ranga immediately impressed Billa. The two quickly formed a partnership.

One of their first crimes together was the kidnapping of a child for ransom. The plan, however, fell apart and the child was eventually returned unharmed. The failed operation led to the two men blaming each other for the fiasco.

By then, the Bombay Police were already closing in. Besides the murder of the Arab tourists, Billa was wanted in a string of robberies. There were also reports around Bombay of young couples being accosted by Billa in secluded areas around Powai. He would also reportedly offer women lifts and ensure that the rear door handles were broken, making escape almost impossible.

With the police on their heels, Billa and Ranga decided to leave the city and head north to Delhi. This was the duo's first trip to Delhi. They did not know the city and hoped to slip in unnoticed.

Meanwhile, the Bombay Police, convinced that Billa and Ranga were in Delhi, had already made two trips to the Capital, even before the Sanjay-Geeta Chopra murders. But the Delhi Police was not entirely convinced. In Delhi, officers of the Bombay Police were provided a jeep and a handful of constables to assist in the search, but little progress was made.

The breakthrough came when Jugal, a former associate of Billa and Ranga, broke ranks and approached the police. He revealed that the duo were indeed in Delhi, moving around in stolen cars and frequently changing number plates to avoid detection. Acting on this information, the Bombay Police made yet another trip to Delhi. They tracked down the painter who had fabricated the fake

number plates, and his description of the two men matched what Bombay investigators already knew — Billa and Ranga were in Delhi.

Then, one day, I got a call from my officer source. I met him reluctantly, having no interest in the story now, eager to find my bearings in Bhopal.

The officer said the Bombay Police wanted a wider manhunt, more personnel, and, most importantly, the circulation of Billa and Ranga's photographs. He gave me Billa's photograph, asking if it could be published in *The Indian Express*.

The *Express* published the photograph in all its editions. Days later, a group of Army jawans travelling on the Kalka Mail spotted the two men. They had recognised Billa from his photograph that a local paper, Navyug, had picked up from the *Express*. They alerted the authorities, leading to the arrest of Billa and Ranga at the New Delhi railway station on September 8, 1978. With that, one of India's most notorious manhunts had come to an end.

The publication of the photo was a pivotal moment that led to their arrest. A congratulatory telex from the editor was what every reporter dreamed about. I got one — Kuldeep Nayyar, then Editor, Express News Service, was always the first to acknowledge a great story.

A series of bunglings

The case would go on to taint Delhi as crime capital, a reputation the city hasn't been able to shake off to this day, and traumatised an entire generation of children and their parents about getting dragged into a moving car. The Billa-Ranga case is now the subject of a series on an OTT platform, highlighting the "heroic" role played by the Delhi Police. But truth should come in the way of a good story.

Let's look at the timeline and the role played by the Delhi Police. The children were kidnapped on a rainy day at about 6.30 pm outside Gol Dak Khana on August 26, 1978. A passer-by, Bhagwan Das, who was on a scooter, saw the children fighting Ranga and Billa in a mustard Fiat. He saw the girl pulling the hair of the driver and the boy quarrelling with the other passenger. He informed the Police Control Room with the number of the Fiat — HRK 8390. This was at 6.44 pm.

Minutes later, another passerby, Inderjit Singh, saw the scuffle. He chased the vehicle up to Shankar Road, but it disappeared after the red lights. The Police Control Room was alerted at 7.40 pm.

By then, Billa-Ranga and the children were already in the Buddha Jayanti Park in Delhi's Ridge area. That was not all. The hapless father of the children, Captain Chopra, complained to the police about his missing children at 10.15 pm and again at 11.30 pm. No one had the imagination to tie it all together.

Those were not the only lapses. Following repeated complaints by Chopra, a posse of about 240 policemen combed the Buddha Jayanti Park. They found nothing. It was a cowherd who found the bodies in the morning, barely 200 yards from where the police organised a manhunt. The lapses seemed endless.

In his confessional statement, Ranga said Geeta Chopra had given Billa a blow to his head, leading to a cut on his forehead. Hours after the murders, Ranga-Billa went to Willingdon Hospital (now Dr Ram Manohar Lohia or RML Hospital) and told a police inspector on duty at the hospital that they were attacked by some men. They used the same Fiat car, in which they had committed the crime, to drive the police to the spot where they were ostensibly attacked and dropped them back. The sub-inspector in his wisdom asked them to leave and come the following day. They, of course, never did.

It was only after they were arrested and the fingerprints in the Fiat car matched with Billa-Ranga's that the Delhi Police acknowledged that they were indeed the two suspects their Bombay counterparts were going after.

The trial took approximately four years to conclude, at the end of which Billa and Ranga were sentenced to death, a ruling that was challenged in the higher courts.

While upholding the death sentence, the Delhi High Court made a significant observation regarding the conduct of the Delhi Police, noting that the lives of the children might have been saved had the po-

A group of jawans on the Kalka Mail spotted Billa & Ranga. They had recognised Billa from his photograph that a local paper had picked up from the Express

lice acted promptly on the information available to them.

Court documents show that although the PCR received the report at 6.44 pm, the local police station deputed an officer for investigation only at 7.05 pm. "Surely the police did not expect the offenders to stay put in their car at Gol Dak Khana and wait for the police. Had flying squad cars been put into operation immediately, there was a good chance for preventing the murders. A general alarm should have been sounded to apprehend the culprits," the court said.

On April 21, 1981, the Supreme Court upheld the death penalty. On January 31, 1982, both men were hanged in Delhi's Tihar Jail.

With that, a sordid chapter in the country's criminal history had finally come to an end.

Fact, fiction and a little in between

The journalism of the late Seventies was very different from what it is today. We had fewer resources, no mobile phones, no internet and certainly no social media. What we did have was an obsession with getting the facts right. Stories were built slowly, source by source, document by document.

Over the years, I watched the Billa-Ranga case acquire a life of its own. Each retelling added a new layer. Some facts were forgotten, others exaggerated. More recently, OTT adaptations have introduced an entirely new generation to the case. They have also, in some instances, blurred the line between fact and fiction.

There is nothing wrong with dramatisation. But when fiction becomes accepted as history, someone eventually has to go back and ask what really happened.

That was the reason Sanjay Singh, my former colleague at NDTV, and I decided to write a book on the subject.

I realised that I had witnessed a small but important part of the story. I had known about Billa before the Delhi murders. I had broken the story of his escape. I had received the photograph that was eventually published across *The Indian Express* network. Most importantly, I still had access to diaries, notes and contacts that could help reconstruct events as they actually unfolded.

What began as a casual conversation with Sanjay Singh eventually became a year-long effort to separate myth from fact. The deeper we dug, the clearer it became that the story most people think they know is only part of the truth.

And I have to thank the Bombay Police's 'Mark Felt' for it.

The writer's forthcoming book, *Billa-Ranga: A Nation Ambushed*, co-authored by Sanjay Singh, is being published by HarperCollins

Shubhra Gupta

OH, A threesome? ‘Hawww, noooo, just checking’. This could well be a tagline for *Cocktail 2*, a spiritual sequel of the 2012 original of the same name, which once again gives us a guy and two girls looking for The One.

Kunal (Shahid Kapoor) plays a dashing chef whose mere presence makes irate female customers swoon. But he is perfectly content with the love of his life, Diya (Rashmika Mandanna), and the two have settled into post-hangover-burpy-domesticity minus the *pheras*: *shaadi*, who needs that, when the two are *miya* and *biwi* in all but name?

On a holiday in stunning Sicily, a chance encounter with the free-spirited Ally (Kriti Sanon), an old friend of Diya’s, becomes the third side of the triangle. Ally is single, and ever ready to mingle, and following through on a wholly contrived ruse, finds herself alone with Kunal: Will the two find more than one chance to stray, and how will that impact our lovey-dovey *jodi*? Who will be the twosome, and who will walk away, all lonesome?

As befits a 2026 rom com, we get couples living-in quite comfortably, without anyone — families or friends — morally judging Kunal or Diya, though neither of them are strictly averse to matrimony as we discover later in the film. Everyone is wealthy enough to go roaming about the world, whistling up fancy convertibles and vineyard tours: no poor people in this film.

The conflict comes up only when a gorgeous fly-in-the-ointment shows up, which seems to be the only instrument Bollywood filmmakers have to muddy the waters: In that respect, nothing seems to have changed in the interval. Can two people fall out of love? That would demand too much complexity, and what would happen to that gold standard Bollywood, ‘*dekhte hain do ladkiyaan lad rahi hain*’. Perish the thought.

The same director, Homi Adajania, helms both films, but this one is written by Luv Ranjan; the older one had Imtiaz Ali as the writer. What I wanted to see was



Too Hungover

whether the 2026 guy has progressed from being any better than the compulsive flirtatious jerk played by Saif Ali Khan, who was more in Luv Ranjan territory. Interestingly enough, it’s the Shahid Kapoor character who fits better with Imtiaz Ali’s idea of a romance: Kunal turns out to be a better guy than we give him credit for; when temptation arises, he turns all noble.

Cocktail 2 coasts on glossiness and too much talkiness, overlaid with Pritam’s ever-present background music. The reprise of the still-popular songs, including *Tum hi ho bandhu*, is flat: all emotions are underlined and overstated, just in case we missed the

COCKTAIL 2

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Homi Adajania

CAST: Shahid Kapoor, Rashmika Mandanna, Kriti Sanon, Pulkit Samrat, Tiku Talsania

stuff going on between the three.

Sanon finds herself with more feelings than she wagered for; Mandanna’s very silly idea of testing-her-true-love leaves her, unsurprisingly, in a suspicious puddle: the former is glamorous in a leggy, sunburnt way; the latter flubs the Hindi accent, and is surprisingly dull. But neither of these matter enough because this isn’t a film which is interested in the girls; they exist only so they can shine a light on the guy.

After the first half fully committed to the template of beautiful vistas-washboard abs-messy emotions, the film turns into a mix of my best friend’s wedding, and the

beautiful bridesmaid, in which we get an array of *lehengas* and *maangtikas*, and other eye-catching ensembles. Post interval, all the hard-working breeziness turns into melodrama, with a ringing endorsement of love not as excitement but habit. Yes, sexiness is great, impulsivity is wonderful, but the ever-after is reserved for steadiness and responsibility.

Ultimately, *Cocktail 2* comes off a bit of a cocktail itself, swinging between style and substance. It is Shahid Kapoor who carries this film with a pleasing conviction I haven’t seen in a long time. And while I missed Deepika Padukone’s wild wounded-ness, Sanon isn’t half bad herself. But there’s no getting past the conservatism which comes wrapped in this *pyaar ka punchnama*: For all its modern vibe, it’s the guy who gets the last word, not the gals.

Lights, Sound and Fury



THE FURIOUS

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Kenji Tanigaki

CAST: Miao Xie, Joe Taslim, Enyou Yang, Brian Le, Yayan Ruhian

Shalini Langer

HELL HATH no fury like a father scorned in *The Furious* — certainly not fury as taut, economical and razor-sharp as this film. Presumably, hell also involves a lot more chit-chat. *The Furious* dispenses with dialogue too; why waste your breath when you will need every ounce for the next tackle?

A much-celebrated action choreographer, director Kenji Tanigaki knows that all he needs is a skeletal story with an emotional tug (in this case, kidnapped children) to set his two action stars, Miao Xie as Wang, and Joe Taslim as Navin, on a mission. Once that machine starts, it barely takes a pause.

Four people are credited as writers, and at the very least they ensure that we don’t raise too many questions about where exactly all the action is happening (“Somewhere in Southeast Asia,” says the film), and why are more people not noticing Wang racing down streets bleeding and bare feet behind a pick-up truck or his daughter (Rainy, played by Enyou Yang) hung upside down from it.

Bad things happen in this grungy, gritty, damp and dreary country, and when they do, our men do what they gotta do. And they do a lot, with Wang, who is mute to boot, taking the lead, and ably matched punch to punch, kick to kick by Navin (you may remember Taslim from *The Raid*, a similar no-frills cracker of an action film). Wang is looking for his daughter, and Navin for his journalist wife who went missing while investigating a gang of child kidnappers.

Don’t dismiss the bad guys either, who are special too, none more than Ho (Brian Le), a giant, bald man in overalls with an agility on his feet that is stunning every time he pulls off a flip, and Tak (Yayan Ruhian, also in *The Raid*) who fights with arrows and cleavers and a devilish smirk.

The superbly choreographed action scenes are staged everywhere from the backside of a pickup truck to an ice factory to a wrestling venue to even under sliding desks at a police station. At least two blood orgies strike out of the blue while, towards the end, Tanigaki is just showing off.

When you can bleed with a thousand cuts, and still have skin to spare, why stop at 999?



Stop Toying With This Story

Shalini Langer

CHILD’S PLAY has always been serious business in the *Toy Story* franchise.

Now, it’s just business.

The fifth iteration of this profitable Pixar franchise is way past its game and, more importantly, has lost its sense of play. The central idea is that tech and tablets are replacing toys and imagination. By the end, the central takeaway is that the twain can co-exist happily.

After all, says a wisened Jessie/ Sheriff (Cusack), once much water has flown under the bridge, the sole mission on Earth for all of them — the ageing Woody (Hanks) to smitten Buzz (Allen) to new-plaything-on-the-block Lilypad — is to be there for the kids when they need them, at the right moment.

Could that moment also have something to do with the fact that Pixar owner Disney needs the tech bros by its side, as much as

TOY STORY 5

★★★★

DIRECTOR: McKenna Harris, Andrew Stanton

CAST: Voices of Tom Hanks, Tim Allen, Joan Cusack, Scarlett Spears, Conan O’Brien

any other corporate, in the world according to Donald Trump?

The message of tech being not just man’s but also a kid’s best friend is reached via a predictable story by now. Continuing from *Toy Story 4*, Jessie, Buzz and others remain toys of Bonnie (Spears), who hasn’t aged a bit in the many years since the third *Toy Story* that she first appeared in. However, her free time now is taken over almost entirely by the tablet Lilypad (Lee), where she desperately seeks out friends in group chats, which can quickly turn mean.

Jessie, Buzz, Bullseye and others, the toys Bonnie has stopped playing with, lie forgotten around her room or under her bed, hoping for her attention. Woody and Bo (Bo Peep) have been discarded and are surviving on the streets, till Jessie turns to Woody for help in finding Bonnie some real — and not just online — friends.

The film deploys many convoluted ways

and a lot of bouncing around roads and fields and many landscapes to tie the different strands together, and to complete the circle from Bonnie to this “real” friend they are seeking, Blaze (Harris).

The adult forces driving this franchise that began, unbelievably, 30 years ago are evident everywhere. It was around that time, in the early 1990s, that the US Congress passed one of its first Acts in a bid to monitor the Internet. It was also around then that Unabomber was finally arrested. Clearly, the world has long been chasing the elusive ground in the middle, now with laws banning social media for under-16s.

Another *Toy Story*, with little meat on it but a Taylor Swift song and a \$250 million budget — making the fifth film among the costliest animation movies ever made — is as good a story of excess as any. Woody, Buzz and Jessie are a long way from where they started. Even longer away from when Andy and Woody bid the love-liest of goodbyes to each other, in that perfect *Toy Story 3* about change and growing up: “So long... partner.”

•STREAMING WATCHLIST



Drishyam 3

PRIME VIDEO

THE MOVIE follows Georgekutty, who seems to have finally secured the future he always wanted for his family and even turned his past into a successful film.

But when the past refuses to stay buried and a trap involving his daughter Anju threatens everything he has built, he is forced into his most dangerous battle yet. Written and directed by Jeethu Joseph and produced by Antony Perumbavoor, it features Mohanlal, Meena and Siddique in lead roles.



I Will Find You

NETFLIX

DAVID BURROUGHS (Sam Worthington) is in prison for a crime he didn’t commit — killing his son. In the latest series from Netflix’s partnership with author Harlan Coben, David sees a glimmer of hope when his sister-in-law Rachel (Britt Lower) brings him a recent photo that seems to show his son, Matthew (Ashton Cressman), alive.



Sugar S2

APPLETV

IN THE new season of the series, Academy Award nominee Colin Farrell stars as John Sugar, an American private investigator on the heels of the mysterious

disappearance of Olivia Siegel, the beloved granddaughter of legendary Hollywood producer Jonathan Siegel. As Sugar tries to determine what happened to Olivia, he will also unearth Siegel family secrets; some very recent, others long-buried.



Athiradi

SONY LIV

THE MALAYALAM-LANGUAGE movie is set against the vibrant backdrop of an engineering college, and follows Samkutty (Basil Joseph), an enthusiastic student determined to revive the institution’s legendary Arohan fest, a celebration that was banned years ago following a tragic incident. But what begins as a mission to restore lost glory soon turns into a roller-coaster of madness when Samkutty crosses paths with Sreekuttan Vellayani (Tovino Thomas), a local goon-turned-musician with a bruised ego.



Your Fault: London

PRIME VIDEO

YOUR FAULT: *London* follows Nick and Noah as they face the biggest test of their relationship yet. As Noah begins a new chapter at Oxford University and Nick stays back in London to

work for his father’s company, distance, ambition, jealousy and outside forces threaten to pull them apart. Based on Mercedes Ron’s bestselling *Culpables* trilogy, the romantic drama is directed by Dani Girwood and Charlotte Fassler and stars Asha Banks and Matthew Broome in lead roles.

ALAKA SAHANI

A Cry for Help

Shubhra Gupta

SOME FILMS come carrying so much weight that they become hard to bear. Some films become testaments to their time. The *Voice Of Hind Rajab* is one that does both: it lets us in on the agony of a small child left alone in the back of a car — her family members murdered — calling for help; it also asks us to bear witness.

Director Kaouter Ben Hania first heard the clip in which a five-year-old girl is heard sobbing, saying she is afraid of the dark, asking for help. The voice belonged to Hind Rajab, who was travelling with her aunts, uncles and cousin in the Gaza strip, when the car was strafed by Israeli forces. Every one in the car is dead, the cousin is grievously injured: We learn that the latter dies

VOICE OF HIND RAJAB

★★★★★

DIRECTOR: Kaouter Ben Hania

CAST: Motaz Malhees, Saja Kilani, Amer Hlehel

too, leaving the terrified Hind hiding as best as she can, behind the backseat.

When the volunteers of the Palestine Red Crescent Society realise the gravity of her situation — tanks are closing in on her, even as she cries — their first reaction is the instant humanitarian one: to order an ambulance to go into the strip to rescue her. They are halted in their tracks by their superior, a man who goes by the book, who demands that the requisite multiple permissions are sought, and the journey cleared on all fronts, before the rescue op-



eration can be launched.

In her tense reconstruction of those last hours of Hind Rajab, Ben Hania uses the actual voice of the little girl, with actors playing the Palestinian volunteers. Each one — es-

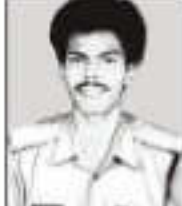
pecially the trio that does the heavy lifting, Omar (Motaz Malhees) who is the first responder, and Rana (Saja Kilani) who offers constant encouragement and support even as they rage against the inaction of their

supervisor, Mahdi (Amer Hlehel) — does their job with empathy and grace. You can feel their growing helplessness as precious time is wasted, and the despair when they learn that she is no more is devastating, as much to them, as it is to us, watching in the theatre. The usage of the real voice, through recordings that flicker on the screen, is a decision that can leave you conflicted, in the way docu-fiction often can. “Please come, I am so scared,” Hind Rajab cries out. We hope, heart in mouth, against hope.

The film lasts 89 minutes. What it leaves us with is the anger and guilt of a lifetime, as we experience each minute being lost in the face of bureaucratic apathy and growing danger. Hind doesn’t survive, and her not being in the world makes it, like so many lives lost to war, a lesser place. It is her voice which has survived, a potent anti-war statement, if ever there was one.

The film is out in India on limited release. Do not miss it.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE	
	CONSTABLE M MOHAN 161 BN BSF 02.06.1968 – 20.06.1994
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable M Mohan on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in a grenade blast, triggered by militants in Kothi Bagh area, Srinagar, J&K and later succumbed to his injuries at 92	
	HEAD CONSTABLE SAIFULLAH MIR SHQ BSF BANDIPUR 08.10.1948 – 20.06.1991
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Saifullah Mir on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries while fighting militants in Bandipur town, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice	

in the line of duty.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE	
	Veer Balidani Head Constable Bhagwati Choubey 116 BN 01-12-1953 To 20-06-2000
	Veer Balidani Constable Narayan Pradhan 116 BN 17-12-1972 To 20-06-2000

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Bhagwati Choubey and Constable Narayan Pradhan of 116 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during a search operation in Digboi, Assam on 20 June 2000. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

	Veer Balidani Constable Anisaur Rehman Mandel 2 BN 15-03-1983 To 20-06-2009		Veer Balidani Constable/Bugler Kishori Sani 2 BN 09-11-1979 To 20-06-2009
	Veer Balidani Constable Tariq Hussain 2 BN 01-04-1984 To 20-06-2009		Veer Balidani Constable Gourav Kumar 2 BN 01-07-1988 To 20-06-2009
	Veer Balidani Constable Ajit Madho Das 2 BN 10-05-1984 To 20-06-2009		Veer Balidani Constable Sanjay Kumar 2 BN 05-06-1982 To 20-06-2009
	Veer Balidani Constable Ali Amjad Ansari 2 BN 26-11-1981 To 20-06-2009		Veer Balidani Constable Rajinder Kumar 2 BN 02-08-1985 To 20-06-2009
	Veer Balidani Constable Vicky Kumar 2 BN 30-03-1985 To 20-06-2009		Veer Balidani Constable Daya Ram Prasad Yadav 2 BN 07-01-1988 To 20-06-2009
	Veer Balidani Constable Dinesh Kumar 2 BN 01-02-1986 To 20-06-2009	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to eleven bravehearts of 2 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an operation in Sukma, Chhattisgarh on 20 June 2009. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.	

CENTRAL INDUSTRIAL SECURITY FORCE			
	HC/GD S ALAGU MALAI OIL DULIAJAN 20-06-2003		CT/GD NAREN RAJBANSI OIL DULIAJAN 20-06-2003

CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of these brave-hearts. On this day, they laid down their lives at the altar of duty while fighting with militants. Their Courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to them for their noblest deeds.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023) Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Bablu S/o Rampal R/o Jhuggi Lal Bagh Azadpur, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 24/2019 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act at PS: Kashmiri Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Bablu can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Bablu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Bablu of FIR No. 24/2019 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act of PS: Kashmiri Gate, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 20.07.2026.

By order
Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
(Central), Room No.138,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

OFFICE OF PRINCIPAL,
CENTRE OF COOPERATIVE
MANAGEMENT OLD CHARA MANDI,
KACHCHA BERI ROAD, ROHTAK
Phone No. 01262-236275, E-mail pccmrk@yahoo.com

ADMISSION NOTICE

The 59th Session of Diploma in Cooperative Management (earlier scheduled to be conducted from 14.05.2026 to 30.09.2026) has now started from 18.06.2026 (20 Weeks). It is hereby informed that last date for applications by private candidates is 24.06.2026. All other terms & conditions shall remain unchanged as per the earlier admission notice.
For further information, contact
Telephone: 01262-236275

Sd/-
(Sarita Rathi)
Principal (Link Officer 1)
Centre of Cooperative Management
No. 46394/HRV
Rohtak

New Tirupur Area Development Corporation Ltd.
"Polyhose Towers" 1st Floor, No: 86, Mount Road,
Guindy, Chennai - 600 032

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Tenders are invited in two cover (Technical Bid & Price Bid) system for Procurement, Construction and Commissioning of Combined Water Supply Scheme for providing 3.5 MLD to SIPCOT Defense Industrial Park, Varapatt, 2.0 MLD to TIDCO Aerospace Industrial Park, Sular and 3.0 MLD to TIDCO Semi-Conductor Industrial Park, Kethanur from NTADCL Water Distribution Station (WDS 24) Murugampalayam, Tirupur

Approx. value of work Rs. Lakhs (Incl. GST)	EMD Rs. in Lakhs	Contract Period	Sale of Bid Document	Date & Time of Pre-Bid Meeting	Due Date & Time for submission of Bids
5296.00	39.72	18 Months	19.06.2026	06.07.2026 & 11.00 AM	20.07.2026 & 3:00 PM

Tender Bid Documents can be obtained from: <https://tntenders.gov.in/> / www.ntadcl.com
For further details, please contact :
The Chief Technical Officer,
New Tirupur Area Development Corporation Ltd.,
Kumaran Commercial Complex, First Floor, Kumaran Road,
Tirupur - 641 601, Tamilnadu.
Phone: 0421-2486864/ 2481165. Email: tirupur@ntadcl.com
DIPR/ 2105 /TENDER/2026

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-OPEN TENDER NOTICE
Open E-Tender Notice No. L-Open-26-27-05, Dt. 18.06.2026
The Divl. Rly Manager (Elect/G)/ Sonpur for and behalf of the president of India invites "Open E-Tender" for following works. The last date of online E-Tendering is 10.07.2026 up to 12.30 Hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-Tender is available on website www.ireps.gov.in
Sr.No. : 1, Name of work : At BJU- Provision of facilities in c/w Raising Rooms at par with that of running rooms of guardloco pilots. Approx. Cost (in Rs.): 1,20,41,915.26, Earnest Money (in Rs.): 2,40,800.00, Cost of Tender document (in Rs.) (Non-refundable): 00.00
The above Tender notice is available on Website- www.ireps.gov.in in RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER. Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone/modify or to cancel the tenders without assigning any reason.
Divl. Rail. Manager(Elect/G)/ East Central Railway/Sonpur
PR/0423/SEE/ELECT/T/26-27/32

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
CONSTRUCTION CIRCLE
U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN)
Opp. Car Scan Centre, Ramghat Road,
Aligarh-202002
Email: suptendinge@gmail.com

Letter No.:593/NIVIDA/66
Date: 18.06.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE
U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online E-tenders for execution of Investigation and survey (on GIS basis) of the project area including soil investigation if required, Engineering Design (hydraulic and structural) as required, Procurement of all labour & material, T&P etc. and construction of various components complete for interception and Diversion Works of tapping drain "USED WATER MANAGEMENT AT JATTARI, DISTRICT-ALIGARH" including successful testing and commissioning of said work on percentage rate "Turn-key basis" under SBM (U) - 2.0 Programme. Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidder. E-tender documents will be available for download from Date-29.06.2026 at 17:00 Hrs, Pre-Bid meeting will be held on date 08.07.2026 at 12:30 Hrs. in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till Date- 20.07.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 21.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. in the office of The Superintending Engineer, Construction Circle, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Aligarh in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs 10000.00+GST @18%. Details are available On U.P. Govt. [http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam\(Urban\)website](http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam(Urban)website) "http://www.jn.upscdc.gov.in".

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
CONSTRUCTION CIRCLE
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Opp. Car Scan Centre, Ramghat Road,
Aligarh-202002
Email: suptendinge@gmail.com

Letter No.:594/NIVIDA/67
Date: 18.06.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE
U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online E-tenders for execution of Investigation and survey (on GIS basis) of the project area including soil investigation if required, Engineering Design (hydraulic and structural) as required, Procurement of all labour & material, T&P etc. and construction of various components complete for interception and Diversion Works of tapping drain "USED WATER MANAGEMENT AT BESWAN, DISTRICT-ALIGARH" including successful testing and commissioning of said work on percentage rate "Turn-key basis" under SBM (U) - 2.0 Programme. Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidder. E-tender documents will be available for download from Date-29.06.2026 at 17:00 Hrs, Pre-Bid meeting will be held on date 08.07.2026 at 12:30 Hrs. in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till Date- 20.07.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 21.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. in the office of The Superintending Engineer, Construction Circle, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Aligarh in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs 10000.00+GST @18%. Details are available On U.P. Govt. [http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam\(Urban\)website](http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam(Urban)website) "http://www.jn.upscdc.gov.in".

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
CONSTRUCTION CIRCLE
U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN)
Opp. Car Scan Centre, Ramghat Road,
Aligarh-202002
Email: suptendinge@gmail.com

Letter No.:591/NIVIDA/64
Date: 18.06.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE
U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online E-tenders for execution of Investigation and survey (on GIS basis) of the project area including soil investigation if required, Engineering Design (hydraulic and structural) as required, Procurement of all labour & material, T&P etc. and construction of various components complete for interception and Diversion Works of tapping drain "USED WATER MANAGEMENT AT KAURIGANJ, DISTRICT-ALIGARH" including successful testing and commissioning of said work on percentage rate "Turn-key basis" under SBM (U) - 2.0 Programme. Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidder. E-tender documents will be available for download from Date-29.06.2026 at 17:00 Hrs, Pre-Bid meeting will be held on date 08.07.2026 at 12:30 Hrs. in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till Date- 20.07.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 21.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. in the office of The Superintending Engineer, Construction Circle, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Aligarh in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs 10000.00+GST @18%. Details are available On U.P. Govt. [http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam\(Urban\)website](http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam(Urban)website) "http://www.jn.upscdc.gov.in".

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-Tender Notice
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/TRD, North Western Railway, Bikaner for & on behalf of the President of India, invites E- tenders for the following work.
1. Complete details of tenders can be seen on Website No. : <http://www.ireps.gov.in> 2. Date & time of closing of e-tenders: 15.07.2026 at 15.00 hours.
3. Date & time of opening of e-tenders: After 15.00 Hrs on 15.07.2026. **Tender Notice No.:** 12-TRD-GSUBKN-ETender-2026-27. **Name of work:** TRD modification work in c/w Raising & Extension of platform and FOB works of GSU/Bikaner over various sections of Bikaner Division. **Approx Cost of the work:** 8833678.39. **EMD/SD (Rupees)** 176700.00. **897-MG/26**
Follow us on: <https://www.facebook.com/NWRrailways> <https://www.instagram.com/NWRrailways>

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता पंचम मण्डल सिंचाई कार्य, बरेली

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या-01/अधी०अभि०/2026-27

महामहिम राज्यपाल उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यो हेतु ऑनलाइन <http://etender.up.nic.in> के माध्यम से प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन टेक्निकल बिड एवं प्राईस-बिड/ फाइनैशियल बिड, सिंचाई विभाग में वरीकृत श्रेणी में पंजीकृत टेकेदारों से दिनांक-29.06.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 10.00 बजे से दिनांक-08.07.2026 अपराह्न 03.00 बजे तक आमन्त्रित की जाती है। प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन टेक्निकल बिड/दिनांक-08.07.2026 को अपराह्न 04.00 बजे अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, पंचम मण्डल सिंचाई कार्य, बरेली उत्तर प्रदेश के कार्यालय में मुख्य अभियन्ता, (शारदा) सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग, उ०प्र० बरेली द्वारा गठित समिति के समक्ष ऑनलाइन खोली जायेगी एवं प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन टेक्निकल बिड में उपयुक्त पाये गये निविदादताओं के प्राइस-बिड/फाइनैशियल बिड खोलने की तिथि कुल प्राय निविदाओं की संख्या के आधार पर ई-पोर्टल पर सूचित किया जायेगा।

लॉट सं०	कार्यो का विवरण	कार्य से सम्बंधित खण्ड का नाम	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत (लौ०एच०सेटी० सहित) (लाख रु० में)	धरोहर वारसाधि (लाख में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (रु० में)	टेकेदार के पंजीकरण की श्रेणी
1	जनपद चम्पावल के अन्तर्गत शारदा बैराज बनवासा के खडनस्ट्रीम दायां मार्जिनल बंध के किमी० 0.100 से किमी० 0.400 के मध्य क्षतिग्रस्त संरचनाओं की पुर्नस्थापना के कार्य।	हैल बक्सा खण्ड, शारदा नहर बरेली	193.44	3.87	18 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "बी" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
2	जनपद बरेली में रुहेलखण्ड नहर खण्ड की रुहेलखण्ड प्रणाली के अन्तर्गत निरीक्षण भवनों एवं राजकीय भूमि की सुरक्षा हेतु प्रीकार्ट बाउंड्रीवाल के निर्माण का कार्य।	रुहेलखण्ड नहर खण्ड, बरेली	99.73	2.00	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "बी" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
3	जनपद बरेली में रुहेलखण्ड नहर खंड की शारदा प्रणाली के अन्तर्गत निरीक्षण भवनों एवं राजकीय भूमि सुरक्षा हेतु प्रीकार्ट बाउंड्रीवाल के निर्माण का कार्य।	रुहेलखण्ड नहर खण्ड, बरेली	168.24	3.37	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "ए" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
4	जनपद बरेली के अन्तर्गत रुहेलखण्ड नहर खण्ड के नियंत्रणपीठ निरीक्षण भवन फर्निचर, सहाराक अभियन्ता कार्यालय, जिलेदारी कार्यालय एवं आवारों के पुनरोद्धार का कार्य।	रुहेलखण्ड नहर खण्ड, बरेली	192.94	3.86	18 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "ए" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
5	जनपद बरेली के अन्तर्गत निरीक्षण भवन रिहोय के पुनरोद्धार का कार्य।	रुहेलखण्ड नहर खण्ड, बरेली	115.72	2.32	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "ए" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
6	जनपद पीलीभीत में शारदा सागर खण्ड के अन्तर्गत शिवपुरी माइनर के किमी० 0.000 से 5.740 के मध्य बायें बैंक पर ब्रिक सोलिंग का कार्य।	शारदा सागर खण्ड, पीलीभीत	101.65	2.04	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "ए" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
7	जनपद पीलीभीत में शारदा सागर खण्ड पीलीभीत के बीसलपुर प्रणाली पर स्थित नली कोठीयों की राजकीय भूमि सुरक्षा हेतु बाउंड्रीवाल के निर्माण का कार्य।	शारदा सागर खण्ड, पीलीभीत	103.94	2.08	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "ए" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
8	जनपद पीलीभीत के अन्तर्गत मोहोटाडा राजवाड़ा के किमी० 0.000 से किमी० 34.700 के मध्य ब्रिक सोलिंग लगाने का कार्य।	शारदा सागर खण्ड, पीलीभीत	413.33	8.27	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "ए" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी
9	शारदा सागर खण्ड, पीलीभीत के अन्तर्गत नवाबगंज निरीक्षण भवन एवं स्ट्याक क्वार्टर के नवीनीकरण तथा सरोवर व अमखिड़िया कोठी पर स्थित राजकीय भूमि की सुरक्षा हेतु प्रीकार्ट बाउंड्रीवाल का कार्य।	शारदा सागर खण्ड, पीलीभीत	78.12	1.57	12 माह	2715.00	सिंचाई विभाग में "बी" अथवा उच्च पंजीकृत श्रेणी

UPID- 252757 DATE-18/06/2026
www.upidavd.gov.in

NORTHERN RAILWAY (E-Auction Notice)

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for allotment of contracts of Water Vending Machines (WVMs) and Multi Purpose Stalls (MPS) at following railway stations/locations:-

Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Cluster No.	No. of WVMs at Railway Stations
CTG-WVM-01-2026	30.06.2026 at 10:00 hrs	G	Total 12 WVMs at Anand Vihar Terminal Railway Station.
		F	Total 06 WVMs (03 WVMs at Kurukshetra, 02 WVMs at Karnal and 01 WVM at Shahbad Marknda Railway Station).
		E	Total 06 WVMs (02 WVMs at Badli, 02 WVMs at Ganaur and 02 WVMs at Sonipat Railway Station).
		D	Total 07 WVMs (03 WVMs at Panipat, 02 WVMs at Samalkha and 02 WVMs at Bhodwal Majri Railway Station).
CTG-WVM-02-2026	06.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs	I	Total 06 WVMs (01 WVM at Garhi Harsaur, 01 WVM at Patli, 01 WVM at Pataudi Road, 01 WVM at Palam, 02 WVMs at Delhi Saarai Rohilla Railway Station).
		J	Total 10 WVMs (04 WVMs at Meerut City, 02 WVMs at Modinagar, 01 WVM at Vivek Vihar, 03 WVMs at Delhi Shahdara Railway Station).
		H	Total 09 WVMs (02 WVMs at Jind, 02 WVMs at Narwana, 02 WVMs at Tohana, 02 WVMs at Jakhhal, 01 WVM at Mansa Railway Station).
		A	Total 10 WVMs (01 WVM at Baraut, 01 WVM at Baghat Road, 01 WVM at Noli, 02 WVMs at Shaml, 01 WVM at Rampur Maniharan and 04 WVMs at Muzaffarnagar Railway Station).
		B	Total 11 WVMs (03 WVMs at Deoband, 03 WVMs at Sahibabad & 05 WVMs at Ghaziabad Railway Station).
		K	Total 09 WVMs (01 WVM at Okhla, 01 WVM at Tuglakabad, 01 WVM at Faridabad, 01 WVM at Faridabad New Town, 02 WVMs at Ballabh-Garh and 03 WVMs at Palwal Railway Station).
Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Railway Station	Lot No.

DEE	MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-163-25-2 MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-133-25-2 MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-134-25-2
MUT	MPS-DLI-MUT-MPS-137-25-2
NZM	MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-113-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-115-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-158-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-116-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-122-25-1 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-156-25-1 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-157-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-126-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-159-25-2
KUN	MPS-DLI-KUN-MPS-135-25-2
NDLs	MPS-DLI-NDLs-MPS-79-26-1
DLI	MPS-DLI-DLI-MPS-165-26-1 MPS-DLI-DLI-MPS-128-25-2
MDNR	MPS-DLI-MDNR-MPS-147-25-2
MTC	MPS-DLI-MTC-MPS-140-25-1

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen [https://ireps.gov.in/\(E-Auction-Leasing\)](https://ireps.gov.in/(E-Auction-Leasing))

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:
Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module - Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module.
Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Update of Turnover Details.
A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism.
The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding round. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions.
Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors/Contractors (E-Tender/E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query	Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055. Email: catering.delhidivision@gmail.com Tel: 011-23743084
No. 23 AC/Ctg./e-Auction/WVM & MPS/2026 Dated: 19.06.2026	2122/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile	

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
CONSTRUCTION CIRCLE
U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN)
Opp. Car Scan Centre, Ramghat Road,
Aligarh-202002
Email: suptendinge@gmail.com

Letter No.:592/निविदा/65
Date: 18.06.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE
U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) online E-tenders for execution of Investigation and survey (on GIS basis) of the project area including soil investigation if required, Engineering Design (hydraulic and structural) as required, Procurement of all labour & material, T&P etc. and construction of various components complete for interception and Diversion Works of tapping drain "USED WATER MANAGEMENT AT PISAWA, DISTRICT-ALIGARH" including successful testing and commissioning of said work on percentage rate "Turn-key basis" under SBM (U) - 2.0 Programme. Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidder. E-tender documents will be available for download from Date-29.06.2026 at 17:00 Hrs, Pre-Bid meeting will be held on date 08.07.2026 at 12:30 Hrs. in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till Date-20.07.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. and technical bid shall be opened on 21.07.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. in the office of The Superintending Engineer, Construction Circle, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Aligarh in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is Rs 10000.00+GST @18%. Details are available On U.P. Govt. [http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam\(Urban\)website](http://etender.up.nic.in&U.P.JalNigam(Urban)website) "http://www.jn.upscdc.gov.in".

NORTHERN RAILWAY CORRIGENDUM

Ref: (i) Tender No. -02265091 due on Dated -23.06.26

(ii) Tender Notice No. - 16

1. In reference to above tender due date has been extended from 23.06.2026 to 06.07.2026.

2. In reference to above warranty period has been revised in s. no. -6

All other terms & conditions remain unchanged.

The corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2114/26

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE No.: T-09-N-2026-27 Date : 17.06.2026

E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N. C. Railway, Agra on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Tender No. : T-09-N-2026-27

Name of work with its location & Completion Period : Electrification work in connection with Fabrication and installation of Pre-Fabricated PUF Panel Porta Cabins at AGC Coaching Depot and AF Station.

Completion Period 08 Months

Approx. Cost of the work : Rs. 1198002.89



MAAHI MILK PRODUCER CO. LTD
Admin Block, Animal Feed and Nutrition Unit, Rajkot- Jamnagar Highway,
Village Khandheri, Taluka- Paddhari, District – Rajkot-360110, Gujarat

INVITATION FOR BID (IFB)
IFB No. Ref: Maahi/IFB/AMMONIA BASED IMCU/2026-27/01
Invitation for Bids: Supply of Ammonia Based Instant Milk Chilling Unit (IMCU), Qty: 3 Nos.
Bidding documents can be downloaded from www.maahimilk.com.
Estimated Bid Value : Rs.1.50 Cr.
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)- DD in favor of Maahi Milk Producer Company Ltd., Rajkot (Returnable) : 1 % @ of Estimated Cost Rs. 1,50,000.00
Start Date of download Bidding document (Through Website) : 20/06/2026, 09:00 Hrs.
Last Time & Date of downloading Bidding document (Through Website) : 06/07/2026, 15:30 Hrs.
Last date and time for submission of bid : 10/07/2026, 16:00 Hrs.
Time and date of opening for technical bid : 11/07/2026, 12:00 hrs.
Note: Commercial bid will be opened after finalization of technical bid.
Issued by: **Chief Executive, Maahi Milk Producer Company Ltd, Rajkot**

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system.
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	77269033 RGC	CHECK RAILS 9.5M LONG	500 SET	13.07.26
02	07265050	BOGIE GENERAL ARRANGEMENT FOR SIDE 1 POWER CAR	150 NOS	15.07.26
03	77269045 RGC	COMPLETE ASSEMBLY OF TWS	100 SET	21.07.26
04	16260040	BEARING ASSLY ROLLER	386 NOS	27.07.26
05	16263634A	TAPERED ROLLER BEARING	282 SET	30.07.26
06	16263633	TAPERED ROLLER BEARING	280 SET	30.08.26
07	07260087	SINGLE PIECE FRP LOUVRE SHUTTER	5388 NOS	25.08.26
08	07261076	COLLAR, FINISH MACHINED FOR DIRECT MOUNTED ROLLER	8703 NOS	26.08.26
09	07260291	SEALED WINDOW GLASS	2210 NOS	28.07.26

Note:1). Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No. 21/2026-2027 Dated: 19/06/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2113/26



Office of the Chief General Manager, Construction Wing
UTTRAKHAND PEYJAL SANSADHAN VIKAS EVAM NIRMAN NIGAM
(Uttarakhand Government Undertaking)
Third Floor (Vishvashwarya Bhawan) (Opposite O.N.G.C Hospital) Kamla Nagar, Dehradun-248001
Tel/Fax: 0135-2764075 E-mail: cgmnirmanwing@yahoo.com, gmnirmanwing@gmail.com
Government of Uttarakhand "e" procurement Notice

Bid Identification no :- 2432/ Nivida(Garhwal) Chamba/53 Dated: 18.06.2026

S. N.	Name of works	Estimated Cost	Period of Completion
1.	CONSTRUCTION OF PROPOSED CHAINLINK FENCING AT BHARSAR AGRICULTURE UNIVERSITY & DEMARICATION OF CAMPUS, RANICHAURI, NEW TEHRI, UTTARAKHAND	Rs. 701.40 Lacs (Excluding G.S.T.)	12 Months
2.	Name and Address of officer inviting the Bid:-	Office of the Chief General Manager, Construction Wing, Uttarakhand Peyjal Nigam, Third Floor (Vishvashwarya Bhawan) (Opposite ONGC Hospital), Kamla Nagar, Dehradun	
3.	Date and Time of Availability of bid documents in the portal:-	20/06/2026 – 17.00 Hrs.	
4.	Pre Bid Meeting Date	27/06/2026 – 12.00 Hrs.	
5.	Last Date/Time for receipt of bids in the portal:-	13/07/2026 – 17.00 Hrs.	

Details of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc. may be obtained from the website.
Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal "<https://www.uktenders.gov.in>" General Manager (Garhwal)

कार्यालय कार्यपालन अभियंता, ग्रामीण यांत्रिकी सेवा संभाग अम्बिकापुर
जिला-सर्गुजा (छ०ग०)
(TENDER-FIRST CALL)
क्रमांक/926/व.ले.ल./ ग्रायांसेवा/2026-27 अम्बिकापुर, दिनांक 15.06.2026
एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली के अन्तर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु ऑन लाईन (Online) निविदा दिनांक 30.06.2026 तक आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

क्र. सं.	ऑन लाईन निविदा क्र०	कार्य का नाम	निविदा की अनुमानित लागत (लाख में)
1	192914	हायर सेकेण्डरी कतकालो में 50 सीटर PVTG Hostel भवन निर्माण, विद्युतीकरण कार्य सहित, ज०प० अम्बिकापुर।	180.47
2	192915	हायर सेकेण्डरी नर्मदापुर में 50 सीटर PVTG Hostel भवन निर्माण, विद्युतीकरण कार्य सहित, ज०प० मैनापट।	180.47

उपरोक्त निर्माण कार्यों की निविदा की सामान्य शर्तें, धरोहर राशि, विस्तृत निविदा विज्ञप्ति निविदा दस्तावेज व अन्य जानकारी ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से दिनांक 16.06.2026 से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है।
हस्ता./- (अविनाश मिंज) कार्यपालन अभियंता ग्रामीण यांत्रिकी सेवा संभाग अम्बिकापुर
RO No-262701538-9



Section - I: Notice Inviting Tender (NIT)
RFP for Selection of an Agency for the Implementation of Animal Birth Control (ABC) Program in Madhubani District of Bihar
Municipal Corporation, Madhubani
Near Red Cross Society, Madhubani, Bihar-847211
Email ID- madhubaninagarnigam@gmail.com
Phone No.-9939240870, Tel: 06276-222033
Email: madhubaninagarnigam@gmail.com
Website : <https://madhubani.nic.in/>

RE-NIT No:-06/NNM-2026-27
1. {**Madhubani** Name of the District ULB HQ **Municipal Corporation Madhubani**} invites proposals from eligible firms for “Selection of an Agency for the Implementation of Animal Birth Control (ABC) Program in MADHUBANI District of Bihar”.
2. Interested Consultancy Firms may download the complete Request for Proposals (RFP) Document, from website: <https://state.bihar.gov.in/urban> or <https://madhubani.nic.in/>

-	PARTICULARS
1	Website for submission of bid/proposal Not applicable Separate bids to be submitted to the respective ULBs HQ at each district. (A bidder may choose to bid for multiple districts . For each district separate bids, Tender fee, Bid Security has to be submitted)
2	Mode of Submission Proposals/bids to be submitted in hard copies only to the respective District ULBs HQ Madhubani Municipal Corporation Madhubani (as per Annexure 3). A bidder is allowed to submit bids in more than one district subject to submission of separate tender processing fee and EMD / Bid Security for each district applied. Submission of Tender fee, Bid Security, payment proof, original copy of affidavit, declaration regarding Blacklisting and Power of Attorney as per RFP document along with the bid hard copies 08/07/2026 up to 05:00 PM
3	Last date and time for Submission of hard copies of Technical Bid/proposal along with financial bid/proposal in separate sealed envelopes inside one envelop.
4	Date and time of Pre bid meeting 24/06/2026 by 12:00 PM At Office Madhubani Municipal Corporation Video call link: https://calendar.app.google/XosVzZDM93YX6qz5
5	Submission of bids through eproc portal Not applicable
6	Date and time of opening of Technical Bids 10/07/2026 at 03:30 PM At Office Madhubani Municipal Corporation
7	Date and time of opening of Financial Bids Will be intimated later to successful bidders by the respective district ULB HQ Madhubani Municipal Corporation Madhubani
8	Method of Selection Least cost (rate per unit) selection method

Agencies/ Firms may download the complete Request for Proposal (RFP) Document, from website: <https://state.bihar.gov.in/urban> or <https://madhubani.nic.in/>
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
Municipal Commissioner
Municipal Corporation, Madhubani
PR- 006054 (B & C) 2026-27
नशी से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।



The Kerala Minerals & Metals Ltd
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Sankaramangalam, Kollam,-691583
Phone : +91-476-2651215 to 217, E-mail : md@kmmml.com

TENDER NOTICE
For more details, please visit E-Tendering Portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmmml.com

No	Tender ID	Items
1.	2026_KMML_856568_1	Fabrication and Supply of Reactor Cooling Tubes
2.	2026_KMML_856239_1	Fabrication & Supply of Heavy Ends Condenser
3.	2026_KMML_856295_1	Fabrication & Supply of Recycle Gas Cooler
4.	2026_KMML_856585_1	Supply and commissioning assistance of LPG Vaporizer
5.	2026_KMML_856614_1	Supply and Installation of 150M3/HR Automated DM Plant
6.	2026_KMML_856450_1	Supply of Brick Acid Resistant
7.	2026_KMML_856625_1	Supply of Chicken meat
8.	2026_KMML_856665_1	Supply of Vegetables and Fruits

Chavara. 19.06.2026 Sd/, Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Manoj, S/o Raghuvveer Rai R/o B-2/135, Gali No.8/10, Agar Nagar, Prem Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No.68/2019 dated 27.02.2019 u/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Prem Nagar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Manoj cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Manoj has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Manoj of FIR No.68/2019 dated 27.02.2019 u/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Prem Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 31.07.2026.
By Order, Ms. Shagun
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class, North-West
Court No.109, 1st Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/8242/RD/2026



Varthana Finance Private Limited
Registered Office at: No. 58C-110, Varasiddhi, Outer Ring Road, Service Road, 3rd Block, HRBR Layout, Kalyan Nagar, Bangalore-560043. Website: www.varthana.com, Email: care@varthana.com, Phone: 080-68455777, Branch Office: Parashara Trade Tower,F8,1st Floor,Plot No BC-2and BC-3Shatabdi Nagar,Meerut-250103.

POSSESSION NOTICE
[Rule 8(1)] (For Immovable property)
Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the M/s. Varthana Finance Private Ltd. (Formerly Known as M/s. Thirumeni Finance Private Ltd.) Meerut, Under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated: 16.03.2026, calling upon the Applicants/ Co-Aplicants/ Mortgagees, in Loan Account No.s. S24MERO029961 and S24MERO30606 (Client ID:307760) 1. M/s. R H M College of Higher Education, Represented by its Authorized Signatory,Vill & Post Siras Khera, Mundha Panday, Moradabad,Shiv Mandir, Uttar Pradesh- 244926 2. Mr. Rukshad Ali S/o Asrar Husain,House No.551, Near Jaama Masjid,Village Siras Khera, Moradabad,Uttar Pradesh-244926 3.Mrs. Rukshasa Bi, W/o Mr.Rukshad Ali, House No.551, Near Jaama Masjid,Village Siras Khera, S, Moradabad,Uttar Pradesh-244926. To repay the amount mentioned in the said notice being a sum of **Rs.24,98,129/-** (Rupees Twenty Four Lakh Ninety Eight Thousand One Hundred and Twenty Nine Only) as on 11-03-2026, to repay agreed contractual rate of interest together with incidental expenses, cost and other charges etc, as details mentioned in the Demand Notice, till the date of payment, within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. However the Applicants/ Co-Aplicants/ Mortgagees herein above having failed to repay the full amount with interest/other charges, notice is hereby given to the Applicants/ Co-Aplicants/Mortgagees in particular and to the public in general that the undersigned being Authorized Officer of the M/s. Varthana Finance Private Ltd, Meerut, Branch has taken POSSESSION of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under section 13(4) of the said Act, read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 on this day of 18-06-2026. The Applicants/ Co-Aplicants/ Mortgagees in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the M/s. Varthana Finance Private Ltd, Meerut, for an amount of **Rs.24,98,129/-** (Rupees Twenty Four Lakh Ninety Eight Thousand One Hundred and Twenty Nine Only) as on 11-03-2026 with agreed contractual rate of interest, as mentioned herein above until the date of payment together with incidental expenses, cost and other charges. The Applicants/Co-Aplicants/Mortgagees attention is invited to provisions of Section 13(8) of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured Assets.
Description of the Immovable Property: All the part and Parcel of property bearing Khata No. 225 and Khasha No. 193 min, measuring area 0.240 hectare out of total area 0.9600 hectare situated at Village - Harsainpur, Tehsil & District Moradabad, U.P and bounded as follows : North: 16 Ft wide Mud Road, South: Agriculture Land of Kabir Pl. East: Agricultural Land of Jayapal and Rampal and Rakesh, West: Agricultural land of Asmat Ali.
Date: 18-06-2026, Sd/- Authorized Officer,
Place: District Moradabad For Varthana Finance Private Ltd.



E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender Notice No. - TM3/USFD/ Outsource/2026 Date: 17.06.2026
On line (through e-tendering) Tender for the following work is invited by Dy. Chief Engineer (Track Machine), Plant Depot, East Central Railway, DDU for and on behalf of the President of India, from reputed Firms.
E-Tender Closing Date: 08-07-2026
1. Name of the work with its location : TM3_USFDOutsource 2025 Ultrasonic Testing of SK/VAT Welds with contractor's own weld tester and Operators on nominated routes of East Central Railway including hand probing (flange testing) of welds as per Indian Railway Standard Specification for Ultrasonic Testing of Rails/Welds, Revised-2020 (Documented No. T-53) and Manual for Ultrasonic testing of Rails Welds, Revised 2022 (with latest amendment) issued by RDSO. Tender Cost- Nil. 2. Approx. Cost of the work : Rs. 1,76,30,250.00. 3. Earnest Money : Rs. 3,52,70,00/- 4. Date and time for submission of e-tender : 08.07.2026 upto 15:00 hrs., 5. Website particulars of e-tendering : www.ireps.gov.in
Dy. Chief Engineer/TMC
Plant Depot, DDU
PR/0418/DDU/ENGG/T/26-27/36

"IMPORTANT"
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GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
PROTECTION OF PLANT VARIETIES AND FARMERS' RIGHTS AUTHORITY
Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare
Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare
Website: "www.plantauthority.gov.in"



PPVFR

Plant Genome Saviour Award 2025-26
Applications are invited for Plant Genome Saviour Community Award/Farmer Reward & Recognition for the year 2025-26 in prescribed format from the farming communities and individual farmers. The detailed advertisement and application format are available on the website of the PPVFR Authority, i.e. <https://plantauthority.gov.in/>
Last date: 3 months from the date of the advertisement.
CBC 01146/12/0002/2627

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
The Sr DME/ Diesel, Northern Railway, Diesel Loco Shed, Tughlakabad for and on behalf of President of India invites e-tenders for the following work The tender will be accepted online only in the prescribed tender document.

Subject	Description
Name of work	"Provision for the Calibration of Tools and Measuring Instruments at Diesel Shed Tughlakabad for 02 years".
Place of work	Diesel Shed, Tughlakabad, New Delhi-110044.
Completion Period	02 Years
Approximate cost of work	Rs. 4,12,292/-Including GST (Rupees Four Lakh Twelve Thousand Two Hundred Ninety Two Only)
Amount of Security Bid	Rs.300/- (Rs. Eight Thousand Three Hundred only)
Technical Eligibility Criteria	As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.
Financial Eligibility Criteria	As per clause 10 of tender form (second sheet) of Tender Document.
Website to download and upload e-tender document	www.ireps.gov.in
Due date & time of uploading of Tender by tenderer	10.07.2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.
Date & Time of Tender opening	10.07.2026 after 12:00 Hrs.
Validity of offer	60 days from opening of tender

Tender Document can be downloaded from Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. In. For details of work experience, scope of work and terms & conditions please see Tender document.
Tender Notice No. DSL-TKD-Calibration-26 Dated 18.06.2026
SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 2107/2026



PUBLIC NOTICE ON AUCTION OF PLEDGED GOLD ORNAMENTS
The borrower/s in specific and interested bidders in general, are hereby informed that on account of non-repayment of the Banks due by the borrowers as under despite the payment notice and recall/auCTION notice issued by the Bank, the gold ornaments pledged with the bank security by the respective borrowers for the loan availed by them will be sold in public auction on "as is where is" and "non-recourse" at branch premises on **29th June 2026 at 10.30 AM**. The auction may be adjourned to any other later date at the discretion of the bank upon publication of the same in the Bank's notice board. The borrowers are hereby further inform that the gold ornaments will be disposed of by public auction/e-auction, if the auction is not successful, and if there is a further balance to be recovered thereafter, legal action will be initiated against the borrower/s for recovery of the balance amounts due to the bank. "In case of Deceased borrower, all conditions will be applicable to legal heirs."

S. No.	Auction Center CSB Branch	Account Name	Client ID	No. of Acc.	Bal. Outstanding as on 16-06-2026	Weight (grams)
1	Ashok Vihar - Delhi	Sourav Dedha	04959554	003	4,16,039.14	79.68
2	Ashok Vihar - Delhi	Vineet Kumar	10113280	002	9,81,693.59	125.34
3	Gautam Nagar	M Tharuman	02949352	001	23,440.80	7.90
4	Gautam Nagar	Om Pal	07676944	001	1,07,714.94	19.75
5	Karol Bagh	Kushal Anand	04811170	001	82,607.03	14.85
6	Karol Bagh	Tejinder Kaur	07736319	001	8,33,170.57	90.77
7	Karol Bagh	Saheb Narula	07933289	002	5,40,166.54	99.96
8	Palam	Sachin	06121599	002	5,83,040.51	89.23
9	Rohini Sector 7	Divya	07765700	001	7,56,944.51	135.10
10	Shalimarbagh	Sunit Khanna	07613897	001	8,29,441.50	81.05
11	Shalimarbagh	Nitika Sondhi	07927281	001	7,85,087.82	69.00
12	Shalimarbagh	Karan Khar	08224967	003	16,32,771.21	157.04
13	Shalimarbagh	Shalu Jain	10279703	001	4,71,819.21	45.36
14	Najafgarh, New Delhi	Karan Kher	08224967	001	5,28,592.95	61.57
15	Narela	Arun Pal	10121635	001	57,263.72	8.25
16	Bhajanpura - New Delhi	Sunil Kumar	04862720	001	12,06,056.25	25.11
17	Bhajanpura - New Delhi	Akash Kumar	07582494	001	2,79,315.00	38.08
18	Bhajanpura - New Delhi	Rakesh Joshi	07929095	001	9,30,477.48	127.90
19	Tn Nagar, New Delhi	Vishnu Kumar	07502124	001	2,13,578.90	32.00
20	Laxmi Nagar	Sreeram Kumar	10114803	001	1,75,163.26	24.80
21	Kamla Nagar - New Delhi	Komal Sharma	10249151	001	6,69,508.99	60.40

For more details/account wise information borrower/s/interested bidders may contact respective branches and for participating in the auction
NCT OF DELHI | 20.06.2026
Sd/- Authorized Officer, CSB Bank



JHARKHAND BIJLI VITRAN NIGAM LIMITED
(CIN – U40108JH2013-SGC001702)
OFFICE OF THE
General Manager-Cum-Chief Engineer
Electric Supply Area, 33/11 KV P/S/S, Daridih, Giridih, Pin- 815302
GSTIN No.- 20AADCJ3148ADZ1, E-mail ID- gm.giridih@jbvnvl.co.in

Very Short e-Tender Notice
e-Procurement for Electrical Line Materials For AIIMS, Deoghar under ADP Head for F.Y. 2026-27.
Online tenders are invited from reputed manufacturers having adequate manufacturing capability & testing facilities or authorized dealers who are financially sound & from reputed & experienced suppliers for supply of the relevant materials conforming to standard specifications for the supply of Electrical Line Materials for AIIMS, Deoghar under ADP Head for F.Y. 2026-27.
All online tenders should be submitted online on www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Group NIT	Sl. No.	Particular of Materials	Unit	Total Quantity	EMD	Cost of BoQ With GST (Non-Refundable)
1.	165/PR/J BVNL/ 2026-27	1	33 KV 3-core XLPE UG Cable Heat Shrinkable Straight Through Jointing Kit Suitable For 400 Sqmm.	Set	18	78,000/-	5,000/-+ 18% GST= 5,900/-
		2	33 KV 3-core XLPE UG Cable Heat Shrinkable Outdoor Type Cable Termination Kit Suitable For 400 Sqmm.	Set	30		
		3	HDPE Pipe - 160mm/6" PE 63 Grade	Mtr	4200		
		4	GI Pipe 6" Medium Duty (B Class)	Mtr	156		

IMPORTANT SCHEDULE OF DATES FOR ABOVE NIT'S

1	Availability of tender document on website	-	From:- 22.06.2026 to 29.06.2026 up to 18.00 Hrs.
2	Date and time for submitting e-tender	-	From:- 22.06.2026 to 29.06.2026 up to 18.00 Hrs.
3	Last date and time of receipt of bid documents (Online)	-	29.06.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs.
4	Date and time of opening of tender i.e. Cover-I	-	01.07.2026 at 14:00 Hrs.

1- Guidelines for online submission of bids can be downloaded from the website <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>
2- Interested bidders can download the bid from the website <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>
3- Bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic form with digital Signature. Bids without digital signature will not be accepted. No proposal (bid) will be accepted in physical form.
4- Bidders must ensure that scanned copies of all necessary documents including copies of online transaction against cost of BOQ & EMD have been attached with bid.
5- Bidders have to upload the online transaction slip or SSI/NSIC registration certificate towards Tender Fee & EMD as mentioned in NIT on or before the cutoff date and time as mentioned in the NIT failing which bid will not be accepted. The details of cost of documents, EMD specified in the tender documents should be the same as submitted online (scanned copies of online transaction slip) otherwise tender will summarily be rejected.
6- 1. Tender Notice is also available on our website: www.jbvnvl.in
7- 2. For any clarification please contact: 75429-73449/ 82501-58600.
सहित एवं राष्ट्रहित में ऊर्जा बचाव। कृपया अपनी शिकायत को 18003456570(कॉल सेंटर) पर दर्ज करायें।
PR 382765 Jharkhand Biljee Vitran Nigam Ltd (26-27)/#D



AAVAS FINANCIERS LIMITED
(CIN:L65922RJ2011PLC034297) Regd. & Corp. Office: 201-202, 2nd Floor, South End Square, Mansarovar Industrial Area, Jaipur. 302020

POSSESSION NOTICE
Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorised Officer of AAVAS FINANCIERS LIMITED under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred upon me under section 13(12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a Demand Notice calling upon the borrowers mentioned herein below to repay the amount mentioned in the respective notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers having failed to repay the amount, undersigned has taken possession of the properties described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said rules on the dates mentioned herein below. The borrower and Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the AAVAS FINANCIERS LIMITED for an amount mentioned as below and further interest thereon.

Name of the Borrower	Date & Amount of Demand Notice	Description of Property	Date & Type of Possession
Prem Singh, Gudiya Yadav (A/C No.) 201220001505325 & 241220004598514	8 Apr 26 Rs. 581401/- & Rs. 938458/- 7 Apr 26	House No. 115/c/P-49, Plot No. 49, Shyam Colony, Kh No. 1233, Wahi No. 1, Gadi Jeevanram, Mouja Narach, The Ettmadpur, Agra Uttar Pradesh (In)- 282006 / Admeasuring 110 Sq Yard (91.96 Sq. Mtr.)	Symbolic Possession Taken On 15 Jun 26
Rekha Sharma, Sunil Sharma (A/C No.) 201224601623665	8 Apr 26 Rs. 1297997/- 7 Apr 26	Property No. 1- Plot No. 28, Khasha No. 150, Baba Dehara Puram Mauza Mohomadpur, Agra, Up. Property No. 2- Shop No 2 & 3, Moza Kalwari, Khasha No 59, Vankay Tulsi Villa Shahaganj, Agra Uttar Pradesh (India)- 282010 / Admeasuring Property No. 1- 100 Sq Yard & Property No. 2- 34.34 Sq Mtr	Symbolic Possession Taken On 15 Jun 26
Gajendra Kumar, Pinki Rani, Manoj Kumar, Pooja Pooja, Dimpal Sagar (A/C No.) 241220104547779	8 Apr 26 Rs. 714723/- 7 Apr 26	Gata No 266, Rakba 0.474h , Mohalla Shastri Nagar, Amroha, Uttar Pradesh (In)- 244221 Admeasuring 105. 28 Sq. Mtr.	Symbolic Possession Taken On 15 Jun 26

Place : Uttar Pradesh Date:

